

BRAIDING EDUCATION, WORKFORCE, AND COMMUNITY: DESIGNING COHESIVE LEARNING SYSTEMS FOR DEMOCRACY AND MOBILITY

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DEDICATION

For the young people whose insight, courage, and determination shape this work. For the communities striving to build education and employment systems that offer opportunity, belonging, and mobility.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

This dissertation reflects the labor, wisdom, encouragement, and belief of many people across many chapters of my life. Although a single author's name appears on the title page, this work is fundamentally collective—shaped by relationships, shared purpose, and the conviction that communities can build systems worthy of their young people.

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demonstrated—through practice—how strategy, trust, and shared accountability can meaningfully coexist.

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and for naming what becomes possible when adults are willing to listen. This work is for you, and because of you.

ABSTRACT

This dissertation examines how education-to-employment systems shape economic mobility and civic participation, and how communities can redesign those systems to better align opportunity, contribution, and institutional trust. Grounded in youth voice and lived experience, particularly youth furthest from opportunity, this integrated research-practice dissertation examines how fragmented learning and labor-market pathways are experienced and how intermediary infrastructure converts fragmentation into coherent systems that support shared prosperity and democratic capacity.

Drawing on IRB-approved qualitative research and embedded practitioner inquiry, the dissertation addresses three gaps in existing scholarship. Workforce development research rarely engages civic theory or democratic outcomes; civic education scholarship seldom examines labor markets or intermediary infrastructure; and systems-design literature rarely treats young people as analytic partners in diagnosing institutional failure. By linking these domains, this dissertation advances scholarship on political economy, labor markets, civic formation, and institutional design within an undertheorized civic-economic space.

Based on interviews, focus groups, surveys, and practice-based artifacts across traditional, alternative, and civic education contexts, findings show youth articulate a consistent “both-and” theory of thriving. They seek economic mobility and meaningful contribution, autonomy and institutional reliability, and self-sufficiency alongside community connection. Youth interpret misaligned systems not as benign complexity but as institutional incoherence undermining dignity, predictability, and civic confidence. When learning and work systems fail to align, youth lose not only access to opportunity, but trust in public institutions.

In response, the dissertation advances the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) as a central theoretical and applied contribution. HQIF conceptualizes intermediaries as civic-economic infrastructure defined by governance, relational, operational, and sensemaking capacities that align education, workforce, and civic systems at regional scale. Youth contributions function as system intelligence, positioning youth as co-theorists whose insights strengthen coherence, legitimacy, and effectiveness.

Grounded in Indiana as an active site of policy and intermediary experimentation, the research examines how HQIF-aligned intermediary infrastructure can be adapted across regions and states, and argues that economic mobility and democratic renewal are mutually reinforcing aims. When education-to-employment systems are coherently designed, they can expand opportunity, stabilize institutional trust, and renew the civic foundations on which shared prosperity and well-being depend.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

CPA	Critical Policy Analysis
CTE	Career and Technical Education
DOL	U.S. Department of Labor
DWD	Indiana Department of Workforce Development
EPIC	Employer Provided Innovation Challenges
ESC	Education Service Center

HCE	Healing-Centered Engagement
HQIF	High-Quality Intermediary Framework
ICAD	International Center for the Apprenticeship Degree
IDOE	Indiana Department of Education
IHE	Institution of Higher Education
INCAP	Indiana Career Apprenticeship Pathway
IRB	Institutional Review Board
JFF	Jobs for the Future
LPN	Licensed Practical Nurse
MSC	Multi-Sector Collaborative
MOU	Memorandum of Understanding
NCAD	National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree
NGSIG	Next Generation School Improvement Grant
OECD	Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development
PAYA	Partnership to Advance Youth Apprenticeship
PK-20	Prekindergarten through Postsecondary Education
RAZ-32	Rural Alliance Zone 32
RN	Registered Nurse
SIG	School Improvement Grant
STEM	Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics
TPM	Talent Pipeline Management
WBL	Work-Based Learning

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BRAIDING EDUCATION, WORKFORCE, AND COMMUNITY: DESIGNING COHESIVE LEARNING SYSTEMS FOR DEMOCRACY AND MOBILITY

Introduction

This dissertation advances three core contributions. First, it offers a theoretical reframing of intermediaries—organizations that work to link education and employment systems in some way, often through work-based learning, workforce, or talent-development programs across a wide range of

institutional forms—as civic-economic institutions central to regional mobility and democratic life. Second, it advances a methodological approach that treats young people as co-theorists, whose analyses inform institutional critique and system design. Third, it introduces an applied framework—the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF)—that translates research findings into replicable strategies for building coherent education-to-employment systems. Collectively, these contributions illuminate how aligned learning and workforce systems can strengthen both opportunity structures and civic capacity.

The findings carry implications for theory, policy, and practice. They suggest that durable progress requires attention not only to technical alignment, but also to the norms of care, accountability, and collective responsibility that shape how systems function in practice. Building coherent civic-economic infrastructure is therefore both a public governance responsibility and a site of local collective agency: while states and institutions must establish enabling conditions, communities themselves play a decisive role in shaping how opportunity is organized, governed, and sustained. In this framing, collective efficacy is not ancillary to governance but central to it—expressed through shared decision-making, reciprocal accountability, and high-quality intermediary infrastructure that translates shared purpose into durable coordination and shared accountability. Through this infrastructure, communities are able to convert fragmentation into coherence and sustain economic mobility, institutional trust, and civic participation over time. Together, these dynamics are essential to sustaining mobility, belonging, and democratic resilience. Grounded in critical policy analysis and community-engaged inquiry, the research examines how education, workforce, and civic systems can be designed and governed to advance both economic mobility and democratic participation.

I write as a practitioner-scholar whose work spans rural and urban contexts and centers young people least well served by current systems. That vantage point shapes the animating question of this integrated research-practice dissertation: How can communities align education and employment in ways that cultivate civic participation and economic mobility for young people—and, in turn, strengthen regional resilience and growth? The analysis presented here contends that the answer lies not in isolated programs or single-sector reforms, but in coherent civic—economic infrastructure that makes shared opportunity possible.

The work proceeds from a foundational premise: systems are created, upheld, and changed by people. Policies, funding streams, and organizational charts matter, but they are enacted through human relationships—through the beliefs, incentives, fears, habits, and hopes that shape daily practice. For this reason, systems change requires relational change: the slow, rigorous work of building trust, shifting mindsets, and helping people see that collaboration is not a loss of autonomy, but a gain in collective capacity. In scarcity-driven contexts, leaders are often conditioned to defend institutional turf, compete for limited resources, or guard information. In the absence of intentional relational infrastructure, fragmentation becomes the default.

To counter these dynamics, the dissertation advances a set of facilitative practices—“we will / we will not” guardrails, consensus-based governance, and adaptable agreements—designed to reduce risk, create psychological safety, and clarify how partners can pursue shared aims without compromising their distinct missions. These practices emerged directly from the predictable hesitations of leaders asked to collaborate in systems that have historically rewarded competition. As Reverend Jennifer Bailey observes, “Relationships are built at the speed of trust, and social change happens at the speed of relationships.” In this spirit, the approach developed here seeks not to replace existing systems or build parallel ones, but to evolve them through relational stewardship—pairing kindness with accountability, flexibility with structure, and human dignity with rigorous shared strategy.

This dissertation also takes up a deeper civic question: What should public, private, and civic systems be expected to provide? American traditions diverge on this point. Some look to government to secure justice and opportunity; others entrust such aims to markets, local communities, or faith-based institutions. This dissertation argues that no single sector can fulfill those promises alone. Making opportunity real requires structured, transparent, and reciprocal collaboration across sectors.

At stake in this work is not only economic mobility, but the civic capacity of communities themselves. The United States has historically drawn strength from broad participation in public life—from the ability of ordinary people to shape local institutions, influence shared decisions, and pursue economic self-determination through collective action. Yet for many communities, particularly those facing persistent poverty, racialized and identity-based exclusion, and geographic marginalization, that civic inheritance has been eroded. As education and workforce systems have grown increasingly fragmented, technocratic, and difficult to navigate, individuals—especially those furthest from opportunity—have been distanced from both their economic futures and their sense of civic agency.

This erosion carries real consequences. Research demonstrates that economic insecurity and institutional mistrust reinforce one another, weakening social cohesion and deepening racial and political divisions. Conversely, when communities are able to build credible pathways to stable work and meaningful contribution, trust increases, bias declines, and democratic participation becomes more viable. This dissertation argues that rebuilding education-to-employment systems as coherent civic-economic infrastructure is therefore not merely a matter of workforce efficiency, but a strategy for restoring shared stake, mutual responsibility, and democratic resilience.

Throughout the chapters that follow, I examine how intermediary structures function as coherent civic—economic infrastructure when they are designed and governed in alignment with HQIF capacities. Regardless of name or form, the essential architecture is the same: durable cross-sector partnerships that braid people, policy, and practice toward shared outcomes. While the cases examined here are grounded in Indiana, the framework is intentionally specified to support application and comparative learning

across regions, states, and, where relevant, international contexts seeking to strengthen education-to-employment systems through intermediary infrastructure. In these settings, intermediaries reduce coordination costs, align incentives, and convert fragmented programs into coherent pathways that build civic and economic capacity for young people, employers, and communities alike. The research advances this argument across three stages:

- - Youth voice clarifies needs and system failure points (Chapters 2–3);
 - Collaborative structures respond with governance, standards, and shared measurement (Chapter 4); and
 - Praxis institutionalizes effective approaches through repeatable tools and routines (Chapter 5).

To increase transparency and support triangulation, the dissertation includes Appendix A, which contains selected artifacts referenced throughout the analysis. These materials document how theoretical frameworks are translated into governance structures, design decisions, and public-facing products across funded initiatives, youth leadership programs, convenings, and policy design efforts. Appendix A works to ground the analysis in concrete institutional practice rather than to serve as a prescriptive implementation guide.

The ultimate aim of this work is dual: to contribute to scholarship on learning infrastructure and to offer usable tools that help regional partners move from temporary projects to durable systems. When communities braid people, policy, and practice with intention, young people gain what they need to participate and prosper in ways that make economic security and civic contribution mutually reinforcing—and individuals, employers, and communities alike benefit.

Chapter 1: The Erosion of the American Promise—Fragmented Systems, Youth Insight, and the Case for Coherence

1.1 Reframing the American Promise: Education-to-Employment Systems in an Era of Civic and Economic Precarity

America is more than a nation—it is an idea, an aspiration. At its best, it promises that regardless of origin, talent and effort will be met with genuine opportunity. Yet from its founding, that promise has been unevenly upheld—expanded, challenged, and reimagined by generations who believed the country could become more than it was. The American Dream has often advanced not through institutions alone, but through the persistent labor of those pushed to the margins: Black freedom movements, immigrant rights advocates, Indigenous sovereignty movements, disability justice organizers, women’s suffrage leaders, labor unions, and youth-led movements for educational and economic justice. These actors have fought to make the Dream real not simply for themselves, but for all.

Alexis de Tocqueville observed in the 1830s that America’s distinct civic fabric rested not only in its formal institutions, but in its habits of the heart—a culture of voluntary association, local cooperation, and collective

problem-solving. That civic inheritance has never been automatic. It has required continual renewal, civic courage, and the difficult work of building across lines of race, class, geography, and ideology. This integrated research-practice dissertation asks: What would it take today—amid profound economic and civic precarity—to reconstitute that civic fabric in ways that advance both mobility and belonging? This chapter situates that question within a broader political-economic and civic context, while subsequent chapters develop the analytic, empirical, and design responses in depth.

This question is not abstract. It emerges from a present-day American reality marked by widening inequality, weakened labor protections, increased corporate concentration, and a political economy that increasingly offloads collective responsibility onto families, schools, and local institutions (Piketty, 2014; Hacker & Pierson, 2010; Brown, 2015; Saez & Zucman, 2019). Schools are asked to compensate for structural failures well beyond their control—often without the fiscal capacity, policy authority, or cross-sector coordination needed to do so. At the same time, public trust in institutions has frayed, and civic belonging has become fragile, particularly for young people navigating systems that often feel unreliable, opaque, or punitive.

The dissertation advances a core claim: the United States faces an intertwined erosion of economic mobility and civic trust—a dual crisis made visible in youth narratives and in the fragmentation of education-to-employment systems. From a capabilities perspective, the question is not only whether young people can access work, but whether systems expand real freedom for meaningful livelihood, participation, and flourishing (Nussbaum, 2011). When young people cannot see how schooling connects to stable work, dignified wages, purpose, and contribution, the result is not only economic inefficiency—it is civic corrosion.

Young people in this study consistently express a desire for learning that connects to livelihood and purpose. They do not reject education; they reject disconnection. They want systems that recognize the full context of their lives. For students experiencing poverty, time is a scarce resource. Poverty is not only a constraint; it is life-shortening (Rothstein, 2017; Ladson-Billings, 2006). Students need access to income now—not merely to stay enrolled, but to sustain life itself. Across focus groups, youth described the mismatch between what school demanded and what survival required. One participant named the dissonance plainly: “I’m trying to hold my family together and school doesn’t even know that’s happening” (Hall, 2021). Another described the hollowing-out of “preparation” when social capital is absent: “Nobody tells you how to get experience or where to start” (Hall, 2021). These are not complaints; they are structural critiques—young people identifying where institutional design diverges from lived reality.

When the brilliance of young people is constrained by systemic neglect, both democracy and the economy weaken. A society that fails to cultivate the potential of all its youth is not only unjust—it is unsustainable. As Taylor White (2024) testified before the U.S. Senate HELP Committee, “Economic mobility, long considered a hallmark of American society, has been declining

for decades.” The erosion of mobility is simultaneously a civic and economic crisis.

Research from Raj Chetty’s Opportunity Atlas reinforces this truth: where a child grows up profoundly shapes adult income and life expectancy. The data reveal stark geographic and racial disparities, showing that even excellent schools cannot offset inequitable local conditions. Opportunity, therefore, depends not only on pedagogy, but on the broader ecosystems in which learning occurs—environments shaped by housing, employment, health, transportation, social networks, and civic life. Education matters deeply, but it cannot carry the burden of mobility alone when the surrounding infrastructure of opportunity remains fragmented.

The answer, this dissertation argues, lies not in isolated programs or single-sector reforms, but in redesigned civic infrastructure for collective problem-solving—structures capable of aligning education, employment, and civic systems around shared responsibility and shared outcomes. Across the country, these structures appear in many forms: regional collaboratives, work-based learning hubs, pathways coalitions, rural alliances, and workforce intermediaries. What matters is not their name, but their design.

This integrated research-practice dissertation addresses three gaps in existing literature. First, workforce development research rarely engages civic theory or democratic outcomes. Second, civic education scholarship rarely examines labor markets or structural mobility. Third, systems-design literature rarely treats young people as analytic partners. By linking these domains—and by grounding analysis in both IRB-approved youth research alongside embedded practitioner inquiry—this integrated research-practice dissertation extends public affairs scholarship into a civic-economic domain that has remained undertheorized.

In response, the dissertation advances the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) as its central analytic and applied contribution. HQIF specifies the governance architecture, relational norms, operational capacity, and sensemaking routines required for intermediaries to function as durable civic-economic infrastructure rather than episodic partnerships. It clarifies the conditions under which collaborative efforts can move beyond goodwill to shared accountability—and beyond fragmented initiatives to coherent systems.

At stake is not merely the efficiency of workforce pipelines. It is the credibility of public life itself. Youth in this study repeatedly linked disengagement from school to broader political alienation: “If the school doesn’t listen, why would the government?” (Hall, 2021). Their reflections point to a legitimacy problem: when institutions fail to deliver reliability, dignity, or responsiveness, people withdraw—not only economically, but civically.

The thesis of this chapter is therefore both pragmatic and moral: repairing the link between education, economic mobility, and democratic belonging requires redesigned governance—structures that braid people, policy, and practice around shared goals and shared accountability. These structures must also respond to a persistent critique of work-based learning and

apprenticeship—that they reduce education to narrow job training. This dissertation rejects that strawman. When designed well, pathways are not anti-humanistic; they are sites where young people can become community members, civic actors, organizers, and whole people with agency and voice—but only if the systems that govern pathways are intentionally designed to protect dignity, expand opportunity, and distribute power fairly.

Table 1.1 contrasts the dominant features of fragmented education-to-employment systems with the characteristics of coherent systems capable of supporting both economic mobility and democratic belonging.

Table 1.1 Fragmentation vs. Coherence in Education-to-Employment Systems

Dimension	Fragmented systems (status quo)	Coherent systems (HQIF-aligned)
Goals	Each sector optimizes its own metrics	Shared outcomes spanning education, work, and civic contribution
Governance	Informal relationships; ad hoc coordination	Formal agreements, shared decision-making routines, distributed authority
Access	Opportunity depends on luck, proximity, social capital	Predictable access to advising, paid experiences, credentials, and networks
Funding	Siloed grants and short-term pilots	Braided finance with sustained backbone capacity and clear value proposition
Accountability	Compliance-focused; blame shifts across institutions	Shared measures; continuous improvement; transparent tradeoffs
Youth role	“Beneficiaries” or “participants”	Analytic partners and co-designers (guardrailed power-sharing)
Civic outcomes	Trust erodes; institutions feel extractive	Trust can rebuild; institutions feel reciprocal and responsive
Economic outcomes	Talent shortages persist; underemployment grows	Regions align training to demand; wages, retention, and mobility improve

1.2 Analytic Lenses for Diagnosing Fragmentation and Specifying Intermediary Quality: CPA, HCE, Collaborative Governance, and Political Economy

This integrated research-practice dissertation is grounded in four interlocking analytical lenses—Critical Policy Analysis, Healing-Centered Engagement, collaborative governance, and political economy—that together enable the work to move from critique to construction. Individually, each framework offers insight into how education-to-employment systems reproduce inequality, alienation, or fragmentation. Taken together, they provide a coherent way to diagnose institutional failure, interpret youth insight as civic intelligence, and specify the governance conditions required for durable and legitimate system redesign. Throughout the dissertation, practitioner evidence is not treated as confirmation of theory, but as a site of interrogation, refinement, and stress-testing alongside youth analysis and policy critique.

These frameworks reflect the dual vantage point of this integrated research-practice dissertation. Over multiple years of intermediary and system-design work across Indiana, as well as engagement with national youth apprenticeship and pathways networks, I have observed how policy logic, organizational incentives, and relational conditions interact in real time. The theoretical commitments articulated here are therefore drawn not only from academic literature, but from applied system-building work, evaluation cycles, and collaborative design processes that inform the analyses in later chapters. Together, they support the dissertation's central claim: fragmented education-to-employment systems are not failing because of insufficient effort or isolated program gaps, but because they lack coherent civic-economic architecture capable of aligning learning, livelihood, and belonging.

Critical Policy Analysis (CPA) provides the foundation for interrogating power, ideology, and inequity embedded in education and workforce policy. CPA attends to the sociopolitical contexts in which policy is produced and enacted, asking core analytic questions that guide this dissertation's inquiry: Whose interests does a policy serve, and whose are marginalized? How do race, class, and geography shape the distribution of opportunity? Where do young people's lived experiences affirm, complicate, or contest official policy narratives? These questions position policy not as a neutral technical instrument, but as a set of governing choices that distribute risk, responsibility, and possibility unevenly (Horsford, Scott, & Anderson, 2019; Welton & Cumings Mansfield, 2020).

In that spirit, this dissertation uses CPA to center young people furthest from opportunity—not only as those most affected by policy design, but as those most likely to surface the system's hidden assumptions and unequal consequences. This emphasis aligns with Welton and Cumings Mansfield's call to conjoin critical policy analysis with community-engaged political action: CPA is strongest when it does not stop at critique, but strengthens the conditions through which communities can act on what the critique reveals (Welton & Cumings Mansfield, 2020). Accordingly, the youth focus groups and civic artifacts analyzed in this study are treated as policy-relevant evidence—grounding CPA's core questions in lived experience across alternative education (VOICES), school-based pathways contexts (Victory College Prep), and formally civic-facing youth governance spaces (the City-County Council Youth Commission and the Statewide Youth Policy

Fellows). In practical terms, youth analysis functions here as a diagnostic input into system redesign—informing the intermediary capacities and governance architecture later specified through HQIF.

Within this dissertation, CPA is used both descriptively and normatively. Descriptively, it surfaces how policies related to attendance, work permits, graduation pathways, accountability metrics, and credential signaling generate disparate impacts for youth navigating economic precarity. Normatively, it treats youth narratives as analytic knowledge—signals about where systems are misaligned and where redesign is required. CPA insists that policy is not only what is written into statute, but what is enacted through institutions and experienced by people living under unequal conditions of trust, harm, and opportunity. As articulated in my qualifying exam, CPA represents “a methodological and ideological commitment to interrogating how educational policies reflect and reproduce racialized, gendered, and classed power structures,” while recognizing that policy outcomes are shaped by how rules interact with lived reality (Hall, 2022).

This perspective is especially salient in education-to-employment systems, where policy design often encodes middle-class assumptions—stable housing, predictable schedules, reliable transportation—that diverge sharply from the conditions youth describe. CPA reframes these mismatches not as individual failure, but as structural negligence. Youth critiques of attendance rules, work-permit barriers, or discipline systems are therefore interpreted as civic diagnostics: evidence of where institutional design fails to account for the realities of contemporary life.

CPA also requires attention to the broader political-economic context in which policy operates. Contemporary education and workforce systems are embedded in an era of hyper-financialized capitalism, where profits have increasingly decoupled from wages, economic risk has shifted onto families, and public institutions are asked to compensate for market volatility without commensurate authority or investment (Brown, 2015; Hacker & Pierson, 2010; Piketty, 2014). In such contexts, policy frequently individualizes responsibility for survival while obscuring structural causes. This dissertation treats these macro-level dynamics as inseparable from the micro-level experiences youth narrate, linking political economy directly to questions of civic legitimacy and institutional trust.

Healing-Centered Engagement (HCE) complements CPA by addressing a limitation of critique alone: diagnosing harm without specifying what repair, legitimacy, and durability require. As articulated by Ginwright (2018), HCE shifts attention from individual pathology to collective conditions, asking not “What’s wrong with you?” but “What has happened to us—and how can we heal together?” Relatedly, Duncan-Andrade (2009) argues, justice-oriented educational work requires a form of critical hope—one that acknowledges structural constraint, refuses false optimism, and insists on collective responsibility rather than individual perseverance alone. In this dissertation, HCE is not deployed as a therapeutic framework, but as a theory of institutional legitimacy under conditions of distrust. It provides analytic language for understanding why policies fail to take hold when they do not

cultivate dignity, belonging, and reciprocal trust—conditions that are prerequisites for durable governance.

HCE reframes young people not as broken or deficient, but as whole and capable actors whose critiques represent acts of care rather than disengagement. Youth insistence on relevance, honesty, and opportunity is interpreted as civic engagement: evidence that young people still believe institutions should function better and are willing to articulate what legitimacy would require. In practitioner learning from organizations such as VOICES, youth described thriving when institutions treated them as knowledge-holders rather than problems to be managed. Statements from VOICES Executive Direct, Kia Wright, such as “all of our programming comes from our youth” function here not as sentiment, but as governance claims—assertions that youth voice constitutes design intelligence essential to system coherence and trustworthiness.

Together, CPA and HCE allow this dissertation to address both structure and legitimacy. CPA exposes how policies reproduce inequity; HCE specifies the relational and cultural conditions required for repair. This pairing is essential in an era of institutional distrust, where technical fixes alone cannot restore confidence in public systems. By treating youth critique as both analytic evidence and moral guidance, the dissertation moves beyond deficit framings toward system redesign accountable to dignity, belonging, and democratic participation.

To translate critique into construction, the dissertation applies a systems lens grounded in collaborative governance and collective impact. These frameworks explain how complex, cross-sector challenges—such as aligning education, workforce, and civic systems—require coordinated action among schools, employers, postsecondary institutions, civic organizations, philanthropy, and government (Ansell & Gash, 2008; Kania & Kramer, 2011). Collaborative governance rests on a core civic insight: no single sector can secure opportunity alone. Durable solutions depend on shared agendas, mutually reinforcing activities, continuous learning, and structured trust-building supported by standing intermediary infrastructure.

However, this dissertation argues that the field’s common invocation of “intermediaries” remains undertheorized. Too often, intermediary work is described in terms of brokerage or convening without specifying the governance architecture, facilitation craft, and moral commitments that distinguish episodic collaboration from durable civic-economic infrastructure. This gap motivates the dissertation’s primary conceptual contribution: the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF). HQIF is not a new name for intermediaries, nor a single organizational model. It is a quality standard for intermediary practice that specifies the capacities required to make cross-sector collaboration durable: shared decision rights across partners, professionalized backbone functions, braided resource strategy, and routines that sustain transparency, trust, and accountability over time. In other words, the “intermediary” is the cross-sector civic-economic table; HQIF specifies what must be true for that table to govern effectively rather than convene episodically.

HQIF provides definitional clarity by specifying the institutional features, governance routines, relational competencies, and braided financing functions required for intermediaries to produce equitable mobility and civic renewal. It emphasizes not only formal structures—such as agreements, shared metrics, and backbone capacity—but also the skilled facilitation required to hold cross-sector tension, manage power asymmetries, sustain trust, and navigate conflict over time. Intermediary quality, in this framework, is not merely technical; it is civic. It reflects a community's capacity to govern shared systems collectively rather than outsource responsibility to individual institutions or heroic actors.

By contrast, this dissertation argues that high-functioning intermediaries are not simply program managers or conveners; they function as civic infrastructure. They anchor shared governance, lower coordination costs, and redistribute opportunity through institutional design—strengthening the relational and structural conditions required for economic mobility and democratic belonging. The intermediary forms examined across this dissertation—including multi- or cross-sector collaboratives, pathways hubs, and other regional partnership structures—vary in name and sponsorship, but each can be evaluated against the same institutional question: whether it operates as standing civic-economic infrastructure rather than episodic coordination. The High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) provides a codified synthesis of these findings, emerging from youth perspectives, empirical fieldwork, comparative research, and implementation evidence, and intended to guide the design, assessment, and scaling of intermediaries capable of advancing both economic mobility and civic renewal. In practical terms, HQIF specifies four interdependent capacities that signal intermediary maturity: shared governance with formalized decision rights; braided finance and durable backbone functions; transparent cross-institutional data and shared measurement; and structured civic participation that builds bridging and linking social capital, including youth voice.

Intermediaries in this dissertation are therefore understood not only as organizational brokers, but as civic institutions that shape how social capital is built, distributed, and sustained across lines of difference. Their design influences whether bridging and bonding social capital can emerge across lines of class, race, geography, and institutional power—and whether collective efficacy is strengthened or undermined in the process. By centering youth furthest from opportunity, particularly those navigating economic disenfranchisement and institutional exclusion, this dissertation treats intermediary quality as inseparable from questions of equity, trust, and shared civic responsibility. In this view, intermediaries do not merely connect systems; they help determine whether communities can practice collaboration, accountability, and mutual obligation in ways that expand opportunity rather than reproduce fragmentation.

These governance questions unfold within a broader political economy that shapes what collaboratives can realistically accomplish. The United States operates within a liberal market regime characterized by weak labor protections, fragmented welfare provision, and heavy reliance on local voluntarism (Esping-Andersen, 1990; Hall & Soskice, 2001). Education and

workforce systems are therefore routinely asked to compensate for structural inequality without commensurate authority or resources. This dissertation treats intermediaries as necessary but not sufficient responses: they can reconfigure local governance and distribute responsibility more fairly, but they operate within macro-level constraints shaped by tax policy, labor regulation, and corporate governance norms. These arrangements shape not only labor markets, but whether public institutions can function as public goods rather than residual safety nets.

Comparative insights from both the CEMETS Education Systems Reform Lab and the Inter/National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree (NCAD) further sharpen the dissertation's analysis of intermediary quality and system coherence. CEMETS' international research and design principles—particularly as translated through Indiana's iLab and related initiatives—highlight the importance of system-level coherence, employer coordination, and aligned governance. At the same time, this dissertation adopts a cautious stance toward the wholesale transfer of Swiss-informed models into the U.S. context, noting that coordinated apprenticeship systems abroad are undergirded by public investments and civic institutions largely absent in the United States. Comparative VET scholarship underscores that apprenticeship mechanisms depend on surrounding institutional architecture and social settlement, not training models alone (Rauner & Wittig, 2010).

NCAD offers a complementary comparative horizon by advancing degree-bearing apprenticeship models that integrate, rather than bypass, higher education. These models illuminate the governance and intermediary capacities required if pathways systems are to strengthen, rather than hollow out, higher education's civic role in the U.S. political economy. This dissertation does not treat these approaches as prescriptive or mutually exclusive. Instead, it uses their tension—employer coordination versus civic anchoring, market responsiveness versus public responsibility—as analytically productive. That tension becomes central to the development of HQIF, which specifies the conditions under which intermediaries can advance not only workforce outcomes, but democratic legitimacy and shared prosperity.

Taken together, these frameworks—Critical Policy Analysis, Healing-Centered Engagement, collaborative governance, and political economy—anchor the dissertation's analytic arc. They allow fragmentation to be diagnosed as a structural and political-economic condition, youth critique to be interpreted as civic intelligence, and governance architecture to be specified with precision. In doing so, they establish the foundation for the empirical analyses that follow and position High-Quality Intermediaries as a central mechanism through which education-to-employment systems can advance both economic mobility and democratic renewal.

1.3 Study Foundations: Braided Evidence, Researcher Positionality, and Youth Insight as Civic Intelligence

To understand how these forces take shape in the daily lives of young people, this dissertation draws on a braided evidence base that integrates

two intertwined streams: IRB-approved qualitative inquiry with youth and adult leaders, and longitudinal practice-based implementation evidence from regional system-design work. Together, these streams incorporate multiple source types—interviews and focus groups, practitioner documentation and field notes, policy analysis, and comparative field observations—allowing the analysis to examine education-to-employment systems from the inside out. A central methodological and philosophical commitment of this dissertation is that youth are not merely recipients of policy; they are interpreters of it. Young people experience fragmentation not as an abstract design flaw, but as a daily civic condition—encountering institutions that may be inconsistent, inaccessible, opaque, or punitive. Their critiques therefore function as what this chapter conceptualizes as civic intelligence: situated knowledge about institutional legitimacy, system coherence, and the conditions under which young people believe public life is reciprocal rather than extractive. Framed this way, youth civic intelligence is not only diagnostic; it is an input into collective efficacy—communities’ shared belief that they can organize, govern, and improve the conditions that shape opportunity. Youth participants framed this stance as both methodological and civic: “Go to where the youth are struggling.” Another challenged deferment narratives of citizenship: “The saying that ‘youth are the future’ always confused me... Why can’t the youth start making impact now?” A third made the bridge from critique to capacity explicit: “I have been wanting to make change for so long, but I didn’t know how... [youth] are very capable and, if we’re not capable, we can become capable.” Across research and data inputs to this dissertation, youth co-theorizing and emerging co-advocacy function as design inputs for building stronger civic-economic systems—systems capable of delivering the “both-and” conditions of thriving (mobility and meaning, stability and voice) that young people consistently articulate.

In the IU Indianapolis work-learn-earn study (IRB #12795), youth independently named the same structural pattern across sites and contexts. School expectations often presume forms of stability that many young people do not possess; system rules are frequently disconnected from survival; and the pathway from school to livelihood is too often obscured behind social capital. Many institutional expectations presume forms of stability, time availability, and navigational support that are unevenly distributed across families and social classes (Lareau, 2011). Youth did not simply express disengagement or a lack of motivation. Rather, they articulated a diagnosis: the system itself is misaligned. Read through a policy lens, this is not complaint but critique.

This stance aligns with Critical Policy Analysis (CPA), which insists that policy is not only written but lived, and that those most affected by policy hold interpretive authority over its consequences. It also aligns with Healing-Centered Engagement (HCE), which frames youth critique as an act of care—evidence that young people still believe institutions can and should do better. As one participant explained, “We know what would help—we just need adults to listen long enough to build it with us” (Hall, 2021). In this dissertation, youth voice is therefore treated not as illustrative color but as analytic signal—revealing where systems break down and what conditions would be required for trust, dignity, and opportunity to be restored.

Consistent with traditions of Youth Participatory Action Research, this study treats young people not as subjects of inquiry but as knowledge producers whose analyses, artifacts, and interpretations inform institutional critique and system design (Curnow et al., 2018).

The problem of fragmentation examined here is structural rather than accidental. Fragmentation is not simply the result of poor coordination or individual failure; it emerges predictably from sector-specific incentives that operate in isolation. Schools are held accountable for graduation rates and test performance. Colleges are incentivized to maximize enrollment and persistence. Employers are driven by production and profit. Public agencies prioritize compliance and eligibility. When metrics, funding streams, and accountability structures remain siloed, responsibility is easily displaced. When employers cannot find talent, schools are blamed. When students cannot secure income, families are blamed. When youth disengage, youth themselves are blamed. CPA reframes these outcomes as evidence of policy misalignment: institutions are often doing exactly what they were designed to do, even when those functions undermine equity, mobility, and civic trust.

This dissertation further argues that fragmentation is a political-economic artifact. It reflects an institutional architecture that diffuses responsibility across thousands of districts, employers, agencies, and local jurisdictions, while asking local actors to solve structural problems—labor-market volatility, wage stagnation, healthcare access, housing instability—without structural tools. In such a system, coherence becomes no one's formal responsibility, even as young people bear the cumulative burden of navigating its gaps.

To interrogate these dynamics, the dissertation draws on four interdependent sources of evidence: IRB-approved youth focus groups and adult interviews; practice-based documentation and field notes generated through my embedded role in designing and stewarding collaboratives from 2022 to the present; policy analysis at state and regional levels; and field observations and comparative frameworks drawn from national youth apprenticeship and pathways networks. Together, these sources make it possible to examine how coherence is built—or fails to be built—how trust is institutionalized, and how governance can shift from goodwill to durable structure.

This analytic vantage point is shaped by my practitioner role in facilitating the design and implementation of the Rural Alliance Zone 32 (RAZ-32), the Elkhart County Work-Based Learning (WBL) Hub, and the Whitley County Career and Technical Education (CTE) Collaborative. That embedded role enabled longitudinal observation, system-level insight, and iterative documentation—forms of practice-based evidence common in implementation science and essential for understanding how collaborative governance functions over time.

I enter this work as a white woman whose life has been shaped by movement across diverse geographies, communities, and systems—each revealing different dimensions of power, belonging, and opportunity. I was born in Pike Township on the northwest side of Indianapolis and later came

of age in Carmel—an early contrast that sharpened my attention to how geography and policy shape lived opportunity. My family roots extend into Appalachian Tennessee and the blue-collar West Side of Cincinnati, traditions that instilled deep respect for working-class ingenuity and community responsibility. Formatively, a Catholic social justice ethic influenced my commitments to dignity and solidarity, even as my adult commitments have evolved over time. Professional experiences in New York, Baltimore, and Washington, D.C. deepened my understanding of multiracial civic organizing and the relational labor required to change systems.

Across Indiana, my work has required serving as a cultural broker across divides of race, class, geography, and political ideology. That experience reinforces a central claim of this dissertation: systems are not distant abstractions; they are lived arrangements shaped by beliefs, habits, fears, aspirations, and histories.

My analysis is grounded in three commitments: (1) relational trust as infrastructure; (2) youth cultural knowledge as expertise; and (3) shared power as both method and outcome.

- ◦ **Relational trust as infrastructure.**
Following Rev. Jennifer Bailey’s insight that “relationships are built at the speed of trust, and social change happens at the speed of relationships,” I approach systems change as fundamentally relational work.
- **Youth cultural knowledge as expertise.**
Young people’s identities, lived realities, and cultural wisdom are not supplementary—they are essential sources of insight that expose system failures and illuminate redesign.
- **Shared power as both method and outcome.**
I recognize the privileges and blind spots that accompany my social location and work to counterbalance them by engaging youth and community partners as co-theorists.

1.4 Methods Overview: Sampling Logic, Procedures, Analysis, and Rigor

This integrated research-practice dissertation employs a qualitative, community-engaged design grounded in critical, participatory, and youth-centered methodological traditions. The study is situated within a transformative qualitative paradigm that treats young people—particularly those most impacted by educational, economic, and civic system failures—as legitimate analysts of institutional design, policy outcomes, and democratic participation. Rather than positioning youth voice as illustrative or anecdotal, the methodology treats youth critique as civic intelligence: situated knowledge capable of diagnosing institutional misalignment and informing governance redesign in the face of complex, or “wicked,” social problems that cannot be resolved through linear or single-sector solutions (Nguyen & Maxcy, 2018).

The sampling strategy is grounded in a clear axiological commitment: to treat youth experience as a legitimate source of civic and policy knowledge. Rather than seeking statistical representativeness, the sample is intentionally constructed to be diagnostically powerful—designed to

illuminate how system fragmentation is lived, interpreted, and navigated by young people situated in markedly different institutional, economic, and civic contexts. By engaging youth across contrasting relationships to schooling, work, and public systems, the study surfaces patterns that cut across individual circumstances and reveal underlying structural conditions. They are young people embedded in distinct institutional configurations—ranging from punitive accountability contexts to high-aspiration, college-preparatory environments—whose lived navigation of education, work, and civic systems reveals how fragmentation is produced and experienced. They are not representative individuals; they are diagnostically positioned analysts of system design. Thus, this dissertation does not claim population-level generalizability; rather, it leverages youth analysis as diagnostic evidence to illuminate institutional design logics and governance dynamics. As such, the analytic purpose of their participation is not to document individual outcomes, but to surface system logics, institutional assumptions, and governance failures as they are experienced from within.

The human-subjects youth data analyzed in this dissertation draw on four semi-structured youth focus groups, each conducted using consistent protocols and facilitation methods. These include: (1) youth participating in VOICES Day-Reporting, (2) students enrolled at Victory College Prep, (3) members of the City-County Council Youth Commission, and (4) Statewide Youth Policy Fellows. These sites were selected because they offered analytically powerful contrast in young people's relationships to schooling, work, and civic institutions, and because together they illuminate how fragmentation is experienced across punitive, aspirational, and formally civic-facing institutional contexts.

VOICES Day-Reporting is a community-based alternative education and accountability setting serving court-involved youth, many of whom are navigating multiple public systems simultaneously. This context provides insight into schooling and work under conditions where institutional reliability is most strained, surveillance is heightened, and the consequences of system failure are immediate. Victory College Prep is a high-expectations, college-preparatory public charter school serving historically marginalized students, with an explicit mission to prepare scholars for college, career, and life through academic rigor, character development, and civic responsibility. This context illuminates how aspiration, preparation, and institutional expectation interact when access to social capital, paid work experience, and navigational guidance remains uneven.

The City-County Council Youth Commission focus group captures youth formally invited into local governance structures, offering an “inside government” perspective on civic participation, legitimacy, and institutional trust. The Statewide Youth Policy Fellows focus group captures geographically diverse youth—many navigating multiple public systems—who are engaged in policy analysis, systems critique, and civic leadership development at the state level. Together, these four focus groups allow the study to examine how fragmentation operates across divergent institutional logics—punitive, aspirational, and civic—while revealing recurring breakdowns in coherence, responsibility, and trust.

In addition, the dissertation draws on youth analytic extensions emerging from Youth Poet Laureate work, which builds directly on the Statewide Youth Policy Fellowship model and long-term youth civic development relationships. These materials—including public-facing analyses, written reflections, and facilitated sensemaking—are not treated as separate focus group datasets but as longitudinal extensions that informed interpretive depth, particularly in later analytic chapters concerned with civic identity, voice, and belonging.

The study draws on multiple complementary data sources to illuminate distinct dimensions of system design and experience. Table 1.2 (Overview of Data Sources and Analytic Purpose) should be placed immediately following this paragraph to provide a consolidated view of participants, age ranges, duration, sampling logic, and analytic purpose across youth focus groups, adult interviews, and practice-based evidence. Adult interviews offer institutional vantage points from civic, education, and workforce leaders responsible for system design and governance. Practitioner field notes and implementation artifacts—including memoranda of understanding, shared-measurement drafts, governance routines, and pathway design documents—are treated as practice-based implementation evidence rather than human-subjects data. These materials document how intermediary structures are formed, negotiated, and sustained over time and are analyzed reflexively in relation to youth and adult findings. Table 1.2B (Practice-Based Implementation Evidence Across Regional Intermediaries) should appear directly after Table 1.2 to specify the scope, governance characteristics, and analytic role of this implementation evidence.

Youth data were collected through semi-structured focus groups conducted in private, partner-approved spaces (e.g., empty classrooms or meeting rooms) at each site. Focus groups lasted approximately 45–60 minutes (about one hour) and included approximately 5–15 participants per group, consistent with approved protocols. Sessions were audio recorded for transcription and analysis. Focus group protocols were designed to elicit youth perspectives on the perceived purpose of high school; what students believe they should know and be able to do after graduation; the values schools promote and should promote; awareness and experience of career-connected learning, work-based learning, and apprenticeships; paid work during high school (including hours, pay fairness, and tradeoffs between school and survival); and youth aspirations and definitions of “good work.” Facilitation emphasized collective sensemaking, inviting participants to respond to one another’s experiences, surface points of agreement or tension, and articulate shared interpretations of institutional design rather than isolated individual narratives.

All youth data collection followed approved Indiana University human-subjects protocols. Participation was voluntary, and participants were reminded that they could decline to answer any question and could withdraw at any time without penalty. Youth age 18 and older provided consent, and youth under 18 provided assent in accordance with approved procedures. No participants were compensated. Participants were informed of the limits of confidentiality inherent in focus group settings and were asked to respect one another’s privacy. Audio recordings and transcripts

were stored on secure, password-protected devices, and reporting uses de-identified quotations with identifying details removed or generalized to reduce re-identification risk. Throughout data collection and analysis, particular attention was paid to narrative justice, including avoiding deficit framings and representing participant meaning with fidelity.

Analysis followed an iterative qualitative process consistent with best practices in interpretive and participatory research (Saldaña, 2016). Youth focus group transcripts were analyzed through open coding to identify recurring concepts related to dignity, navigation, trust, economic pressure, civic identity, and institutional reliability, followed by focused coding to refine these concepts into analytic categories. Cross-case comparison was used to identify patterns that persisted across youth focus groups despite differing institutional positions and logics. Findings were triangulated with adult interview data and with reflexive analysis of practice-based implementation evidence to compare youth interpretations with institutional perspectives and real-time governance dynamics. Integrative memoing documented analytic decisions and traced how youth critiques informed the identification of intermediary capacities necessary for system coherence. This dissertation does not attempt a comprehensive comparative analysis across all identity groups. Instead, it uses identity-attentive scholarship to interpret how power and historical inequity shape trust, belonging, and cross-sector navigation. Future research should examine how specific identity intersections (race/ethnicity, immigration experience, disability, gender identity, rurality) mediate young people's experience of education-to-employment systems and the civic infrastructures that govern them.

Throughout analysis, structural forces—including racialized inequality, economic precarity, and political-economic constraints shaped by capitalism—were treated as contextual conditions shaping experience rather than attributes of individual participants. This analytic stance allows the study to surface how young people interpret institutional responsibility and legitimacy under unequal conditions, rather than reducing outcomes to individual choice or effort. The High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) emerged through this process as a synthesis rather than a pre-specified model, reflecting an iterative movement from lived experience to institutional diagnosis to applied system design.

To clarify the youth evidence base, across the study youth contributions enter the analysis through three complementary channels:

- (a) IRB-covered human-subjects data, including four semi-structured youth focus groups, adult interviews, and a supplemental survey administered to statewide youth fellows;
- (b) youth-authored civic products developed through structured programming (e.g., the Inside Out youth-led policy series, Youth Summit deliverables, and formal policy proposals), treated as consequential civic artifacts; and
- (c) longitudinal analytic extensions emerging from Youth Poet Laureate fellowship work that builds on the statewide youth fellowship model.

This structure ensures the dissertation treats youth not as illustrative respondents but as co-analysts and co-advocates, while maintaining methodological clarity about what constitutes human-subjects research versus practice-based documentation. These artifacts—including the Inside Out youth-led policy series, the YES Youth Fellows mental health and addiction policy pitch, and subsequent legislative action—are treated not as illustrative supplements but as consequential civic outputs, produced through structured youth–adult partnership and intermediary facilitation rather than episodic consultation.

Additionally, this dissertation treats youth-authored public commentary, policy proposals, and survey responses as analytically meaningful civic artifacts rather than ancillary program materials, enabling analysis of how youth interpretation is articulated, formalized, and communicated beyond facilitated settings. Blogs, policy documents, and survey instruments are understood as boundary objects—sites where youth interpretation meets institutional discourse. Together with focus group data, these materials allow the study to examine not only what young people say about systems, but how their analysis travels into public narrative, policy design, and governance. This multi-modal evidentiary approach aligns with a research–practice paradigm that understands civic learning as both interpretive and productive, and positions youth as co-theorists of system design rather than subjects of evaluation.

Table 1.2 Overview of Data Sources and Analytic Purpose

Table 1.2B Practice-Based Implementation Evidence Across Regional Intermediaries

*Note: These implementation evidence streams function as practice-based documentation rather than human-subjects data and are analyzed reflexively in relation to youth and adult findings.

Field notes capture sustained, practice-based implementation evidence across regions, including one-on-one and small-group meetings with intermediary staff, employer partners, education leaders, and civic collaborators; facilitation of cross-sector convenings; employer activation through Talent Pipeline Management (TPM) content, councils, and demand-alignment sessions; negotiation of memoranda of understanding and formal partnership agreements; development of training plans, pathway sequences, and work-based learning structures; documentation of role clarification and data-sharing processes; identification of implementation barriers such as transportation, staffing, scheduling, and compliance constraints; and ongoing sustainability planning related to funding braids, backbone capacity, and governance durability.

1.5 Why Indiana as a Living Laboratory for Building Coherence

Indiana is analytically valuable because it is a place where the tensions this dissertation names are actively playing out: evolving diploma expectations, workforce-region restructuring, expanding career-connected learning initiatives, and growing regional experiments in cross-sector coordination. Indiana is “in motion,” which makes it a natural test bed for observing how collaboratives translate state policy into local practice—and how fragmentation either multiplies administrative burden or is reduced through coherent intermediary infrastructure.

Indiana’s value as a living laboratory is further underscored by place-based research on economic mobility showing that children’s long-run outcomes vary substantially across neighborhoods, counties, and commuting zones—often sharply even within the same metropolitan area. The Opportunity Atlas (produced by Opportunity Insights in partnership with the U.S. Census Bureau) makes these geographic differences visible and policy-relevant by linking childhood neighborhood conditions to adult outcomes such as earnings and incarceration. This variation matters for the present study because it signals that opportunity structures, institutional access, and local labor-market conditions are not evenly distributed—exactly the conditions that regional intermediaries and collaboratives attempt to address. The counties anchoring the regional intermediaries examined in this dissertation—Elkhart County (Work-Based Learning Hub), Whitley County (CTE Collaborative), and the multi-district context of Rural Alliance Zone 32 (RAZ-32)—span distinct economic and social geographies, offering a lens for observing how governance, employer alignment, and pathway coherence intersect with local mobility conditions. Indianapolis and Marion County, home to VOICES and a critical urban context, add analytic contrast given the city’s larger labor market and demographic diversity. Together, these sites allow the dissertation to observe how fragmentation and coherence are produced through institutional design rather than assumed as fixed features of place.

Indiana also illustrates the national stakes. For example, statewide postsecondary attainment and completion goals—and the persistent gaps tied to geography and income—are central to whether regions can build family-sustaining pathways. Recent reporting from the Indiana Commission for Higher Education (2024) underscores both progress and persistent disparities in postsecondary attainment and completion across the state, with outcomes continuing to vary sharply by geography, income, and race—reinforcing the importance of regional systems capable of translating statewide goals into equitable local pathways.

Indiana also provides a grounded labor-market context for this dissertation's arguments about wages and work quality. Federal labor statistics show that in the Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metropolitan area—the primary labor market for many young Hoosiers—the average hourly wage in May 2024 was below the national average, with substantial variation across industries and occupational groups (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2025). These patterns shape the opportunity structure into which young people transition, reinforcing the significance of both wage quality and structural alignment in regional systems. Indiana's civic participation patterns likewise underscore the dissertation's claim that civic participation and institutional trust are intertwined with lived experience of opportunity: overall voter turnout in the 2024 general election was lower than in the 2020 presidential contest, with an estimated 61 percent of registered voters casting ballots—roughly 3 percent fewer than four years earlier, even as registration numbers grew (Indiana Business Research Center, 2025; Indiana Capital Chronicle, 2024). These trends illustrate how questions of economic opportunity and civic engagement co-occur within local political economies, reinforcing the analytic value of studying regional collaboratives as sites where both economic and civic inclusion are contested and constituted.

1.6 Dissertation Structure

Across chapters, this dissertation advances a single argument: youth critiques reveal interlocking relational, civic, and economic failures, and high-quality intermediaries function as a governance mechanism capable of repairing those failures. Chapter 1 establishes the study's conceptual foundations, evidence base, and methodological logic for treating youth critique as civic intelligence and intermediary design as a governance response. The analytic arc moves from youth voice (Chapters 2–3) to intermediary and system design (Chapters 4–5), to civic and political-economic analysis (Chapters 6–8), culminating in the articulation of the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) and accompanying tools that specify how intermediary capacities link to both mobility and civic outcomes.

The dissertation proceeds in eight chapters:

- ◦ Chapter 2 examines youth perspectives on schooling, work, belonging, and institutional reliability.
- Chapter 3 explores youth civic leadership as democratic practice and a ladder toward shared power.

- Chapter 4 theorizes intermediaries as civic infrastructure and details what “quality” must mean in collaborative design.
- Chapter 5 situates Indiana as a living laboratory and examines how regional collaboratives make state reforms implementable.
- Chapter 6 turns to civic and political-economic stakes—arguing that pathways systems are also democracy systems.
- Chapter 7 analyzes social capital as both crutch and catalyst and positions intermediaries as converters of private networks into public capacity.
- Chapter 8 consolidates implications and articulates the work ahead—framing coherent learning infrastructure as a civic-economic project.

Before the dissertation turns to governance design, it begins where repair must begin: with youth knowledge. Youth perspectives establish the diagnostic baseline for what coherence must accomplish and why—surfacing how fragmentation is lived as navigation burden, conditionality, and institutional unreliability. In response, the dissertation specifies HQIF-aligned intermediary governance as the architectural mechanism through which regions can convert fragmented initiatives into coherent pathways. Importantly, high-quality intermediary infrastructure is not a one-time “build”; it is an ongoing practice of shared governance, braided resourcing, and role clarity sustained across leadership turnover and shifting incentives. When communities do this well, both systems become more humane and more effective: schools expand meaningful learning-to-earning pathways, employers strengthen talent pipelines without extraction, and young people—especially those furthest from opportunity—experience greater dignity, mobility, and civic belonging. While grounded in Indiana’s living laboratory, the dissertation’s central claims and HQIF design tools are specified to support adaptation, comparative learning, and policy-relevant application across other regions and states seeking more coherent education-to-employment systems.

Chapter 2: Youth Perspectives on School, Work, and Survival—From Lived Experience to System Design

2.1 Survival, Schooling, and Economic Precarity

“If you’re starving, they still didn’t give you a work permit.”
-VOICES Day-Reporting student (white, urban Indianapolis)

This statement cuts through abstraction to reveal a central truth of contemporary American life: it is life-threatening to be poor in the United States—one of the wealthiest countries in the history of humanity. In a nation with vast aggregate wealth, poverty remains strongly associated with shortened life expectancy, chronic illness, food insecurity, housing instability, and elevated exposure to violence and environmental risk (Chetty et al., 2016; Woolf & Schoomaker, 2019; Rothstein, 2017). For many young people, school does not function as a bridge to opportunity but as a site where systemic neglect becomes visible.

Policies that tie access to lawful employment to attendance or grade point average may appear neutral; for students navigating housing instability,

caregiving responsibilities, or chronic economic scarcity, they communicate that survival is secondary to compliance. Research on adolescent employment consistently shows that youth labor participation is shaped by household economic insecurity, parental employment instability, and the need to contribute to family income—particularly among low-income households and households facing racialized labor-market disadvantage (Staff et al., 2010; Entwisle, Alexander, & Olson, 2005). In other words: when teenagers work, it is often not a matter of preference but of necessity.

The student's remark refers to Indiana's former youth work-permit policy, which required schools to approve or deny employment eligibility for minors. This is where a reader's "why didn't the school just sign it?" question matters. In practice, the students who most needed lawful work were often the least likely to receive approval—because the same poverty-driven instability that made work essential (missed days for caregiving, transportation breakdowns, crisis housing moves, court involvement, untreated anxiety) also produced the attendance, GPA, or disciplinary records used to justify denial. The gatekeeping function was not incidental; it was structural. It positioned educational institutions as arbiters of "worthiness" for work, frequently in ways disconnected from students' material realities. Youth-serving organizations, including VOICES, documented how schools' discretionary authority over work permits disproportionately harmed low-income and system-involved youth, especially when schools acted out of liability concerns rather than student need. Following advocacy by youth and community organizations, Indiana revised this policy in 2021—shifting responsibility for youth employment documentation from schools to employers through the state's Youth Employment System (YES) (Indiana Department of Labor, 2021).

Importantly, this policy shift aligns with a broader evidence base suggesting that paid work-based learning can strengthen—not weaken—young people's motivation and persistence when it is structured, safe, and connected to future opportunity (e.g., paid internships, apprenticeship-aligned placements). That is especially true for students from low-income backgrounds for whom earnings are not "extra," but stabilizing. Paid work can reduce the volatility that undermines attendance and engagement, and it can increase the perceived credibility of school by making learning-to-earning pathways tangible (Strada Education Network, 2021).

While Indiana's 2021 change reduced schools' formal control over work authorization, the student's account captures how education policy had previously functioned not merely as misaligned with economic necessity, but as actively obstructive to it. This example illustrates more than bureaucratic inconvenience. It exposes a deeper institutional logic in which education and employment systems are not only separated but, at times, positioned in tension with one another. Schools were empowered to restrict work participation based on assumptions that learning belongs exclusively in classrooms, that paid labor is a distraction rather than a site of skill development, and that economic need signals irresponsibility rather than structural constraint. Sociologists of education have long noted how such assumptions reproduce class bias by privileging middle-class norms of uninterrupted schooling while penalizing students whose lives require

economic contribution (Ladson-Billings, 2006; Alexander, Entwisle, & Olson, 2014).

These contradictions sit within the broader terrain of a financialized, hyper-capitalist political economy, in which families absorb increasing economic risk while the labor market offers fewer stable, well-compensated entry-level pathways (Harvey, 2007; Milberg & Winkler, 2013; Peck & Tickell, 2002). Wage stagnation, rising living costs, weakened labor protections, and the erosion of collective safety nets have shifted responsibility for survival onto households, even as institutions continue to demand uninterrupted compliance with educational norms that presume stability (Autor, 2022; Kalleberg, 2018). The students in this IRB-approved research are not simply navigating the limits of schooling; they are navigating the downstream effects of an economy that individualizes what are, in fact, structural failures.

Indiana-specific context sharpens the stakes of this contradiction. In the Indianapolis metro area, the minimum wage remains \$7.25/hour, while a living wage for a single adult with no children is estimated at \$21.54/hour—and rises sharply with children (MIT Living Wage Calculator, updated Feb. 10, 2025). When the distance between wages and basic needs becomes that wide, youth work is not a “character-building elective;” it becomes part of household survival strategy. In that context, policies that condition lawful work on school-based compliance can function less like “youth protection” and more like the state enforcing scarcity discipline on families already bearing disproportionate risk.

Students themselves name this economic rationality and the civic costs that follow. In one VOICES focus group, young people described the immediacy of economic responsibility and the way “school rules” can ignore it:

- ◦ “I’m not sure if a lot of y’all are in the same situation as me, but I feel like education is important. I wanna finish school, but I also gotta provide for me. I gotta provide for my family.”
- “That’s what we’re living for—jobs. Like, just to have money...”
- “It’s hard to, like... worry about all this, but also worry about your family situation...”

And, in direct reference to the work-permit gatekeeping dynamic:

- ◦ “I feel like school and work are two different things... Like, your attendance and your grades don’t define you... your behavior, none of that...”
(VOICES youth, focus group)

From a Healing-Centered Engagement perspective, youth critiques of these policies are not acts of defiance but strategies of sense-making and self-preservation (Ginwright, 2018). Young people are naming the impossible choices they are forced to manage: attend school and risk family hardship, or work to survive and risk institutional punishment. From a Critical Policy Analysis lens, these same critiques expose the moral work of policy—how rules determine whose needs are recognized as legitimate and whose are treated as deviations (Horsford, Scott, & Anderson, 2019; Welton & Cumings

Mansfield, 2020). Attendance requirements, work-permit rules, and accountability metrics encode assumptions about time, stability, and deservingness that systematically disadvantage students living under conditions of poverty.

This chapter positions youth voice as both diagnostic and design-oriented. Drawing on focus-group data from two contrasting sites—a traditional college-preparatory charter school (Victory College Prep) and an alternative education program serving system-involved youth (VOICES Day-Reporting)—it examines how students interpret the purpose of school, how economic and institutional context shapes those interpretations, and what young people believe education should provide. Several participants were also engaged in VOICES’ civic leadership initiatives, which shaped how they understood responsibility, governance, and public purpose. While those civic experiences are analyzed more fully in Chapter Three, they inform how students in this chapter articulate institutional legitimacy and failure.

What emerges from these accounts is not disengagement, but acuity. Students articulate the economic and civic conditions constraining their futures with precision. They are not asking to be absolved of responsibility; they are asking to exercise responsibility in ways that generate stability, dignity, and contribution under conditions of scarcity. Their insistence on relevance reflects a demand for reciprocity: if institutions ask effort of young people, they must offer credible pathways in return (Mehta & Fine, 2019; Dewey, 1916). And crucially, youth testimony underscores why the burden cannot rest solely on schools. The nation’s education crisis is not merely pedagogical but structural—a misalignment between what schools are incentivized to prioritize and what young people, families, and regional economies actually require. This misalignment cannot be resolved by asking more of individual teachers or schools that are already overextended (Rothstein, 2017; Love, 2019). Schools cannot—and should not—be expected to compensate for housing instability, food insecurity, labor-market precarity, and the erosion of civic infrastructure on their own (Alexander, 2010; Mazzucato, 2021).

In naming these contradictions, young people surface a deeper civic concern: when institutions wield authority without attending to lived reality, trust erodes. The denial of a work permit to a hungry student is not simply a policy failure; it is an erosion of institutional legitimacy. As scholars of democracy and civic life warn, sustained misalignment between institutional demands and lived experience corrodes collective efficacy and weakens democratic participation (Putnam, 2000; Sampson, 2012). Youth testimony here therefore provides both the empirical grounding and the moral urgency for the system-level redesign explored in later chapters, where governance structures capable of aligning education, employment, and civic life are examined.

2.2 The Purpose and Design of American High School

Since the early twentieth century, the American high school has rested on a dual promise: to cultivate democratic citizens and to prepare workers for an industrial economy. Yet, as Tyack and Cuban (1995) argue, the “grammar of

schooling” has remained remarkably rigid even as the civic and economic conditions surrounding schools have transformed. Over recent decades, federal and state accountability systems—from *A Nation at Risk* (National Commission on Excellence in Education, 1983) through the Every Student Succeeds Act (2015)—have reinforced a logic of measurable attainment (seat time, credits, standardized outcomes) that frequently privileges graduation and test performance over competence, purpose, applied learning, or civic connection (Labaree, 2010; Mehta & Fine, 2019).

This incentive structure reflects what Labaree (2010) describes as the public-private tension of American schooling: public education is rhetorically justified as a democratic equalizer, yet it is operationalized as a competitive marketplace for individual mobility. The result is a system optimized to signal attainment—credits earned, diplomas awarded—more reliably than it ensures meaningful capability, mobility, or civic agency. For students without access to social capital or brokerage, attainment signals that lack labor-market currency function less as opportunity and more as deferred risk. Under conditions of scarcity, this distinction is not academic; it is existential. In the focus groups underlying this chapter, youth repeatedly recognized that schools can demand compliance without delivering credible pathways in return.

The tension is particularly visible in Indiana, where headline measures of schooling progress can coexist with deeper fragility in economic security and postsecondary momentum. Indiana’s median household income is modest relative to the costs families face, and a meaningful share of Hoosiers live in poverty—conditions that shape youth decision-making long before “career readiness” becomes a formal policy concern (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024). At the same time, Indiana’s education-to-workforce discourse has been increasingly defined by concerns about talent shortages and the perceived misalignment between educational outputs and labor-market needs. The policy conversation therefore oscillates between two competing narratives: a humanistic view of education as democratic formation and a narrower economic view of education as pipeline production. Youth in this study, however, do not accept that as a binary. They want learning that leads to earning and learning that cultivates voice, belonging, and power.

This is precisely where contemporary critiques and attacks on higher education become analytically relevant. In public discourse, higher education is often evaluated as though its only legitimate purpose were immediate wage returns—an assumption that reduces learning to transactional “skills” and treats civic formation, identity development, and critical thought as expendable luxuries. Yet the youth voice in this chapter suggests something more complex: young people want education that “counts” in the labor market, but they also want education that equips them to interpret systems, navigate institutions, and contribute meaningfully to community life. In other words, the current “either/or” framing—either college as civic good or apprenticeship/work-based learning as economic good—misrepresents what youth are actually asking for. Their critiques instead imply a “both/and” demand: pathways that confer economic stability while strengthening civic agency.

Comparative contexts help clarify that this integration is not an impossible aspiration; it is a design choice. In many countries, vocational preparation is not positioned as the “non-academic” track and higher education is not positioned as the only credible pathway to dignity. Instead, systems are constructed to make learning and work mutually reinforcing through structured transitions, shared governance, and consistent expectations across institutions (OECD, 2023; Rauner & Wittig, 2010). What is often missed in U.S. policy borrowing is that the strength of such systems is not only the apprenticeship mechanism itself; it is the surrounding infrastructure and social settlement that makes the mechanism equitable and durable. Put differently: the visible work-based learning model sits atop a less visible foundation of public capacity, civic norms, and institutional arrangements that stabilize youth transitions.

International systems make visible what is often obscured in U.S. reform debates: education and employment are treated as interdependent public systems rather than parallel or sequential ones. In countries such as Switzerland, Germany, Singapore, New Zealand, Australia, and the United Kingdom, co-governed apprenticeship frameworks, national qualifications authorities, and sector councils align incentives across employers, schools, higher education, and government agencies—producing transitions that are predictable, navigable, and collectively stewarded (OECD, 2023; Rauner & Wittig, 2010; Tucker, 2019). As synthesized by Tucker (2019), high-functioning vocational education systems share a common feature: education–employment transitions are governed through coherent, institutionalized cross-sector coordination, rather than market signaling or individual navigation alone. In these systems, coordination is publicly authorized, durably funded, and designed to function at scale rather than through episodic or pilot-based interventions. In the Swiss case study, Schwartz and Hoffman (as cited in Tucker, 2019) document that apprenticeship success depends less on firm-level participation than on dense coordination among employers, vocational schools, intermediary bodies, and public authorities. Youth in this dissertation intuit the absence of such connective tissue not through policy language, but through lived experience—feeling the consequences of a system that demands performance without providing coherent passage.

Crucially, these systems are sustained not only by technical design, but by political-economic settlements that distribute responsibility broadly rather than individualizing risk. High-functioning apprenticeship ecosystems are typically nested within contexts characterized by progressive tax structures, strong labor protections, shared employer–worker governance, robust youth-transition supports, and institutional constraints on corporate excess (Busemeyer & Trampusch, 2012; Thelen, 2014). Transplanting apprenticeship mechanisms without these enabling conditions risks superficial mimicry rather than durable transformation—replicating form without function.

The misalignment in the United States is therefore not only structural, but cultural. An ethos of individualism fuels innovation and upward striving, yet it also undermines collective responsibility for transition, care, and belonging. High schools are caught between competing imperatives:

preparing students to compete and preparing them to contribute. Too often, the system resolves this tension by sorting rather than strengthening—signaling merit without securing capability. Youth in this study name this contradiction directly, experiencing opportunity as a private gamble rather than a shared civic commitment. The work of high-quality intermediaries, developed later in this dissertation, begins to reconcile this divide by treating learning, work, and contribution as a collectively governed public enterprise rather than an individualized race.

This dissertation's comparative lens is informed by sustained engagement with international and national apprenticeship system-building efforts, including participation in the CEMETS Education Systems Reform Lab in Switzerland and multiple convenings within the Inter/National Center for the Apprenticeship Degrees (I/NCAD) ecosystem. These experiences illuminate how education-to-employment systems can be structured to integrate applied learning with broad educational formation, rather than positioning work-based learning and higher education as competing or mutually exclusive pathways. In particular, the degree-apprenticeship model advanced through NCAD offers a productive “middle way” for U.S. contexts: it braids employer-based learning with postsecondary credentials, treating colleges and universities not as institutions to be bypassed, but as essential partners in building durable mobility. This approach stands in contrast to reductive portrayals of apprenticeships as narrowly instrumental or as mechanisms for producing compliant labor. When designed well, apprenticeship degrees expand workers' knowledge, bargaining power, and long-term civic-economic agency precisely because they integrate applied skill development with sustained academic learning and institutional support.

This comparative lens is especially clarifying in Indiana, a state whose political economy has long emphasized being “business friendly” and whose policy posture has often framed labor protections and union power as impediments rather than civic infrastructure. In such contexts, it is tempting to invoke Switzerland as a pro-business model that simply “asks employers to chip in.” But that reading understates the extent to which high-functioning apprenticeship systems depend on robust public capacity, shared governance, and long-term institutional trust. Even fiscal comparisons—often used to suggest that Switzerland operates with “smaller government”—can obscure the lived reality of public scaffolding and social insurance that stabilize youth transitions across education, workforce, and civic systems. Switzerland's overall government spending and debt profile differs from many peers, but such macro indicators alone do not capture how coordinated institutions, norms, and expectations collectively reduce risk and support mobility (Dixon, 2023).

For the purposes of this dissertation, the point is not to romanticize any international system or propose superficial mimicry. It is to clarify what is structurally missing in the American context: coherent infrastructure—shared governance, consistent pathways, and durable intermediary capacity—that can align education, higher education, employers, and community institutions toward both economic mobility and civic renewal. This is why the dissertation's core contribution is not a particular collaborative site or

“model,” but an overarching High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF): a way of specifying the governance features, facilitation practices, and accountability mechanisms required for collaboratives to produce real mobility and real civic capacity, not just good intentions.

Youth themselves anticipate this argument. A VOICES Day-Reporting participant described the stakes of the high school bargain with disarming clarity: “High school is a scam; college is where it’s at. That’s where you’re going to learn how to get your money; we don’t learn nothing [in high school, we] just get in trouble” (Hall, 2021). Another youth, reflecting on stratification, noted: “I’m a 21st Century Scholar and I saw a lot of the class divide...” (Hall, 2021). These statements do not read as anti-learning. They read as an indictment of a system that sorts opportunity and misrecognizes where learning actually happens.

2.3 Urgency, Distrust, and Economic Survival

Students at VOICES and Victory describe vastly different educational environments, yet across both sites they share an acute awareness of systems that fail to deliver on their promises. Their words expose what might be called the hidden curriculum of scarcity: work to survive, navigate bureaucracy, and learn to distrust institutions that have seldom proven reciprocal.

At VOICES, economic urgency dominated discussion. Students repeatedly returned to the immediacy of paid work and family responsibility:

- - “That’s what we’re living for—jobs.”
 - “You have to provide for your family... some of our parents aren’t that fortunate to have that money.”
 - “They didn’t care about your home life. If you were starving, you still didn’t get a work permit.”

These statements reveal a grassroots economic rationality. Students understand opportunity cost, labor value, and institutional incentives with remarkable sophistication. When students leave school to earn income prematurely—or are blocked from doing so—they are not necessarily making “irrational” choices; they are acting rationally under constraint, responding to systems that do not account for the true costs they bear. Their reasoning mirrors what labor-market scholars observe: when precarity rises and wages do not keep pace with living costs, young people often prioritize immediate income over deferred returns that feel uncertain or inaccessible (Autor, 2022; Kalleberg, 2018). Students are naming the downstream effects of wage stagnation, weakened bargaining power, and frayed safety nets—conditions that render schooling, as currently structured, insufficient for survival.

As introduced in Chapter One, labor economists describe a related distinction between “low-road” and “high-road” employment systems: low-wage, low-stability jobs versus dignified work that offers wages, mobility, and voice (Appelbaum et al., 2014). Youth in this study intuitively recognize this difference. Their critique is not simply “we want jobs.” It is “we want

good work”—work that sustains dignity, supports families, and offers forward motion.

A Healing-Centered Engagement (HCE) frame suggests these narratives are not defiance; they are strategies of self-preservation and sense-making in contexts shaped by cumulative adversity (Ginwright, 2018). Poverty generates chronic stress and developmental burden, and institutional policies that punish absence while ignoring need can intensify harm rather than alleviate it (Evans & Kim, 2013; Ladson-Billings, 2006). Students explicitly described how absences were often produced by family obligations rather than apathy:

- - “Just because I’m missing school doesn’t mean I don’t need a job. I might be missing school because I need a job.”
 - “Sometimes I miss school because I have to watch my little brothers when my mom has to work early. They say it’s unexcused, but what am I supposed to do?”
 - “They tell us to ‘be responsible adults’ but then don’t let us work. That makes no sense.”

From a Critical Policy Analysis (CPA) lens, such accounts expose the moral work of policy: how rules determine whose needs are legible as legitimate and whose are treated as deviations (Horsford, Scott, & Anderson, 2019; Welton & Cumings Mansfield, 2020). Attendance requirements and accountability metrics encode assumptions about time, stability, and deservingness that systematically disadvantage students living under conditions of scarcity. Youth distrust, then, is not cynicism; it is pattern recognition. As Smith (2010) argues, distrust often emerges where institutions have historically failed to reciprocate. In that light, skepticism becomes a democratic demand for accountability—not a rejection of schooling, but a critique of its current design.

2.4 Identity, Interest, and Engagement

Across focus groups, students consistently linked motivation to whether learning felt connected to lived interests, responsibilities, and emerging identities. Engagement, in their experience, is less about compliance and more about meaningful application. “Interest equals engagement,” one student said simply. Another offered a concrete illustration: “I actually like learning, but not busy work. If you showed me how to wire a house, I’d pay attention.” A third added: “I wish they asked us what we’re into before making us fill out all these packets.”

These statements reinforce that young people are not rejecting rigor—they are rejecting irrelevance. They want learning that builds real skill, supports purposeful contribution, and connects to livelihoods. Yet their aspirations extend beyond the immediate conversion of skills into wages. Students repeatedly emphasized the desire to understand how the world works, how to help themselves, how to support their families, and how to navigate institutions with confidence. In this sense, youth are describing education as both economic preparation and civic capability—an argument consistent with Dewey’s claim that education is not merely preparation for life but life

itself: inquiry rooted in experience, oriented toward both personal growth and the public good (Dewey, 1916).

Students named dreams spanning trades, entrepreneurship, and community contribution: “I want to flip cars,” “start a fashion brand,” “help my community,” “be an HVAC technician.” But those ambitions were paired with sober recognition of structural constraints: “It’s easy to get a job but not a good job.” “Minimum wage is not enough to sustain yourself.” “Fast food is also labor, but they don’t treat it like it.” These themes also align with the SCARF (Status, Certainty, Autonomy, Relatedness, and Fairness) framework (Rock, 2008): youth want autonomy over pathways, certainty about prospects, relatedness with caring adults, status through meaningful contribution, and fairness in opportunity. In fragmented systems, each of these drivers is threatened—pushing young people into survival logics rather than flourishing.

As I wrote in my qualifying exam: “Young people engage in policy interpretation daily, often developing sophisticated critiques of systems that constrain their futures. To dismiss their insights as adolescent frustration is to misunderstand their analytic capacity” (Hall, 2022). The findings bear that out. Students’ economic reasoning about wages, opportunity cost, workplace treatment, and market precarity often exceeds what accountability systems capture or reward. Their insights reflect everyday political analysis grounded in the recognition that economic structures shape civic participation, autonomy, and the ability to live well.

Cumulatively, youth articulate a both-and theory of thriving. They want real skills, real wages, and real pathways; and they also want belonging, dignity, and agency. In their accounts, career readiness and civic readiness are not parallel tracks; they are intertwined strands of a coherent life. In articulating this both-and theory, students collapse a dichotomy that policy frameworks often treat as fixed: the economic purpose of education versus its civic purpose. For young people, these aims are not competing—they are mutually reinforcing. A “good job” matters not only because it provides income, but because it confers stability, voice, and the capacity to participate meaningfully in community life. Likewise, learning how systems work—whether electrical, social, or economic—cultivates civic agency, enabling students to navigate institutions with confidence rather than precarity. Career readiness and civic readiness are not parallel tracks in youth accounts; they are intertwined strands of a coherent life.

This orientation aligns with human capital economics in its broadest sense—the idea that investments in human potential yield returns not only to individuals but to society (Becker, 1964; Goldin & Katz, 2008). Yet youth voices here press beyond narrow economic framings. When capital is human, it is inherently relational and communitarian. Skills divorced from community context do not generate shared prosperity; they reproduce isolation. This distinction echoes Sen’s (1999) conception of capability as freedom: development expands what people are able to be and do with and for others, not merely what they can earn. Students are not rejecting work; they are demanding work that matters—work that sustains mobility, strengthens community, and enables meaningful lives.

Their critiques also resonate with culturally sustaining and healing-centered approaches to learning. Repeated calls for authenticity—“teach the truth,” “ask what we’re into”—reflect a desire for educational environments that affirm identity, honor lived experience, and support full participation rather than mere compliance (Ladson-Billings, 1995; Paris & Alim, 2017). Through a healing-centered lens (Ginwright, 2018), these critiques read not as disengagement but as acts of restoration: attempts to reclaim dignity, relevance, and collective wellbeing within institutions that too often demand obedience without understanding.

Taken together, youth are not merely naming problems; they are articulating criteria for a just and functional learning infrastructure—one that enables:

- - learning connected to real-world application and community life;
 - work that sustains dignity, mobility, and contribution;
 - environments that affirm identity and cultural integrity;
 - relationships that cultivate belonging, capability, and confidence; and
 - communities in which individual advancement strengthens the collective.

These criteria point toward an educational system capable of producing both individual capability (Sen, 1999) and collective efficacy (Sampson, 2012): a system in which people build the skills, confidence, and relationships necessary not only to advance their own futures, but to strengthen the communities to which they belong. This dual economic-civic lens becomes a throughline for the dissertation—shaping the analysis of fragmentation in subsequent chapters and grounding later arguments about the governance capacities required to translate youth insight into coherent civic-economic infrastructure.

2.5 Youth Values and Institutional Legitimacy

If urgency shaped how students interpreted institutional rules, identity shaped how they interpreted learning itself. Students at both sites described school environments obsessed with attendance, compliance, and discipline—often experienced as alienating rather than supportive.

- - “It’s like being locked up. They detain us.”
 - “Teachers have too much authority—they isolate you.”

These statements capture the oppressive potential of pedagogy when it demands compliance without comprehension and participation without power (Nasir et al., 2013). Students are not resisting learning; they are resisting powerlessness. Students also challenged the legitimacy and completeness of school knowledge:

- - “They make us believe this is how things really happened—but it’s not.”
 - “They teach half the story. My family didn’t experience the history they talk about.”

For many youth—particularly those navigating economic precarity and racialized inequity—curriculum is not experienced as neutral. Partial histories and sanitized narratives produce dissonance between lived reality and institutional story. In this context, the demand for “truth” is not merely an academic concern; it is a civic demand for recognition, belonging, and dignity. Students are asking institutions to acknowledge the forces that have shaped their communities and to treat their lived knowledge as legitimate.

Culturally sustaining pedagogies argue that schools must not merely avoid harm but actively sustain students’ cultural and linguistic assets (Ladson-Billings, 1995; Paris & Alim, 2017). Students’ critiques of content frequently co-occurred with critiques of discipline because both were experienced as mechanisms of control rather than connection. When authority is exercised without transparency or respect, institutions lose legitimacy—even when intentions are benevolent.

Importantly, youth narratives also illuminate the limits of what individual teachers can shoulder within systems structured by inequality. Many educators are deeply committed to students, yet operate under funding disparities, testing pressures, and bureaucratic constraints that shape what is possible in classrooms. As students themselves noted throughout this IRB-approved research, their needs exceed what any single adult—or single classroom—can reasonably be expected to address. This is why the problem students are naming cannot be resolved through pedagogy alone. As later chapters argue, durable solutions require governance and infrastructure reform: coherent cross-sector architecture that reduces the expectation that schools compensate for regional economic instability, weakened safety nets, and the erosion of civic trust within a highly financialized political economy (Mazzucato, 2021; Reich, 2015).

From this vantage point, students’ calls for “truth,” “respect,” and “being seen” are not pedagogical preferences alone; they are civic claims about how public institutions should function. They reflect a desire for systems that acknowledge structural harm, affirm identity, and cultivate the confidence required for both economic mobility and community contribution. These insights echo Freire’s (2000) insistence that education function as a practice of freedom rather than domestication, and hooks’ (1994) call for pedagogies grounded in care, mutuality, and lived experience.

Seen through a Healing-Centered Engagement lens (Ginwright, 2018), these demands are acts of collective restoration. To ask for truth and respect is to reclaim agency within systems that too often expect obedience without understanding. In naming what feels dishonest or disconnected, young people articulate the conditions under which education can become dignity-conferring civic infrastructure—capable of supporting mobility, belonging, and democratic confidence rather than reproducing alienation.

Further, this study draws on identity-attentive and social capital scholarship to interpret how trust, legitimacy, and belonging are produced—or foreclosed—within education-to-employment systems. Importantly, this dissertation does not attempt a comprehensive comparative analysis across identity groups. Instead, it uses identity-attentive scholarship to examine

how power, historical inequity, and institutional positioning shape young people's navigation of education, workforce, and civic systems; whose knowledge is recognized as legitimate; and how cross-sector collaboration is experienced in practice. These theoretical traditions inform the study's interpretive lens rather than serving as variables to be measured or outcomes to be adjudicated.

Consistent with the dissertation's core normative claim—that education-to-employment systems must be evaluated from the vantage point of those furthest from opportunity—the youth voices centered here are intentionally drawn from contexts shaped by economic precarity, racialized inequality, and constrained civic power. This analytic choice reflects an axiological commitment to treating youth most impacted by structural misalignment not as marginal cases, but as diagnostically central interpreters of system design.

This approach is informed by foundational scholarship on racial identity development, intergroup contact, and social capital (Cross, 1971; Helms, 1990; Tatum, 1992; Portes, 1998; Pettigrew, 1998, 2008), as well as sociological analyses of participation, power, and belonging (Jenkins, 2014), without positioning identity development stages as analytic outcomes in this study. Instead, these traditions inform how the study interprets legitimacy, trust, and relational infrastructure within fragmented systems. This paradigm builds on earlier research design work developed in the author's prior graduate research and refined here for application to intermediary- and system-level analysis (Hall, 2016). Taken together, these lenses are used to interpret institutional design and governance dynamics—not to assess individual identity development or produce comparative claims across demographic groups.

2.6 Linking Youth Perspectives to Systemic Barriers

Across focus groups and follow-up discussions, students described a shared tension: schools prepared them to earn credits, not to navigate futures. They wanted mentorship, real-world application, and clear pathway information, but encountered fragmented advising, inconsistent communication, and limited access to career-connected learning.

- - “I had to wait three weeks to talk to my counselor. By then, the scholarship deadline had passed.”
 - “There's no one to ask. Everyone's too busy.”

These narratives reflect a classic institutional failure: information asymmetry, compounded by explicit and implicit messaging from adults and institutions about who is most likely to access—and be deemed deserving of—opportunity. Those with the least structural power often face the greatest burdens in accessing timely, high-quality information about credentials, opportunities, and transitions. When navigation is scarce, opportunity costs rise and future options narrow accordingly.

Indiana's own policy environment illustrates how such disconnections can become structural. For example, until 2021, Indiana positioned schools as gatekeepers for youth work permits. After advocacy and policy change, the

state shifted responsibility for employment documentation from schools to employers through the Youth Employment System (YES) (Indiana Department of Labor, 2021). The reform matters not only as a compliance adjustment but as an example of the deeper governance problem: when education systems are tasked with adjudicating youth “worthiness” to work, policy can intensify scarcity rather than relieve it.

To connect youth lived experience to structural realities, Table 2.1 synthesizes the alignment—and misalignment—between what students experience and what Indiana’s education-to-employment system currently provides. It is not an external overlay; it is grounded in youths’ own interpretations of system design.

Table 2.1 Student-Identified Barriers and Structural Causes in the Education-to-Employment Linkage

Beyond practical barriers, students also described the emotional and psychological cost of navigating fragmented institutions:

- - “It’s tiring to keep asking for help you never get.”
 - “After a while, you just stop caring because it feels like nobody cares about you.”

These sentiments align with research on scarcity-induced cognitive load and decision fatigue (Mullainathan & Shafir, 2013). When young people must continually advocate for themselves in systems designed around adult convenience rather than youth need, the psychological toll accumulates. That toll is not individual weakness but structural consequence.

Taken together, these accounts show that youth are not merely describing inconvenience; they are diagnosing a system that offloads navigation, risk, and coherence onto those with the least power. When responsibility for alignment is dispersed across schools, counselors, employers, postsecondary institutions, and families—without shared accountability—young people themselves become the connective tissue holding the system together. Their exhaustion reflects not personal disengagement, but the absence of coherent governance capable of stabilizing transitions and distributing responsibility more equitably.

2.7 Youth Demands as Design Specifications: Toward Coherent Civic-Economic Learning Infrastructure

Youth critiques in this chapter function not only as testimony but as design guidance. As my qualifying exam noted, “Educational policy failures are often framed as individual failures, when in fact individuals are behaving rationally in systems designed without them” (Hall, 2022). Across sites, students did not ask for fewer expectations; they asked for expectations that make sense—systems that are navigable, reciprocal, honest, and coherent.

This is where the chapter’s argument intersects directly with the dissertation’s core contribution: the need for High-Quality Intermediary Frameworks (HQIF) that enable collaboratives to produce durable outcomes. Youth are effectively naming the failure mode of many well-intentioned “collective impact” efforts: coordination without governance, partnership without accountability, programs without infrastructure. Their accounts clarify why the work is not simply to add more initiatives, but to build the connective tissue that stops young people from being the de facto system integrators.

To keep youth voice central while avoiding repetition, I return here to a recurring theme already visible across the chapter: students described high school as feeling “like a scam” when it fails to produce credible pathways—when institutional metrics substitute for navigable transitions into dignified work and adult stability. As earlier youth testimony made clear, students distinguish sharply between institutional metrics and lived capability—critiquing systems that judge “worthiness” through narrow compliance indicators while offering limited navigable pathways to stable, dignified work. These recurring distinctions are not rhetorical; they function as

design specifications, pointing toward governance features that reduce navigation burden, expand paid pathway access, and make learning-to-earning transitions more coherent and credible.

In economic terms, fragmented systems generate deadweight loss: unused talent, unmet labor demand, misallocated resources, and diminished regional competitiveness (Mazzucato, 2021; Reich, 2015). In civic terms, they generate alienation, mistrust, and disengagement. When institutions wield authority while ignoring lived reality, legitimacy erodes. As scholars of civic life and democracy warn, sustained misalignment between institutional demands and everyday experience corrodes collective efficacy and weakens democratic participation (Putnam, 2000; Sampson, 2012). Youth voice therefore provides not only empirical grounding but moral urgency for system redesign.

Importantly, this redesign must resist the false dichotomy that pits work-based learning against civic education or frames apprenticeships as anti-intellectual “training” rather than formation. Youth in this chapter want paid learning that leads somewhere, but they also want education that makes them more fully human and more fully able to act: to interpret systems, advocate for themselves, support their families, and contribute to community life. That is exactly why degree apprenticeships and apprenticeship degrees matter as a conceptual bridge: they refuse the story that higher education must be discarded to achieve mobility. Instead, they suggest a pathway ecology in which postsecondary learning is re-anchored in public purpose and in workers’ long-term power—not only wages, but voice.

Across findings, youth call for learning systems that make possible:

- - Pathways that connect learning to real livelihoods and regional economic needs
 - Advising and mentorship structures that treat students as future adults, not data points
 - Truth-telling and cultural integrity in what counts as legitimate knowledge
 - Paid opportunities that confer dignity, not just compliance
 - Relationships that cultivate belonging and capability
 - Civic agency braided with economic mobility, so earning and belonging grow together

These are not abstract ideals. They are design specifications for intermediaries and collaboratives. Chapters 4–6 therefore translate youth-identified failures into governance features: shared accountability, employer engagement that is not extractive, data systems that serve navigation rather than surveillance, and youth voice that is not symbolic but structurally consequential. In this sense, youth in this chapter are not only narrators of system failure—they are co-theorists of system redesign.

Across these findings, youth voices offer design specifications for learning systems capable of supporting earning, belonging, and collective power. They call for pathways that connect learning to real livelihoods and regional economies; advising and mentorship structures that treat students as future

adults rather than data points; truth-telling curricula that reflect lived histories and civic realities; paid opportunities that confer dignity rather than compliance; and relationships that cultivate confidence, capability, and contribution.

Their critiques reveal a longing for agency, purpose, and contribution—and a conviction that systems could, with intentional redesign, honor these aspirations. Youth are not only naming barriers; they are mapping the contours of a more coherent, equitable, and human-centered learning infrastructure. In effect, they are functioning as civic economists: diagnosing the misalignment between public purpose and economic design, and identifying the conditions required for broad-based opportunity and democratic vitality. As a result, youth critiques supply not only experiential evidence, but design logics that later chapters translate directly into governance features of high-quality intermediary infrastructure.

In naming these misalignments, young people are also offering a grounded critique of life in a hyper-capitalist order that offloads risk onto families while treating opportunity as a private gamble. Their perspectives do more than diagnose failure; they imagine alternatives. They point toward systems where economic mobility and civic agency are not competing aims but mutually reinforcing ones—where earning and belonging grow together, and where young people learn not only to navigate institutions, but to contribute to and transform the communities they call home.

This chapter has shown that youth read their environments with clarity and sophistication. Chapter Three builds on this insight by examining how young people convert critique into civic practice through youth leadership and participation programs. These programs operate as small-scale laboratories of democratic participation—spaces where critique becomes contribution and participation becomes power—offering a preview of what is possible when young people are treated not as subjects of policy, but as co-designers of public life.

As the next chapter demonstrates, youth-identified barriers map directly onto the structural features that effective intermediaries must address—governance, backbone capacity, employer engagement, shared data, and youth voice—forming the blueprint for the system-level architecture examined in Chapters Four through Six.

Chapter 3: Youth Voice in Civic Leadership—From Disillusionment to Democratic Practice

3.1 Converting Disillusionment into Democratic Practice

If Chapter Two revealed young people's disillusionment with schooling and civic systems, Chapter Three explores how structured civic leadership programs can convert that disillusionment into agency. This framing aligns with scholarship that conceptualizes youth activism and civic participation as formative civic learning spaces—particularly for young people marginalized by formal institutions—where political agency, collective identity, and democratic skill are developed through consequential participation (Kirshner, 2007). This chapter examines how high-quality civic

programs—such as the VOICES-facilitated City-County Council Cohort and the Youth Policy Fellowship—enable students to transform critique into creativity, skepticism into stewardship, and frustration into governance.

These programs demonstrate that civic learning, when rooted in relevance, relationship, and belonging, can repair the frayed link between education and democracy. Young people are not disengaged from public life; they are reimagining it with a clarity born of lived experience. Their reflections reveal how power, purpose, and participation come to life when systems make room for youth voice to matter. Students are not merely participants in civic learning; they are co-theorists of a renewed civic infrastructure—one that later chapters argue must be braided into the architecture of education-to-employment systems.

This chapter also unfolds within a broader civic moment marked by declining trust in institutions, widening economic inequality, and what scholars call “democratic backsliding” within a hyper-capitalist order characterized by rising corporate influence and political polarization (Levitsky & Ziblatt, 2018; Mayer, 2016). Youth civic leadership programs therefore serve a dual role: they cultivate agency and belonging for young people, while operating as local counterweights to macro-level forces that narrow the public sphere and erode shared responsibility.

My perspective here is shaped not only by facilitation and formal youth research, but also by over a decade of mentorship at the intersection of art and civic life. Since 2013, I have led writing, poetry, and youth leadership programs that use the literary arts as catalysts for social imagination and democratic participation. In 2018, I became the founding Director of the Indiana Youth Poet Laureate (YPL) Program, an affiliate of the National Youth Poet Laureate network launched in partnership with the Library of Congress and the Academy of American Poets.

In that capacity, I have coached and mentored young poets who treat language as a civic act—among them Alyssa Gaines, Indiana’s first National Youth Poet Laureate, and Charlotte Yeung, who later earned the National Regional Youth Poet Laureate distinction. Both of these leaders also served as statewide Youth Fellows. Their work—spanning classrooms, city halls, community forums, and national stages—embodies a core claim of this dissertation: storytelling is not only expressive but structural. It shapes what and whom a democracy values, whose experiences count as evidence, and what futures become imaginable.

In that capacity, I have coached and mentored young poets who treat language as a civic act—among them Alyssa Gaines, Indiana’s first National Youth Poet Laureate, and Charlotte Yeung, who later earned the National Regional Youth Poet Laureate distinction. Both also served as statewide Youth Fellows. The poems they submitted as part of their National Youth Poet Laureate applications (included in the appendix) exemplify a core claim of this dissertation: storytelling is not only expressive but structural. Through poetic language, these works interpret how educational, civic, and economic systems are experienced, whose dignity is recognized, and what forms of participation and leadership young people believe are possible.

Across these poems, Gaines attends closely to the lived and institutional dimensions of schooling and civic life, pairing artistic expression with a clear commitment to expanding access to the arts for all young people regardless of race or economic background. Yeung's poems similarly function as civic analysis, while engaging questions of ecological futures, nuclear disarmament, and the long-term consequences of institutional power—often situating these concerns within a broader commitment to multilateral cooperation and the strengthening of international governance structures such as the United Nations. Taken together, these works operate as artist-led civic inquiry: not partisan argument, but interpretive co-theorizing that surfaces how systems operate and what forms of stewardship, responsibility, and repair young people believe are required.

This tradition of youth civic voice gained unprecedented visibility when Amanda Gorman delivered "The Hill We Climb" at the 2021 presidential inauguration (Gorman, 2021). But what Gorman did on a national stage is what young people in programs like VOICES do every week: declare that the arts are not peripheral to democracy—they are instruments of civic leadership. Poetry, narrative, testimony, and public voice are not adornments; they are infrastructure.

For the purposes of the dissertation's argument, this chapter treats youth civic programs not as enrichment, but as essential civic and economic infrastructure. They cultivate precisely the capacities later chapters identify as foundational for both earning and belonging, for both economic mobility and collective efficacy, and for both individual advancement and community well-being. These insights form the bridge into Chapter Four, where youth-identified barriers become design specifications for the governance architecture and intermediary capacities this dissertation names and theorizes.

Across this chapter, youth civic leadership is treated not as separate from economic formation, but as one of its preconditions. Young people repeatedly describe how access to power, policy literacy, representation, and narrative authority shape not only their civic participation, but their economic horizons—what work feels meaningful, what futures feel possible, and whether institutions appear trustworthy or extractive. In this sense, youth civic critique functions as a form of civic-economic intelligence: it surfaces how fragmented systems undermine both democratic legitimacy and economic mobility, and how coordinated governance can restore both. This framing sets up the central design question carried forward in the dissertation: how regional education-to-employment systems can institutionalize youth civic agency so that earning, learning, and belonging reinforce one another rather than compete.

3.2 Civic Leadership Programs as Participatory Infrastructure

The City-County Council Cohort is a youth leadership initiative where students learn the structure and function of city government by shadowing, advising, and proposing local policy. The Youth Policy Fellowship extends this work through direct policy research, narrative development, coalition-building, and participatory governance. These programs create structured

opportunities for young people to practice civic participation in forms that are consequential: learning how agendas are set, how budgets and committees function, how testimony and narrative shape policy, and how relationships and coalition-building determine what becomes possible.

VOICES is a Black-founded and Black-led nonprofit organization with a multi-million-dollar annual budget devoted to youth healing, leadership, equity, and opportunity. Many of the young people participating in VOICES programs are Black, Latino/a/e, or low-income white youth—students whose lived experiences of systemic inequity shape their civic imagination. Their perspectives resonate with writers from James Baldwin to Barbara Kingsolver—figures who remind us that to love one’s community, or one’s country, is to see it clearly, to hold it accountable, and to help it live up to its promise.

It is also important to clarify the relationship between VOICES, collaboratives, and the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) advanced later in the dissertation. VOICES is not posited as an intermediary in this dissertation. Rather, it is a civic youth-development organization and leadership intermediary that excels at cultivating youth voice, healing-centered civic identity, and participatory leadership in partnership with local government and other institutions. In contrast, RAZ-32 (a rural collaborative), the Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub, and similar cross-sector “hub” or coalition structures are examples of collaboratives that are striving toward the institutional characteristics articulated in the HQIF—especially durable governance routines, shared accountability, braided financing, and the facilitative capacity required to align sectors over time. VOICES illustrates what high-quality youth civic infrastructure can look like inside a single organization and its partnerships; HQIF clarifies what must be true when regions attempt to institutionalize that civic capacity across an education-to-employment ecosystem.

Importantly, the civic programs examined here are not discrete events; they function as intermediary civic ecosystems where young people practice governance, test ideas, and explore how systems might work differently. In that sense, they preview the kind of civic architecture that later chapters argue collaboratives can embed at scale: civic learning not as a unit or elective, but as an ongoing practice of shared power and shared responsibility—one strand of the “three-strand braid” formalized later in the dissertation.

3.3 Youth Reflections on Power, Participation, and Belonging

Across focus groups and program reflections, several themes emerged that illuminate how students interpret power, representation, policy, belonging, and long-term aspiration. Consistent with this dissertation’s research-practice approach, youth comments are treated not only as data but as design guidance for the system-building work explored in Chapters Four through Six. In other words, youth voice functions here as civic intelligence: a diagnostic signal about institutional legitimacy and a set of practical specifications for what “better” must look like in lived experience.

As youth testimony earlier in the dissertation makes clear, students enter civic leadership spaces with deep skepticism about institutional authority—particularly skepticism shaped by schooling experiences that emphasize compliance, credentialing, and economic sorting over power, participation, and shared governance. Rather than suppressing this skepticism, the civic programs examined here treat it as a legitimate starting point for inquiry. Youth are invited to interrogate who benefits from existing systems, how decisions are made, and what it would mean to exercise power collectively rather than merely comply with institutional expectations.

Importantly, students' skepticism was not apathy—it was discernment, often sharpened by the gap between lived experience and what schools treat as legitimate knowledge. One VOICES Day-Reporting participant put it plainly: "We learn more on TikTok or from our grandma than in history class." The point was not that formal schooling is irrelevant, but that institutional narratives can feel partial—especially when Black history, community memory, and structural truth are muted, sanitized, or treated as "controversial." In this sense, students' critique functioned as cultural truth-telling: a demand that civic learning honor identity, lived experience, and the knowledge carried in families and communities.

Within that container of truth-telling, civic learning shifted from commentary to practice. As one student summarized: "We're not [just] learning about power here. We're learning how to use it." These reflections reveal a generative truth: critique is a form of care. Power becomes not domination but coordination—the ability to align people, ideas, and resources toward shared purpose. To learn how to use power ethically is itself an education in love: a disciplined practice of responsibility toward one another and toward the world we share.

As James Baldwin famously wrote, "I love America... and exactly for this reason, I insist on the right to criticize her perpetually" (Baldwin, 1955). For students—many of them young Black Americans participating in a Black-founded civic institution—critique is devotion: an insistence that democracy live up to its potential. That stance matters for the dissertation's broader argument about civic-economic infrastructure: when institutions treat critique as defiance rather than intelligence, they sever legitimacy; when institutions treat critique as a starting point for co-design, they build trust.

This reorientation also marks a profound shift from what schools too often teach: compliance, competition, and individual performance. Within VOICES programs, power becomes a communal tool for problem-solving rather than a credential to be hoarded. This insight aligns with Healing-Centered Engagement (Ginwright, 2018) and Collective Efficacy (Sampson, 2012), both of which emphasize that thriving communities depend on a shared belief in their capacity to act together—and on the relational conditions that make coordinated action sustainable. As one student summarized: "When we learn how power works, we learn how to help each other."

Organizational, motivational, and economic research points in a parallel direction. Cultures of initiative, distributed leadership, and self-determination are consistently associated with innovation, adaptability, and

long-term performance across organizational settings (Amabile & Kramer, 2011; Ryan & Deci, 2000; Dweck, 2006; Grant, 2013; Hsieh, 2010). Employers often describe this cluster of capacities as intrapreneurship. Read through an education-to-employment lens, the claim of this chapter is not that civic programs simply produce “good citizens,” but that they cultivate the same human capacities that enable sustained economic contribution in complex systems: collaboration, initiative, ethical reasoning, strategic thinking, and the ability to navigate institutions without losing one’s sense of purpose or agency. Civic agency and workplace initiative are not separate domains; they are two expressions of the same underlying capacity for coordinated action within shared systems of accountability.

Across civic leadership programs, students described three interrelated dimensions of civic development: representation and identity, policy literacy, and narrative power. Together, these experiences reshaped how young people understood both their civic agency and their professional futures. Students also repeatedly described the transformative power of seeing themselves reflected in civic roles:

- - “I didn’t think someone like me could speak in City Hall. But now I know I can.”
 - “When you see somebody who looks like you in office, it’s like... oh, okay, maybe I could do that.”

Representation functioned not merely as symbolism but, consistent with research on civic identity development, as a catalytic force shaping how young people understand their potential roles in public life (Crocetti et al., 2012; Yates & Youniss, 1999). It altered the opportunity set young people could imagine for themselves, expanding both civic horizons and professional possibility. Youth described how proximity to belonging—being in City Hall, being taken seriously, being coached rather than dismissed—changed what they believed they could become.

This dynamic appeared across identity groups in patterned but overlapping ways. Young Black and Latino leaders emphasized the affirmation that comes from seeing their identities recognized in public life. Low-income white students from rural Indiana described how these programs helped them understand that their struggles—poverty, foster care, addiction, exclusion—are also part of the American story. These reflections matter for mobility because civic identity and career identity frequently braided together: seeing oneself as a civic actor expanded one’s sense of professional possibility. Across programs, students consistently demonstrated the capacity to hold critique and commitment at the same time—naming harm and hypocrisy while remaining invested in collective problem-solving.

The work of democracy requires holding complexity—seeing contradictions clearly and still committing to collective problem-solving. As democratic theorists note, effective civic participation depends on the capacity to recognize tension while remaining engaged in shared inquiry (Allen, 2004). Students demonstrated precisely this kind of nuanced reasoning: they

named harm and hypocrisy while continuing to ask how systems could be redesigned.

A third theme centered on policy literacy. Understanding how decisions are made transformed how students viewed their own potential:

- - “Now I know how budgets work and how decisions get made. I can tell if something’s just noise.”
 - “We should learn how to unionize, negotiate, and build long-term power—not just follow rules.”
 - “We don’t have a direct democracy. We should understand how our government really works.”

Students called for civic and financial literacy, labor rights, and exposure to real policy mechanisms—not just theoretical civics. Civic learning shifted from compliance to design thinking: the study of systems and the rehearsal of reform. This awareness deepened how students interpreted the economy. They wanted to learn collective bargaining, negotiation, budgeting, and long-term civic strategy—recognizing these as essential not only to civic participation but to building stable, purpose-filled lives. As one student put it: “We learn rules in school, but not how to change them.” In a political economy where access to stability, protection, and mobility is mediated through institutions rather than guaranteed as a public good, this knowledge gap carries material consequences.

Within the dissertation’s argument, this is not a “soft” skill request; it is a direct critique of institutional design. If schools prepare students to comply with systems but not to interpret or improve them, then schools reproduce civic fragility and economic vulnerability at the same time. Policy literacy becomes both a civic and economic competency, especially in a political economy where young people must navigate complex institutions to access credentials, wages, protections, and opportunities. Students also repeatedly affirmed that storytelling was not ornamental to civic life—it was foundational:

- - “I never thought my story mattered until I told it and people listened.”
 - “We get to speak truth. That’s power.”

Through op-eds, testimony, and especially poetry, students learned to translate lived experience into public purpose—a form of civic labor that is rarely recognized within formal educational systems. In the Indiana Youth Poet Laureate ecosystem, this translation becomes particularly visible. Alyssa Gaines’s writing and civic voice foreground the relationship between personal experience and structural conditions—how race, schooling, neighborhood context, and institutional attention shape what young people are allowed to become (Gaines, NYPL application materials; Gaines, media kit). Her laureate work emphasizes the necessity of naming anti-Blackness and insisting on full humanity, while also modeling what it looks like for a young leader to carry a public platform with discipline, care, and institutional fluency. Charlotte Yeung’s work, across her poems and vision statement, repeatedly returns to interdependence across time—how policy choices reverberate through climate, migration, violence, and technological

power, and what forms of accountability and stewardship young people must demand of adults and institutions (Yeung, NYPL application materials; Yeung, “Anthropocene” submission; Yeung, vision statement). In distinct registers, both leaders treat youth voice as evidence: a way of making visible what dominant narratives obscure.

In VOICES civic programs, narrative ownership becomes a civic design tool: storytelling is how young people claim space, assert legitimacy, and reshape public discourse. It is also how they learn to be stewards of the communities they critique and love. In this dissertation, storytelling is treated as a constitutive element of civic infrastructure, stabilizing the relational conditions required for collaborative governance: shared understanding, legitimacy, motivation, and the capacity to remain engaged across conflict and difference.

This ethic of public storytelling reached a deeply instructive moment in April 2021, when two VOICES Youth Policy Fellows participated in INside Out: Youth-Led Policy in the Heartland—Session #2, a public webinar I pitched, organized, and co-led in partnership with New America and VOICES Corp. As part of the national Youth America: Storytelling for Action initiative, the event was deliberately designed to reflect Indiana’s racial, geographic, and socioeconomic complexity. This was not symbolic participation; it was a live exercise in civic system-building—one that translated youth experience into institutional insight and public problem-solving. Working alongside VOICES Executive Director Kia Wells—a dear friend and collaborator who is a Black woman leader at the helm of a Black-founded civic organization—we curated a panel that intentionally juxtaposed two youth whose life experiences rarely appear together in shared civic space: a white young woman from one of Indiana’s poorest rural communities who had spent time in the foster-care system and carried a deep understanding of rural poverty, kinship networks, and community precarity; and a Black young man from Gary, raised by a single mother navigating structural racism, disinvestment, and a legacy of urban segregation while pushing tirelessly to expand his opportunities.

Their dialogue revealed the kind of bridging and bonding social capital I examined in earlier work (Hall, 2016). These two students—divided by race, region, community history, and socioeconomic trajectory—recognized one another not through sameness, but through shared struggle and shared aspiration. Their exchange embodied what the civic literature calls bridging social capital: ties that connect people across lines of difference, generating broader collective capacity. It also revealed bonding social capital: connections rooted in empathy, identity, and mutual recognition that foster trust within communities. Here, both operated at once.

What made this moment powerful was not simply that they shared a virtual “stage.” It was that their presence together contested the false dichotomy between “urban” and “rural” suffering—a dichotomy policymakers often accept uncritically, resulting in fragmented or zero-sum policy debates. Importantly, this was not accidental proximity; it was the result of intentional, skilled facilitation. The session was deliberately designed to create a container where young people could risk being honest across lines of race, region, gender, and class. Warmth, clear structure, and shared

agreements about listening and confidentiality did not erase difference; they made it safer to name and work across it. Thus, facilitation itself became a form of civic infrastructure—an invisible but essential architecture that allowed bridging social capital to emerge as more than a slogan. The conversation illustrated a core claim of this dissertation: youth, when given space and structure, intuitively build the civic bridges adults struggle to construct.

The INside Out session convened youth policy fellows Daniel Dabney and Legend West; VOICES founder Kia Wells; myself (as a VOICES leader and New America Indianapolis Fellow); and moderator Molly Martin, Director of New America Indianapolis (see event landing page in Appendix). Together, we explored how lived experience can inform state funding formulas, youth-development investments, and school discipline policy. Civic intermediaries like VOICES created the conditions in which youth could do three things systems rarely allow them to do simultaneously: (1) name systemic harm with precision, grounded in lived experience; (2) dialogue across racial, geographic, and class divides, generating new civic understanding; and (3) translate narrative into policy insight, moving from personal story to systemic design. This was Healing-Centered Engagement in practice (Ginwright, 2018), not in abstraction. It was Collective Efficacy at civic scale (Sampson, 2012), enacted by youth rather than merely studied by adults. Through cross-race, cross-region facilitation woven across racially diverse adult leadership, we modeled distributive power, shared responsibility, and mutual accountability.

Importantly, VOICES does not function as a comprehensive intermediary in the High-Quality Intermediary Framework articulated later in this dissertation. It does not coordinate regional education-to-employment systems, broker workforce partnerships, or manage cross-sector implementation at scale. Instead, VOICES operates as a civic intermediary—specializing in youth voice, facilitation across difference, and the translation of lived experience into public problem-solving. Its significance in this chapter is analytic rather than categorical: it demonstrates civic capacities that HQIF-aligned intermediaries must incorporate if they are to generate durable legitimacy, trust, and collective efficacy. Thus, VOICES illustrates not the full architecture of an intermediary, but a critical layer of it—one that is often absent from workforce and education collaboratives despite being essential to their long-term success.

The session also demonstrated that belonging and agency are not byproducts of civic learning—they are prerequisites for it. The sophistication with which these youth engaged in policy problems underscored the dissertation's broader finding: civic fluency and system design are interdependent forms of leadership. Later chapters return to this often-invisible layer of work, arguing that the collaborative governance required for effective, region-scale collaboratives depends not only on formal structures and MOUs, but on exactly this kind of facilitative capacity that can hold complexity, difference, and shared purpose at once.

Finally, students' civic learning experiences consistently translated into aspirational, future-oriented goals:

- - "I want to work for the government and change policies about police accountability."
 - "I want to build a youth program where people feel safe and seen."
 - "I want to do TED Talks, meet Neil deGrasse Tyson, and show what's possible."

These aspirations reveal a defining theme of this chapter: students braid their civic identity with their professional identity. They articulate career goals not as escapes from inequity, but as strategies to confront and transform those inequities. Their visions entwine economic independence with social impact, purpose with prosperity. This is especially clear when students describe how their civic experiences deepen their understanding of structural forces—economic exclusion, housing instability, workforce precarity—that shape their communities. They interpret these not as individual misfortunes but as democratic failures. Thus, their civic work becomes a form of collective resistance to the erosion of public goods, and their professional ambitions emerge as extensions of their civic commitments. These braided civic-professional aspirations preview the dissertation's central claim: that durable mobility depends not on separating civic formation from economic preparation, but on designing institutions capable of holding both at once.

Taken together, these findings raise a generative systems-design question that carries forward into the dissertation's intermediary analysis: how can regional education-to-employment collaboratives learn from youth civic organizations like VOICES in cultivating legitimacy, shared purpose, and participatory power—and how can civic programs, in turn, become more tightly connected to durable economic pathways? VOICES demonstrates depth on the civic side of the equation, while regional collaboratives such as RAZ-32, the Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub, and the Whitley County CTE Collaborative are working to institutionalize economic coordination at scale. The dissertation argues that progress toward HQIF-quality systems depends on reciprocal learning between these models, rather than treating civic formation and economic alignment as separate or sequential domains.

3.4 Interpreting Youth Civic Practice through CPA, HCE, and Collective Governance

Critical Policy Analysis (CPA) helps interpret youth civic programs as producers of counter-narratives that reject deficit theories of young people—especially youth of color and those navigating marginalization. CPA recognizes young people as co-theorists whose lived experiences reveal policy contradictions that remain invisible from the center of power. In the context of civic programs, youth voice does not merely "share an opinion"; it provides analytic knowledge about how institutions actually function and where legitimacy breaks down.

Healing-Centered Engagement (HCE) complements this by clarifying why civic learning becomes transformative when it centers identity, culture, and

belonging. Inviting youth into policymaking is not symbolic; it is institutional repair. HCE is especially useful here because many young people enter civic space carrying justified distrust—built from histories of institutional betrayal, erasure, or punishment. When civic programs prioritize dignity and relational trust, youth do not become “less critical”; they become more able to translate critique into sustained stewardship.

Collaborative governance provides a third lens. These programs model cross-sector alignment—education, nonprofit, and local government—where shared power, collective accountability, and distributed leadership become civic rehearsal for the system-level redesign explored later in the dissertation. Civic practice here is also workforce practice: negotiation, coordination, problem-solving, ethical reasoning, and strategic communication. Civic learning thus becomes connective tissue between democratic renewal and labor-market vitality—between the civic capacities and economic mobility this dissertation argues must grow together.

Across all three lenses, facilitation emerges as a critical—if frequently under-theorized—form of public work. Creating spaces where youth and adults can deliberate across lines of race, geography, and institutional role requires more than goodwill; it requires structured processes, shared norms, and leaders who can blend emotional intelligence with design skills. Later chapters return to this theme, arguing that region-scale collaboratives aspiring toward HQIF-quality outcomes are only as strong as the facilitative capacity that undergirds them.

3.5 Implications for Education and Democracy

Taken together, the civic leadership programs examined in this chapter reveal what education can and must be: preparation for participation, not just performance. Civic identity does not grow through worksheets alone, but through real practice, shared power, and access to consequential decision-making. When schools fail to provide these opportunities—or actively avoid them—they enact forms of civic erasure that carry democratic consequences.

As one Black student summarized painfully, “Our teacher skipped the civil rights unit because she said it was too controversial.” Such silence functions as a form of harm in students’ civic learning, consistent with scholarship on civic erosion, curricular exclusion, and institutional betrayal in educational contexts (Smith & Freyd, 2014; Levinson, 2012; Kahne & Bowyer, 2017). Over time, these omissions undermine democratic resilience and constrict civic imagination—particularly for students whose histories and identities are already marginalized within formal curricula.

VOICES programming demonstrates that a different institutional orientation is possible. Rather than treating civic learning as an extracurricular add-on, these programs embed participation within authentic, identity-affirming contexts where young people exercise power, practice deliberation, and engage institutions as legitimate—even when they are critical of them. Dewey’s (1916) insistence that democracy must be “reborn in every generation,” and bell hooks’ (1994) framing of education as “the practice of freedom,” come into sharper relief when youth are treated not as civic

afterthoughts but as civic actors whose lived experiences constitute valid public knowledge.

At the same time, this chapter draws an important distinction between a youth civic organization and a region-scale collaborative. VOICES functions as a civic intermediary that braids youth insight into institutional spaces through facilitation, leadership development, and participatory governance. By contrast, Rural Alliance Zone 32, Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub, and Whitley County Career and Technical Education regional collaboratives seeking to align education, workforce, and community institutions around shared outcomes at regional scale. Regions require both: organizations like VOICES that cultivate youth civic agency with depth and integrity, and collaboratives that can institutionalize that agency across education-to-employment infrastructure so civic identity, democratic legitimacy, and economic mobility become mutually reinforcing rather than episodic or fragile. Future research and implementation will examine how these organizational forms can intentionally learn from one another, grounded in the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF): supporting youth civic organizations like VOICES in deepening alignment with economic pathways, while guiding regional collaboratives such as RAZ-32, Elkhart, and Whitley to more fully embed youth voice, co-creation, and healing-centered governance—particularly through Domain 8 of the framework.

3.6 Youth Civic Engagement as Purpose, Identity, and Public Infrastructure

Youth civic participation is a declaration of belonging. It demonstrates that young people and their communities matter, even when institutional structures fail to recognize or build upon that contribution. Yet civic contributions often occur in spite of schools, not because of them. Table 3.1 synthesizes youth civic practice as both lived experience and system diagnostic, drawing on focus group data and program artifacts. It shows how civic engagement is widely enacted but unevenly recognized, and that current educational structures do not consistently integrate, credential, or build upon the civic labor young people already perform. The table makes visible a core contradiction: youth practice civic leadership across contexts, yet the institutions most responsible for cultivating it rarely integrate or credential these contributions. This gap clarifies a central design challenge: civic identity must become infrastructure, not ornamentation. Rather than treating civic engagement as enrichment or extracurricular activity, current systems often overlook or underutilize the civic labor that already functions as an informal foundation for how young people learn to contribute to their communities.

Table 3.1 Youth Civic Engagement Opportunities and Systemic Supports

3.7 Synthesis: From Participation to Civic Infrastructure

Table 3.1 makes the underlying pattern unmistakable: young people already practice civic life, but the system treats these acts as peripheral. When students' contributions receive no credit, compensation, or credential, participation becomes a privilege rather than a right—deepening inequity and narrowing democratic capacity. This is where the dissertation's central argument crystallizes in the civic register: purpose must be designed into the architecture of education-to-employment systems. Youth civic leadership is not a “nice-to-have.” It stabilizes the motivational and relational conditions that make persistence, skill development, and long-term economic participation possible.

At the same time, precision matters. VOICES demonstrates how a youth civic organization can cultivate voice, belonging, and policy fluency through high-quality programming and facilitation. RAZ-32, Elkhart WBL Hub, and Whitley CTE Collaborative illustrate a different challenge: how regions braid institutions together so that learning, earning, and belonging are not episodic, but structurally supported across a community. In the language developed later in the dissertation, these collaboratives are examples of regional structures striving toward HQIF-quality intermediary capacity—so civic agency is not dependent on a single program or charismatic leader, but becomes a reliable public good.

This dissertation adopts the term durable skills to emphasize their long-term, cross-context value: competencies that persist across roles, sectors, and economic conditions, and that enable individuals to adapt as technologies, labor markets, and civic demands evolve (America Succeeds, 2021; America Succeeds, 2023). These skills are often described interchangeably in the literature as soft skills, transferable skills, or 21st-century skills; however, the term durable foregrounds their structural importance rather than their perceived disposability. Crucially, these skills are not ancillary to technical preparation; they are foundational to long-term employability, civic participation, and economic resilience. When schools prepare students to comply with systems but not to interpret, navigate, or improve them, they reproduce civic fragility and economic vulnerability at the same time. Youth civic leadership programs make visible what current systems often obscure: that durable skills are not “nice-to-have” dispositions, but core capacities for sustaining mobility, legitimacy, and collective problem-solving in complex societies.

Through this lens, civic engagement becomes infrastructure: the motivational, relational, and ethical framework that sustains academic persistence, work-based learning, and regional vitality. The chapter reveals a feedback loop: youth agency fuels civic imagination; intermediaries translate imagination into institutional design; and systems expand opportunity for the next generation. As a result, what is often framed narrowly as an education-to-employment pipeline is better understood as civic-economic infrastructure: a system that prepares students not only to earn a living but also to shape the civic and economic conditions of collective thriving.

3.8 Youth Civic Leadership as Foundation for System Redesign

Youth civic leadership programs reveal a profound truth at the heart of this dissertation: young people already possess the insight and imagination required to redesign public systems. What they need are institutions willing to share power.

- - Their critiques name structural harm.
 - Their creativity outlines alternative futures.
 - Their collaborations model the ecosystems our democracy and economy require.

Chapter Three completes the narrative arc opened in Chapter Two: youth voice expands from diagnosis to democratic practice. These early chapters together provide the moral and empirical foundation for the structural, regional, and systems-design work that follows. Chapter 3 forms connective tissue between youth critique (Chapters 2–3) and intermediary design logic (Chapter 4), showing why civic agency must be treated as infrastructure, not enrichment.

Chapter Four now turns to institutional architecture—examining how high-quality intermediaries and collaboratives aspiring toward HQIF conditions translate youth insight into durable, coordinated systems capable of advancing both economic mobility and democratic renewal. The design challenge sharpened here is direct: if young people are already practicing civic leadership, what kinds of regional structures can sustain, credential, and expand that work—so earning, learning, and belonging become predictable, equitable, and real.

The evidence in this chapter makes one requirement unmistakable. Youth cannot be positioned merely as program participants or downstream beneficiaries of system redesign. They must be treated as co-theorists, co-designers, and—where appropriate—co-governors of the regional systems that shape their educational and economic futures. Relational trust, identity development, and healing-centered engagement are not optional enhancements to this work; they are core infrastructure. When youth insight informs governance design, accountability mechanisms, and system priorities, education-to-employment pathways are more likely to produce not only workforce alignment, but democratic legitimacy.

This claim is grounded in the youth interviews and civic artifacts presented in Chapters Two and Three; in the facilitation and governance practices of VOICES; in Healing-Centered Engagement frameworks; and in developing proof points from multi-sector collaboratives where relational trust, participation, and shared power are treated as design variables rather than byproducts. Together, these sources establish a central premise carried forward in the dissertation: systems that exclude youth voice may achieve short-term coordination, but systems that embed youth voice are more likely to sustain legitimacy, adaptability, and shared purpose over time.

Chapter 4: Intermediaries as Civic Infrastructure: Designing Regional Education-to-Employment Systems

4.1 From Programs to Civic Infrastructure

The previous chapters argued that young people experience schooling not only as an academic system, but as a civic and economic sorting mechanism. They encounter fragmented programs, shifting initiatives, and overlapping reforms that rarely add up to a coherent pathway. Yet their narratives also reveal a persistent desire for connection: between what they learn and who they are becoming; between classrooms and communities; between present sacrifice and future possibility. As one student put it, “School prepares us for capitalism, not for power.” Another added, “We learn rules in school, but not how to change them.” In Chapter 4, that line becomes a design requirement: if pathways are going to build mobility and legitimacy, regions need structures that teach and credential skill while also widening young people’s practical access to decision-making—through shared governance, transparent rules, and real roles in shaping the system. Collectively, youth narratives frame today’s challenge as a dual crisis of economic access and democratic legitimacy: pathways that fail to deliver stable livelihoods also fail to confer voice, agency, and institutional trust.

This chapter responds to that diagnosis by reframing regional collaboratives, or intermediaries, as civic infrastructure. In the national field, terms like intermediary, coordinating entity, backbone, and partnership are often used interchangeably, sometimes to describe a single program and other times to describe an entire regional governance system. The result is conceptual sprawl: the more we name intermediaries as important, the less clear it becomes what “quality” actually entails, how it can be assessed, and what should be funded as infrastructure rather than as a temporary pilot or programmatic effort. Comparative vocational education research similarly cautions that the effectiveness of apprenticeship and pathway systems depends less on discrete program features than on the surrounding institutional architecture and social settlement that sustain coordination over time (Rauner & Wittig, 2010).

To address that gap, this dissertation advances a High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) as an overarching guidepost—an emerging “gold standard” for what regional collaboratives, or “intermediaries” striving to become high-quality, must be able to architect, govern, and sustain if regions hope to align education-to-employment systems in ways that advance both mobility and democratic renewal. The HQIF is the primary contribution of the design argument across Chapters 4–6: it clarifies the capacities that distinguish intermediaries that merely support programs from those that transform systems. Throughout this chapter, I use the terms regional collaboratives and intermediaries broadly to refer to cross-sector collaborative structures and the coordinating civic-economic institutions that steward them; when referencing the Indiana model that I worked to advance through the 2025 legislative policy push, I retain the name Multi-Sector Collaboratives (MSCs). All are evaluated against the HQIF, which functions as a quality standard rather than a competing model. Within that frame, the examples referenced in this chapter—rural collaboratives (e.g., RAZ-32), countywide work-based learning hubs (e.g., the Elkhart WBL Hub), and CTE collaboratives (e.g., Whitley County CTE Collaborative)—are best

understood as regional collaboratives or intermediaries striving (with varying degrees of maturity) toward HQIF-level quality.

This reframing matters because the broader context is not neutral. Youth civic leadership in Chapter 3 unfolds amid declining trust in public institutions and widening legitimacy gaps—conditions that scholars associate with democratic strain and backsliding (Levitsky & Ziblatt, 2018). Contemporary survey evidence reinforces this: trust in the federal government remains near historic lows (Pew Research Center, 2023), with relatively small shares reporting that they trust government “just about always” or “most of the time.” In parallel, intensified forms of hyper-capitalist political economy continue to shape how Americans debate education itself—especially higher education—often reducing schooling to a narrow labor-market instrument rather than a site for civic formation, moral reasoning, and identity development. In that climate, work-based learning and apprenticeship are sometimes caricatured as producing “worker bees for the machine,” instead of community members with agency: organizers, caregivers, inventors, union leaders, and civic actors with power unto themselves.

The argument here is the opposite. When designed with integrity, education-to-employment alignment is not a retreat from civic purpose; it is one route back to it. Regional collaboratives that strive toward HQIF quality do not merely broker placements or coordinate credits. They build civic capacity by formalizing shared governance, distributing decision rights, and creating durable routines through which educators, employers, higher education, and community partners deliberate, negotiate, and co-own outcomes. Done well, these collaboratives reduce reliance on compensatory heroics—individual teachers, counselors, or employer champions absorbing system failures through extraordinary personal labor—and instead build predictable structures that can withstand turnover, funding cycles, and political swings.

Because youth critiques reflect both structural gaps and the need for relational repair, HQIF-level intermediaries also require Healing-Centered Engagement design—relational trust, shared power, and authentic youth voice—embedded into governance rather than appended to programming (Ginwright, 2018). The work is technical and civic. It depends not only on the right spreadsheet, course code, or MOU, but on the nuanced facilitation that allows cross-sector groups to stay at the table through conflict, difference, and the unequal power that inevitably accompanies money, credentials, race, geography, and institutional status. In political-economic terms, HQIF-aligned intermediaries operate at the meso-level: they cannot resolve macro-level inequality or labor precarity, but they can redesign the institutional interfaces through which young people encounter markets, credentials, and civic authority.

This chapter operationalizes the civic and structural demands voiced by young people in Chapters 2 and 3. If youth seek coherence, dignity, and shared power, the design question becomes: what intermediary capacities make those aspirations real at regional scale—and how do collective impact strategies mature into civic-economic infrastructure rather than remaining a patchwork of well-intended programs?

Read as a design signal rather than a complaint, youth critiques are not rejections of work, wages, or skill-building. They are diagnoses of institutional design—of a deeper mismatch between preparation for economic participation and preparation to shape the civic terms under which that economy operates. Young people are asking for pathways that make earning and learning real and cultivate the power, belonging, and collective capacity required to sustain workplaces, communities, and democratic life over time.

This chapter takes that diagnosis seriously by reframing intermediaries as civic infrastructure: structures designed to make coherence, dignity, and shared decision-making durable at regional scale rather than episodic or personality-dependent. The design question that follows is therefore not whether collaboration matters, but what intermediary capacities are required for collaboration to mature into legitimate civic-economic infrastructure rather than remain a patchwork of well-intended programs.

4.2 From Conceptual Sprawl to a Quality Standard: Intermediaries and the HQIF Target

At their core, regional collaboratives and intermediaries respond to a structural limitation of contemporary education-to-employment systems: no single institution can, on its own, design and sustain pathways that are simultaneously rigorous, equitable, and responsive to labor-market demand. Yet many systems continue to rely on ad hoc, bilateral partnerships—one district paired with one employer, or one program negotiated at a time—often brokered through personal relationships rather than shared infrastructure. These arrangements are inherently fragile, difficult to scale, and uneven in who they serve.

In the national field, terms like intermediary, backbone, hub, and partnership are used inconsistently—sometimes to describe a single program and other times to describe an entire regional governance system. This dissertation does not attempt to settle that naming debate or advance a new label as the solution. Instead, it treats terminology as secondary to a more consequential design question: what capacities must any regional collaborative possess if it is to function as durable civic-economic infrastructure rather than a collection of well-intended activities? The High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) is offered as a transferable quality standard—an evaluative and developmental guide that can be applied across collaborative forms and institutional “homes,” allowing regions to assess intermediary maturity, identify predictable failure modes, and strengthen the conditions under which education-to-employment systems can advance both mobility and democratic renewal. From a practitioner standpoint, this shift—from naming to quality—also keeps the focus on building agreements and routines that reduce fragmentation while creating a shared table where partners can learn, adapt, and co-own regional outcomes.

A necessary complication is that fragmentation is not the only problem. Even a coherent system can reproduce harm if the terms of coherence remain tethered to capitalist extraction or racialized hierarchy. In other words, the question is not only whether pathways are coordinated, but who benefits,

who bears risk, and who gains voice. In the current moment—marked by widening inequality, policy retrenchment around equity work, and persistent racialized disparities—intermediary architecture must be evaluated not merely for efficiency but for whether it interrupts predictable patterns of exclusion and dispossession.

The HQIF is offered with that constraint in view. While all domains carry equity implications, Domains 6–9 function as explicit guardrails against “pipeline logic” that externalizes costs to families, treats youth as inputs, or mistakes participation for power. Together, they push regions to design navigation and access that are reliable for students furthest from opportunity (Domain 6), build shared measurement as collective learning rather than compliance (Domain 7), embed youth as co-theorists and co-designers with consequential roles (Domain 8), and adapt to place in ways that protect non-negotiable quality and public purpose (Domain 9). Read this way, HQIF is not a promise that systems will become just through design alone; it is a quality standard intended to make power, dignity, and distributive consequences visible—and therefore governable. Put differently, and simply: HQIF is an attempt to make “what works” inseparable from “for whom, at what cost, and with what voice.”

From an implementation standpoint, fragmented partnership models impose significant transaction costs on students, families, educators, and employers. Each new partnership introduces additional forms, calendars, liability agreements, supervision rules, and quality expectations—frequently misaligned across institutions even when serving the same learners and employers. The result is not merely administrative inefficiency, but structural inequity: students with greater social capital navigate complexity more successfully, while others encounter opaque systems, inconsistent access, and lower-quality experiences.

Critically, fragmentation is often reinforced—not resolved—by the proliferation of discrete contracts and memoranda of understanding (MOUs) between the same partners for related work. In Indiana and comparable contexts, it is common for a single employer to maintain MOUs with District A and, for even medium-sized employers, five or more additional districts—each with its own academic calendar, bell schedules, supervision expectations, liability terms, onboarding processes, points of contact, cultural norms, and reporting timelines. These arrangements are often layered atop separate agreements with a higher education partner for the same pathway.

Simultaneously, District A may hold separate MOUs with both the employer and the postsecondary institution, while the postsecondary partner maintains parallel agreements with that same employer—producing a web of duplicative contracts governing a single pathway or set of experiences. The consequence is not only inefficiency, but the loss of a shared forum for collective conversation, relationship-building, and continuous improvement across sectors. When agreements are bilateral and siloed, partners lack a shared space to align schedules, standardize expectations, coordinate supports, or collectively assess quality. By contrast, when districts actively engage in a regional collaborative, they can intentionally align calendars,

policies, and learner supports across districts and organizations—reducing friction for families and employers alike. Similarly, when multiple employers are aligned through a collaborative structure, they can commit to shared processes and tools—such as common training plans, mentor preparation materials, safety protocols, and evaluation rubrics—making district engagement more feasible, streamlined, and equitable. These shared structures also make it possible to evaluate implementation with a growth mindset, focusing on continuous improvement rather than compliance or fault-finding.

Fragmented agreements, by contrast, obscure system-level visibility and foreclose civic dialogue about the whole. Partners are left managing transactions rather than stewarding outcomes, and regions lose the capacity to collectively see, discuss, and evolve their education-to-employment system as a system. This is precisely why the inclusion of civic and economic development actors—such as mayors, county councils, chambers of commerce, and regional development organizations—is so generative. These actors anchor collaboration in place-based outcomes that transcend any single institution, including median wage growth, workforce retention, population stability, public health, educational attainment, and civic participation.

From an HQIF perspective, this fragmentation constrains multiple dimensions of intermediary quality simultaneously. The absence of shared agreements and forums undermines Domain 1 (Leadership, Governance, and Public Purpose) by diffusing decision-making authority across bilateral relationships rather than situating it within shared, accountable governance. It weakens Domain 3 (Backbone Capacity) by forcing coordination to occur through informal workarounds rather than authorized, resourced facilitation. Fragmentation also weakens the conditions necessary for Domain 7 (Data, Learning, and Continuous Improvement): when data are generated and held within siloed agreements, regions struggle to develop shared measures, interpret patterns across institutions, or engage in continuous improvement grounded in a common understanding of outcomes. Similarly, without a coherent intermediary structure, adaptations to local context—rural scale, transportation constraints, labor-market shifts, or demographic change—occur reactively and unevenly rather than through intentional, cross-sector design, constraining Domain 9 (Contextual Adaptation and Place-Based Design). In this way, what appears as administrative duplication is more accurately understood as a structural barrier to collective learning, shared governance, and place-based stewardship.

These pressures are heightened in states like Indiana, where high school redesign, expanded work-based learning, and new graduation diploma requirements—especially the Employment Seal and Employment Honors Plus Seal (Indiana Department of Education, 2024a)—have accelerated demand for employer partnerships faster than many regions have been equipped with the intermediary infrastructure needed to coordinate them coherently. As a result, policy ambition has outpaced the development of shared governance forums, backbone capacity, and deliberative structures required to align employers, schools, and postsecondary institutions at

scale. It is precisely these enabling and constraining conditions—particularly the absence of durable coordination and shared sense-making—that gave rise to collective impact and intermediary approaches in the first place.

Collective impact approaches emerged precisely to address this kind of fragmentation: they seek shared agenda, mutually reinforcing activities, shared measurement, continuous communication, and backbone support. In education-to-employment ecosystems, however, the field has too often stopped at the language of collaboration without specifying the governance and infrastructural capacities that make collaboration durable and impact-driven. The HQIF is proposed to fill that gap. It defines the intermediary not merely as a connector, but as a civic-economic institution with the authority and capacity to do four kinds of work reliably:

- 1. **Architect coherence** across districts, employers, and postsecondary partners (pathway design, schedules, placement systems, credit articulation).
- 2. **Govern shared decision-making** (clear decision rights, enforceable agreements, conflict navigation, equitable participation).
- 3. **Braid resources and incentives** (public funding streams, employer contributions, philanthropy, and policy levers aligned to shared outcomes).
- 4. **Sustain legitimacy and belonging** (youth voice embedded in design; public narrative; trust-building across lines of race, place, and class).

Importantly, these functions do not constitute additional HQIF domains; they describe the intermediary's core work. The HQIF domains that follow specify the governance, operational, measurement, equity, youth-voice, and place-based capacities that determine whether this work is durable, equitable, and legitimacy-building over time.

This is where relational capital becomes structural. High-quality intermediaries must cultivate both bonding social capital (trust within communities) and bridging social capital (trust across communities and institutions). Classic social capital research underscores the civic significance of these dynamics (Putnam, 2000), and newer empirical work links forms of social connectedness—especially cross-class connection—to economic mobility outcomes (Chetty et al., 2022). Regional collaboratives that move toward HQIF quality are therefore not just coordinating meetings; they are generating the relational preconditions for shared governance in places where institutional distrust is rational, historically produced, and widely felt.

Indiana's policy-era term "Multi-Sector Collaborative" (MSC) illustrates one way a state can codify and fund this work. In the 2024–2025 policy materials, MSCs were defined (in simplified form) as regional collaboratives that: (a) include multiple, primarily small and rural "Heartland" school districts; (b) are anchored by a coordinating intermediary not owned by any single district; (c) provide a cohesive hub or center of decision-making, communication, and materials across sectors and organizations; (d) hold

formal partnership agreements with employers directly tied to ROI and impact for students; (e) align pathways to high-wage, high-demand sectors; and (f) track shared outcomes across students, employers, and regions. In this dissertation's terms, those MSC criteria can be read as an applied, policy-ready attempt to name HQIF-aligned features—not the full universe of intermediary quality, but a state's pragmatic effort to authorize and invest in regional coherence, especially for often under-resourced or constrained small and rural communities.

A recurring design decision in this field concerns where intermediary functions “live.” For example, some regions create a new standalone entity (often a 501(c)(3)) to hold backbone responsibilities, while others formally authorize an existing regional institution (e.g., a workforce board, education service center, community foundation, or higher education partner) to serve as the backbone under shared governance guardrails. In either case, the choice of where the intermediary is housed must balance the need to establish durable backbone capacity with the need to leverage the complementary strengths of all partners while maintaining shared decision-making and collective impact tenets. HQIF treats this housing choice as consequential for Domains 1 and 3 because it shapes decision rights, operational capacity, and the potential to scale beyond a single region.

The emphasis on multi-district design is not incidental. In Indiana, many districts—particularly small and rural “Heartland” districts, defined in the proposed Multi-Sector Collaborative (MSC) legislation as those serving 2,000 students or fewer—lack the scale to sustain specialized pathways, clinical experiences, and robust work-based learning independently. Former Indiana Chamber of Commerce CEO Kevin Brinegar was among the state's most visible advocates for responding to these structural constraints through school consolidation, advancing the argument primarily through a fiscal and efficiency-oriented lens. Yet despite sustained advocacy, consolidation efforts failed to gain durable traction in the legislature—due in large part to constituent resistance and the widely held recognition that schools function not only as service providers, but as core civic institutions anchoring community identity and democratic life (Smith, 2024).

More recent policy conversations—shaped by a broad coalition of education, workforce, employer, and community organizations—have increasingly emphasized collaboration over consolidation. During the 2025 legislative session, I led the design and advancement of the Multi-Sector Collaborative (MSC) policy proposal, working in close partnership with the Indiana Chamber of Commerce's Vice President for Education and Workforce Development, who served as a central co-advocate and strategic driver alongside this work. Together, this coalition reframed questions of scale around shared governance, regional coordination, and durable backbone capacity rather than district elimination. This shift reflects both economic and civic realities: Indiana has over 260 public school districts, including more than 160 serving fewer than 2,000 students, making questions of scale unavoidable, but not determinative. While consolidation may still be appropriate in select circumstances, regional collaboratives offer an alternative design response—one that preserves local governance while creating shared backbone capacity. By pooling demand, sharing costs,

aligning employer relationships, and co-owning a portfolio of pathways, districts can reduce fragmentation without erasing place-based identity.

Thus, multi-district collaboratives intervene directly in the dynamics youth describe at the outset of this chapter: they redesign schools not as isolated civic and economic sorting systems, but as collectively governed infrastructure capable of expanding both mobility and democratic participation. This logic also applies beyond rural contexts. A countywide work-based learning hub in a manufacturing-dense region like Elkhart demonstrates how a collaborative can function as a “front door” for employers and a coherence structure for schools—reducing duplication, standardizing quality expectations, and coordinating placements across a labor shed that already spans multiple districts.

Finally, this chapter keeps the civic stakes explicit. The purpose of building HQIF-level intermediaries is not to perfect a pipeline for its own sake; it is to restore agency, coherence, and public legitimacy in a period when many young people understandably doubt that institutions are designed for them. Regional collaboratives become civic infrastructure when they make room for youth voice as consequential—when young people are not only “served” by pathways but participate in shaping the rules, norms, and priorities that govern those pathways. As Chapter 3 established, youth are already asking for civic power, not just credentials; the design question in Chapter 4 is what kind of intermediary architecture can honor that demand without collapsing into either technocracy or charity. Later in the chapter, Table 4.2 maps common collaborative forms to typical strengths and risks, previewing which dimensions of intermediary quality become most protective when regions attempt to build durable pathway infrastructure.

4.3 RAZ-32 as a Prototyping Site: Rural Health Pathways, Governance, and Healing-Centered Design

The Rural Alliance Zone 32 (RAZ-32) serves as a primary prototype for the kind of HQIF-aspiring regional collaboratives this dissertation examines. Located in East Central Indiana—a region facing persistent healthcare shortages, aging demographics, and pronounced disparities in health access and outcomes—RAZ-32 emerged from a convergence of local urgency and statewide experimentation. It illustrates the dissertation’s central claim that the “missing middle” between policy intent and lived outcomes is not motivation, but infrastructure: coordinated governance, braided financing, and skilled facilitation that can hold both economic and civic aims at once.

Superintendents in Randolph County, all of whom led “Heartland” districts serving 2,000 or less students, experienced a common dilemma: their districts were too small, individually, to build robust healthcare pathways that included clinical experiences, dual credit, and stackable credentials. At the same time, regional employers—especially Reid Health—were struggling to fill critical roles across the clinical pipeline. Traditional hiring strategies, including signing bonuses and travel nurse contracts, were not solving the underlying issue: an inadequate local talent pipeline, shaped by out-migration pressures, uneven postsecondary access, and limited early exposure to healthcare careers for rural youth.

Youth involved in the early design of RAZ-32 consistently named healthcare not only as a viable career pathway, but as a form of civic contribution —“helping people we know,” “staying and serving,” and “being useful here.” These aspirations shaped pathway sequencing and governance decisions, including early exposure, paid work, and credential transparency. RAZ-32 was designed as a multi-district backbone structure intended to address these intertwined challenges through a collective-impact strategy rather than isolated program development. A common refrain among participating leaders was “collaboration over consolidation”—language that echoed multi-year discussions in the Indiana statehouse (and in other states) about how to improve efficiency and achieve economies of scale across small rural districts. RAZ-32 was positioned as an alternative pathway: one that could create shared infrastructure and scale across districts while preserving core local assets, including geographic proximity, smaller cohort structures, and relational school environments often cited as beneficial to student development and access. This emphasis reflected broader statewide concerns about the long-term viability of small districts and growing pressure toward consolidation, and it aligned with contemporaneous dialogue among Indiana leaders about whether regional pathway infrastructure could expand opportunity without dissolving local governance.

A critical but often underexamined feature of this work is the catalytic leadership required to convene a regional table before durable infrastructure exists. In the RAZ-32 case—and in parallel efforts in Concord, Whitley County, and Elkhart—regional collaboration did not emerge organically from system incentives alone. It required superintendents willing to act ahead of formal authorization, shared funding, or guaranteed outcomes. In Randolph County, Concord Community Schools, and Whitley County Consolidated Schools, superintendents Aaron Black, Dan Funston, and Dr. Laura McDermott had each already engaged me to support high school redesign and district transformation efforts. Each then made a consequential additional choice: to extend that work beyond their own district boundaries and to personally invest early resources—including paying for external facilitation and convening—so that a broader regional collaborative could be tested.

This form of leadership is neither purely technical nor merely relational. It reflects a willingness to absorb early risk on behalf of the collective, to use positional authority to invite peers into shared problem-solving, and to model the belief that rising tides can lift all districts without erasing local identity. In HQIF terms, this catalytic phase is most closely aligned with Domain 1 (Leadership, Governance, and Public Purpose) and Domain 3 (Backbone Capacity, Facilitation, Operations, and Braided Finance): leaders must temporarily stand in for missing infrastructure while simultaneously working to build it. Importantly, this leadership work is invisible in many policy analyses because it occurs prior to formal structures. Yet without it, shared governance cannot materialize, backbone capacity cannot be trusted, and partners—particularly employers and postsecondary institutions—remain skeptical that collaboration will outlast individual champions. In this sense, early facilitation and convening function as a form of civic risk

capital: an investment in trust, process, and shared purpose that precedes—and makes possible—later institutionalization.

This catalytic phase also depended on key allies across sectors—individuals with sufficient institutional credibility to translate collaborative intent into sustained engagement. In the RAZ-32 context, this included employer and postsecondary leaders such as Reid Health’s Jason Troutwine and Ivy Tech Richmond Chancellor Chad Bolser, whose willingness to co-design across institutional boundaries reinforced the legitimacy of the effort. Parallel dynamics appeared in other Indiana regional collaborative examples, including Pam Morrison at Beacon Health and Tom Kavanaugh at the Northern Indiana Workforce Board in Elkhart. While these relationships were cultivated among partners themselves, skilled facilitation—through structured convening, bilateral check-ins, and transparent sense-making—played a critical role in building trust, surfacing tensions, and sustaining momentum toward shared outcomes.

Within this policy context, Indiana’s Secretary of PK–20 Education, Dr. Katie Jenner, invited regional leaders to present the RAZ-32 model as a developing proof point of what multi-district, employer-anchored pathway infrastructure can make possible when governance, operations, and partner commitments are formalized. This state-level validation was reinforced through the Vision in Action: Driving Workforce Innovation & Education Transformation convening in Randolph County, where Dr. Jenner served as keynote and publicly elevated RAZ-32—including its LPN-by-graduation pathway—as an emerging example of regionally governed, employer-anchored pathway infrastructure. Public-facing documentation of the convening—including the agenda, partner materials, and archived web resources—illustrates how regional collaboratives translate shared governance and employer engagement into visible, legible civic-economic infrastructure (Vision in Action Regional Partners, n.d.).

In addition to the Indiana-based implementation artifacts referenced above, Appendix includes selected public-facing materials from national convenings and media engagements that situate the RAZ-32 model and its intermediary governance logic within broader field dialogue. These materials are included as contextual documentation rather than as independent empirical evidence. They include my panel contribution at the 2025 National Youth Apprenticeship Summit, hosted by New America, where RAZ-32 was discussed alongside national strategies for youth apprenticeship and healthcare workforce development, as well as two episodes of the Rural Innovation Series podcast that place RAZ-32 within wider conversations about rural systems change and intermediary design. One episode features Randolph Eastern Superintendent Aaron Black, reflecting on the catalytic leadership and cross-district coordination required to initiate regional collaboration prior to formal authorization (Black, 2024); the other features my own reflections on intermediary governance, policy alignment, and the practical work of translating regional design into durable infrastructure (Hall Riggins, 2024). Together, these engagements document how RAZ-32 has functioned as a developing proof point in regional and national conversations—illustrating how HQIF-aligned intermediary infrastructure is

interpreted, translated, and tested in practitioner-, employer-, and policy-facing settings beyond a single research site.

These materials are included not as evaluative evidence of outcomes, but as documentation of how intermediary design choices travel across contexts, attract cross-sector scrutiny, and contribute to field-level sense-making. Collectively, they illustrate how regional, employer-anchored pathway infrastructure—particularly in rural healthcare—has become a focal point for national discussion about scale, equity, and durability in education-to-employment systems. As with other Appendix artifacts, these sources are analyzed reflexively as practice-based evidence of intermediary maturation rather than as primary data.

Through shared governance routines and formal partnership commitments, participating districts agreed to support a new healthcare pathway hosted at one of the founding districts. The pathway was intentionally designed to:

- - begin as early as middle school through structured career awareness and exploratory experiences;
 - offer coherent high school pathways integrating dual credit coursework with Ivy Tech Community College;
 - provide supervised clinical rotations and paid work-based learning placements in partnership with Reid Health and other regional employers; and
 - enable students to earn Licensed Practical Nurse (LPN) credentials by graduation, with clearly articulated bridges to Registered Nurse (RN) licensure and specialty certifications.

Importantly, advancement beyond the LPN credential was designed to be financially accessible. Employer-sponsored tuition assistance—such as Reid Health’s tuition reimbursement for incumbent and emerging workers—was explicitly integrated into pathway planning, reducing cost barriers for students while aligning workforce investment with long-term regional retention of homegrown talent.

This pathway design was supported by parallel investments in postsecondary and employer infrastructure. Ivy Tech Community College–Richmond launched a new healthcare education center designed to expand clinical training capacity and reduce geographic barriers for rural learners, explicitly aligning its programming with regional workforce demand (Ivy Tech Community College, 2024a). Concurrently, Reid Health deepened its role as an employer-partner by integrating advanced clinical learning environments and virtual-care technologies across its facilities—signaling a long-term commitment to workforce development embedded in care delivery rather than episodic hiring (HelloCare.ai, 2024). Together, these investments reinforced the feasibility of a regionally coordinated healthcare pathway by aligning instructional capacity, clinical placement, and employer demand within a shared regional context.

The HQIF provides a useful lens for interpreting both the promise and the vulnerability of the RAZ-32 prototype—particularly in Domain 1 (Leadership, Governance, and Public Purpose) and Domain 3 (Backbone Capacity, Facilitation, Operations, and Braided Finance). Structurally, RAZ-32’s

decision to incorporate as a separate 501(c)(3) signals an ambition to function as a durable regional intermediary rather than a time-limited program. However, intermediary durability is not produced by legal form alone; it depends on governance design and operational backbone capacity capable of holding cross-sector decision rights over time.

In HQIF Domain 1, “Leadership, Governance, and Public Purpose,” RAZ-32’s governance has periodically risked collapsing into a school-centered CTE initiative rather than a fully braided education–employment system. In practice, formal decision rights have remained concentrated primarily among district leaders, while higher education and employer partners have participated in advisory and influence roles rather than as co-governors with shared authority. This configuration has still produced meaningful gains, including clearer employer-facing value propositions and ROI considerations within regional measurement. However, it remains vulnerable to a predictable failure mode: when shared public purpose is not structurally protected through distributed cross-sector governance, intermediary work can drift toward the priorities, metrics, and operating rhythms of the most institutionally dominant sector.

In Domain 3, “Backbone Capacity, Facilitation, Operations, and Braided Finance,” RAZ-32 also illustrates a second vulnerability: the difference between simply “having a director” and possessing true backbone capacity. When backbone leadership and facilitation are configured as part-time or layered onto another institutional role, convening can remain episodic, employer co-design under-resourced, and operational routines dependent on individual bandwidth rather than institutionalized practice. From an HQIF standpoint, the lesson is not that RAZ-32’s approach is flawed, but that its next maturation step likely involves strengthening backbone capacity and clarifying shared decision rights across sectors so the initiative can withstand leadership turnover, competing institutional incentives, and the gravitational pull of school-centered programmatic priorities that can reassert themselves in the absence of shared cross-sector authority. One implication—tested more fully in other developing proof points in Indiana—is that anchoring backbone functions within a trusted incumbent regional institution (such as an education service center or workforce board), while formalizing cross-sector governance and guardrails, may increase durability and reduce the administrative overhead of creating new entities solely for coordination.

Vision Corner—a physical hub and collaborative space in Union City—became both symbol and vehicle for this work. It houses simulated healthcare learning environments (e.g., a practice hospital trauma floor, nurses’ station, and EMT practice space) made possible through braided investment across regional development funds, school improvement grants, and significant in-kind employer contributions from Reid Health (Ivy Tech Community College, 2024a; Ivy Tech Community College, 2024b). These instructional assets are complemented by Reid Health’s concurrent investments in smart-hospital and virtual care infrastructure, which expand the scope and realism of clinical learning while reinforcing the region’s long-term commitment to healthcare innovation and workforce development (HelloCare.ai, 2024).

Vision Corner also functioned as a catalytic platform for regional capacity-building beyond Indiana. Through an Innovation Fund investment, a cross-sector delegation of 8 Indiana leaders—representing K-12 districts, higher education, employers, and intermediary leadership—participated in the CEMETS Education Systems Reform Lab’s Summer Institute. This experience accelerated shared technical understanding of youth apprenticeship design, governance, and quality standards, directly informing the region’s decision to pursue an LPN-by-graduation pathway embedded within a broader learn-and-earn nursing model. Rather than importing a foreign system wholesale, the CEMETS engagement strengthened local design capacity, enabling Indiana partners to adapt apprenticeship principles to rural context, regulatory constraints, and youth-centered priorities. Public documentation of Vision Corner’s development—including Ivy Tech’s framing of the project as a place-rooted pathway hub rather than a standalone facility—underscores how regional partners intentionally positioned the site as shared civic and workforce infrastructure serving students across districts rather than a single institutional owner (Ivy Tech Community College, 2024b). Together, these investments reinforced the feasibility of a regionally coordinated healthcare pathway by aligning instructional capacity, clinical placement, and employer demand within a shared regional context.

Employers describe the value of this structure not only in terms of filling positions, but in terms of community continuity. As one health system leader explained, “We’re not just hiring employees; we’re investing in neighbors who will still be here ten years from now.” Students similarly experience the pathway as a bridge between aspiration and place. In one RAZ-32 pitch competition, a student emphasized, “I used to think I had to leave to become a nurse. Now I can see a way to stay, help my community, and still grow my career.” This is a civic—economic statement: a young person naming both livelihood and belonging as legitimate design outcomes.

Within this setting, students do more than complete clinical checklists. They participate in pitch competitions, advise on pathway design, and offer feedback on schedules, supports, and workplace culture. This work is explicitly aligned with Healing-Centered Engagement (Ginwright, 2018): students and families are not treated solely as sources of needs data, but as co-theorists of what a coherent system should feel like. Trauma is acknowledged at structural and interpersonal levels; joy, purpose, and belonging are positioned as legitimate outcomes of system design rather than incidental byproducts.

Viewed as a whole, these design choices position RAZ-32 to aspire towards functioning simultaneously as:

- **a talent pipeline strategy** (filling critical healthcare roles);
- **a regional development initiative** (stabilizing the local workforce and strengthening place-rooted opportunity); and
- **a democratic classroom** (where youth, educators, employers, and civic leaders rehearse shared governance and shared responsibility).

The historical record of U.S. apprenticeship policy demonstrates that fragmentation repeatedly undermines durability: expansions rely on pilots more than architecture, and employer involvement can remain inconsistent or exclusionary when systems do not make engagement legible and worthwhile (Clark, 1992; Marshall, 1995). What differentiates RAZ-32 in this dissertation is not that it “has apprenticeships,” but that it is attempting to build the institutional conditions—governance, standards, and coordination—through which apprenticeship and work-based learning become reliable and equitable at regional scale. The case therefore supports the argument that the unit of change is not a program but the quality of the intermediary layer—what this dissertation formalizes as HQIF.

4.4 Core Features of HQIF-Aspirational Regional Collaboratives: Building the Highway Between Education and Employment

The formation of a regional collaborative is never merely technical; it is relational, political, and dependent on civic capacity—or the will to surface and steward civic capacity that already exists but has not yet been collectively organized or realized. Early design choices—who convenes, who is invited first, who serves as a coordinating backbone, and how decision rights are distributed—shape the initial trajectory of collaboration, but they need not predetermine its future. What matters most is not the availability of additional time, energy, or goodwill, but whether systems are designed to make latent civic capacity actionable—by reducing duplication, clarifying roles, and creating shared forums where effort can be pooled rather than repeatedly expended in isolation. When governance and facilitation are structured to do this work, collaboration becomes less burdensome over time, not more. It is this shift—from heroic individual effort to shared civic infrastructure—that allows cooperation to overtake competition and enables a coalition of the willing to mature into durable civic-economic capacity rather than a temporary alignment of overextended actors.

Across the regional collaboratives examined in this dissertation—including RAZ-32, countywide Work-Based Learning hubs such as Elkhart County’s, Whitley County’s CTE Collaborative work, and Indiana’s policy-ready Multi-Sector Collaborative design—several core features consistently appear in efforts aspiring toward HQIF quality. Together, these features function like a regional highway system between education and employment: clear lanes, predictable on-ramps, and shared rules of the road, rather than a maze of disconnected local streets. In the language of collective efficacy, they institutionalize shared norms, decision routines, and mutual accountability that make coordinated action durable rather than episodic (Sampson, 2012).

First, HQIF-aspiring collaboratives operate across multiple school districts to achieve economies of scale that no single institution can sustain alone. In small or mixed urban-rural regions, individual districts often lack sufficient enrollment, staffing, or employer density to support specialized pathways, clinical experiences, or high-quality work-based learning independently. By aligning calendars, credit articulation, advising tools, and employer engagement across districts, regional collaboratives pool demand and capacity while preserving local governance. This multi-district architecture reflects labor-market reality—employers recruit from a regional shed, not a

single attendance boundary—and allows public systems to respond without resorting to consolidation or competitive duplication.

Second, HQIF-aligned collaboratives reframe employer engagement as system design rather than episodic participation. Across the Indiana cases, employers are rarely resistant to engagement; they are responding rationally to fragmentation. Disaggregated systems impose high transaction costs: multiple points of contact, inconsistent expectations, uneven quality, and unclear value. HQIF-aspiring collaboratives reduce these costs by organizing the education side into coherent structures and creating a clear regional “front door” for employers. Engagement shifts from guest speaking or isolated placements toward co-design of roles, competency expectations, placement systems, and feedback loops—making participation legible, efficient, and valuable over time.

Third, HQIF treats backbone capacity as essential infrastructure rather than administrative overhead. Regional collaboratives require a staffed intermediary layer responsible for convening partners, managing governance routines, coordinating employer engagement, aligning resources, and supporting continuous improvement. Without this capacity, collaboration defaults to compensatory heroics: extraordinary counselors, relationship-rich teachers, or individual superintendents absorbing system failures through personal labor. In a political economy characterized by high churn, thin staffing, and declining institutional trust, reliance on individual effort is both inequitable and unsustainable. HQIF therefore positions backbone capacity as a precondition for durability rather than an optional enhancement.

Fourth, HQIF-aspiring collaboratives formalize shared decision-making through codified agreements that replace fragmentation with collective architecture. In many regions, misalignment is addressed through a proliferation of bilateral memoranda—one school with one employer, or parallel agreements among schools, intermediaries, and agencies—creating what practitioners often experience as “MOU fatigue.” While these agreements may temporarily patch gaps, they multiply administrative burden without producing system-level coherence. HQIF reframes MOUs, charters, and compacts as civic-economic infrastructure: instruments that clarify decision rights, fiscal responsibility, quality standards, and a small set of shared North Star indicators that reflect mutual value across sectors. Education partners remain accountable for matriculation, persistence, and achievement; employers define and assess return on investment through talent development, role quality, retention, and efficiency; and intermediaries are accountable for coordination, equity, and system health. When facilitated with care, these agreements operationalize collective efficacy by translating trust into enforceable routines and shared responsibility rather than parallel effort.

Fifth, HQIF-aspiring collaboratives align pathways to labor-market demand through a dignity standard rather than demand alone. While high-wage, high-growth sectors such as healthcare, advanced manufacturing, and information technology are prioritized, HQIF insists that pathways lead to roles capable of sustaining family life, supporting upward mobility, and

allowing young people to remain place-rooted by choice rather than constraint. This emphasis reflects the youth voice documented earlier in the dissertation: students distinguish sharply between work and good work, seeking stability, purpose, and agency rather than placement alone. Labor-market alignment, in this frame, is inseparable from civic legitimacy.

Sixth, HQIF-aligned collaboratives intentionally bridge K-12, postsecondary education, and employers through coherent work-learn-earn pathways. Dual credit, industry-recognized credentials, youth apprenticeship, and paid work-based learning are designed to stack, signal value, and reduce dead ends rather than operate as disconnected experiences. This dissertation explicitly rejects the caricature of work-based learning as narrow job training. In the cases examined here, work-learn-earn experiences function as sites of civic development where young people practice responsibility, negotiation, ethical judgment, and collective problem-solving—capacities associated with both democratic participation and workplace leadership.

Finally, HQIF-aspiring collaboratives rely on shared data and transparent measurement to support collective learning rather than surveillance. Enrollment, persistence, credential attainment, paid work-based learning hours, placement outcomes, and equity indicators are reviewed through governance routines designed to surface patterns, guide improvement, and reinforce shared accountability. When used well, shared measurement becomes a collective mirror; when misused, it risks reproducing hyper-capitalist logics that reduce students to outputs and communities to labor reservoirs. HQIF therefore emphasizes guardrails that ensure data strengthens belonging, fairness, and public purpose alongside efficiency. This section establishes the design logic that Chapter Five formalizes into the High-Quality Intermediary Framework itself—specifying what intermediary quality must mean if regional collaboratives are to produce not only economic mobility, but durable civic renewal.

4.5 Collective Governance as Civic Learning

As established in Chapters Two and Three, agency is learned in practice. Regional collaboratives are not merely economic engines; they are also democratic classrooms. When students co-design pathway features, present pitches to employers, provide feedback on work-based learning experiences, or serve in governance-adjacent roles, they rehearse the habits of public life—deliberation, coalition-building, compromise, and shared accountability. This matters because the civic stakes of pathways work are often misunderstood in current political discourse. Critics sometimes frame apprenticeships and work-based learning as a narrowing of education—reducing young people to technical labor for the market. Yet the youth evidence in this dissertation argues something else: young people want power, policy literacy, and participation. As students put it earlier in this dissertation: “School prepares us for capitalism, not for power,” and “We’re not [just] learning about power here. We’re learning how to use it.” These statements are not anti-work; they are anti-disempowerment. They call for pathways that produce community members and civic actors, including union organizers and policy advocates, not only employees.

From a Critical Policy Analysis (CPA) perspective, embedding youth voice into governance counters deficit framings of marginalized youth as passive “clients.” Instead, young people become co-theorists of public systems, shaping the policies and practices that will govern their futures. In Healing-Centered Engagement terms, this is not an add-on; it is institutional repair. State policy can reinforce this civic dimension when it defines work-based learning as structured, standards-aligned, and partnership-based rather than informal job placement. Indiana’s work-based learning guidance emphasizes that experiences should include sustained interaction with industry professionals in real or simulated workplace settings, alignment to competencies, and written partnership agreements/training plans that clarify roles and expectations among students, families, schools, employers, and intermediaries. In practice, HQIF-aspiring collaboratives make such definitions usable: they translate policy language into local agreements, training plans, quality expectations, and coherent pathways rather than disconnected episodes.

Within this dissertation, VOICES functions not as a labor-market intermediary, but as a civic one: its contribution lies in governance learning, narrative power, and youth legitimacy rather than pathway coordination or employer aggregation. This distinction matters, because it clarifies how different intermediary forms contribute complementary capacities within a broader civic-economic ecosystem.

Operationally, collective governance around pathways and WBL becomes civic learning: stakeholders co-interpret policy, negotiate tradeoffs (e.g., depth versus breadth of experiences), and build shared norms about what counts as meaningful work. That interpretive work—done with nuance, transparency, and care—is facilitation as civic infrastructure: a prerequisite for HQIF-level governance. Seen this way, intermediary governance becomes a civic curriculum: the structure through which youth learn how power is exercised, shared, or withheld in real institutions.

4.6 Intermediary Translation: From Youth Voice to Public Narrative and Policy

A central finding of this dissertation is that youth civic development deepens when young people are positioned not only as participants in programs, but as producers of public knowledge—capable of shaping narrative, diagnosing institutional failure, and proposing policy alternatives. In the VOICES Youth Fellows cohort, this shift from participation to authorship was made visible through two complementary forms of youth-produced artifacts: (1) nationally published public commentary, and (2) a formal, youth-authored policy proposal addressing mental health access in Indiana schools.

Several Youth Fellows published first-person analyses through New America’s Indianapolis platform, a nationally recognized policy and research organization whose blog reaches state and national audiences of policymakers, researchers, and practitioners. These posts functioned not as reflective journaling, but as civic interventions—youth entering public discourse to contest dominant framings of power, safety, and institutional responsibility.

In “Youth Charge: One Young Hoosier’s Journey to Become an Advocate,” a Youth Fellow describes learning to navigate political systems not as abstract civics content, but as lived power:

- ◦ “Before this, politics felt like something happening to us, not something we could shape. Now I know how to speak in rooms where decisions are actually made.”

This articulation echoes themes surfaced in Chapter Three, where youth distinguished sharply between schooling that prepares students for compliance and learning spaces that cultivate agency. Here, however, that distinction moves from analysis to enactment. The act of publishing on a national platform reframes youth voice as legitimate policy knowledge—visible beyond local audiences and durable beyond the program itself.

Similarly, in “Rethink Sex Ed to Curb Violence,” a Youth Fellow connects personal experience, structural gaps, and policy consequence:

- ◦ “When schools avoid talking honestly about consent and healthy relationships, they don’t stay neutral—they leave young people vulnerable.”

This framing reflects a sophisticated causal analysis: violence is not an individual failure, but an institutional outcome shaped by curricular omission and policy avoidance. Rather than appealing solely to empathy, the author positions education policy as a preventive public health intervention—an analytic move typically reserved for adult experts. In doing so, youth are not only narrating harm, but diagnosing system design failures and naming policy responsibility.

These public-facing artifacts are analytically significant for two reasons. First, they demonstrate that youth civic learning extended beyond internal program spaces into external arenas of public legitimacy. Second, they show that youth analysis traveled across formats—storytelling, argumentation, and policy logic—rather than remaining bounded within a single expressive mode.

That analytic breadth is further evidenced in a separate youth-authored policy proposal developed by a different subset of Youth Fellows: Youth-Led Evaluation and Solutions to Mental Health Care in Indiana Education Systems. Unlike the blog posts, which intervene in public narrative, this document operates squarely within the grammar of formal policymaking. It assembles epidemiological data, fiscal constraints, counselor-to-student ratios, licensure requirements, and statutory amendment language to advance a concrete redesign of Indiana’s school-based mental health infrastructure.

The proposal’s structure mirrors legislative conventions—“WHEREAS” clauses grounding the problem in empirical evidence, followed by specific amendments to Senate Bill 246 and proposed implementation mechanisms. Youth authors identify systemic contradictions (expecting schools to manage mental illness without training or staffing), equity barriers (transportation, insurance acceptance, cultural stigma), and institutional misalignment

(counselor ratios exceeding ASCA recommendations by more than double). They then advance solutions that redistribute responsibility across schools, community mental health centers, and the state—rather than locating failure within individual students or families. In doing so, youth learned the structure and language of policymaking itself as part of their civic and advocacy development.

Viewed together, these artifacts—national blog publications and a formal policy proposal—constitute evidence of youth functioning as institutional actors rather than advisory participants. They are not merely expressing opinion; they are producing civic infrastructure in miniature—public narratives that shift discourse and policy texts that specify governance change. Survey findings further corroborate this shift from participation to governance. Across measures of civic confidence, institutional understanding, and engagement behaviors, youth reported increased capacity to articulate policy positions, identify decision-makers, and participate in civic and political processes beyond the program itself—indicating not only expanded opportunity for voice, but a reframing of youth identity as legitimate civic actors whose analysis could travel into public and institutional arenas.

From a Healing-Centered Engagement perspective (Ginwright, 2018), this movement from lived experience to institutional redesign is not incidental—it is central to healing itself. Youth healing here is not framed as withdrawal from systems, but as re-engagement with them under altered power conditions. Likewise, from a Critical Policy Analysis lens, these artifacts disrupt deficit-based framings of system-involved youth by demonstrating their capacity to generate legitimate policy knowledge and to critique institutions without reproducing cynicism or disengagement.

Most importantly, these youth-produced outputs make visible a throughline that runs across this dissertation: when young people are invited into consequential roles—authorship, analysis, and agenda-setting—the boundary between civic learning and system change begins to dissolve. Youth are no longer preparing for future participation; they are actively reshaping the civic and educational institutions that govern their present. The full text of youth-authored public commentaries published through New America's Indianapolis platform, along with the youth-authored mental health policy proposal referenced here, are included in Appendix as analytic artifacts. These artifacts illustrate how intermediary-facilitated structures can convert youth analysis into durable public knowledge and institutional uptake, rather than leaving civic learning confined to individual development or programmatic space.

In addition to qualitative focus groups and youth-authored civic artifacts, this chapter draws on a supplemental survey administered to participants in the Statewide Youth Policy Fellowship. The survey was designed to assess how youth experienced key dimensions of Healing-Centered Engagement—including identity affirmation, belonging, adult-youth relationality, civic confidence, and perceptions of institutional power—rather than to evaluate discrete program outcomes.

Survey items examined youth perceptions of civic efficacy, sense of belonging, identity recognition, and engagement in civic actions such as policy advocacy, organizing, and dialogue with decision-makers. Taken together, these responses provide interpretive triangulation: they help explain how youth were prepared to produce the public narratives and policy artifacts analyzed in this chapter. The survey is therefore treated not as standalone evidence of effectiveness, but as contextual data that illuminates the relational and developmental conditions under which youth analysis translated into institutional engagement.

4.7 The National Field: Convergence, Gaps, & the Intermediary Quality Problem

Across the national landscape, “intermediary” has become a ubiquitous but imprecise term. Jobs for the Future (JFF) and networks such as PAYA, Advance CTE, the National Governors Association, and Aurora Institute converge around enabling functions: cross-sector partnership, governance and leadership, quality assurance, equity and access, infrastructure and capacity, and shared measurement.

Yet three persistent limitations remain in the field:

- **1. Structural ambiguity**
Many intermediaries are described loosely as “connectors” or “brokers,” with limited clarity about governance, legal form, and decision rights. It is often unclear who can make binding decisions about pathways, funding, schedules, or data across multiple institutions.
- **2. Data scarcity**
Evidence of impact is frequently narrative rather than comparative. Few intermediaries are assessed across shared indicators or benchmarked across regions in ways that enable learning about relative effectiveness.

Recent field learning reinforces this “data scarcity” constraint as structural rather than incidental. In the early work of the Launch Initiative, seven Impact Cohort site teams completed a cross-system data capacity assessment. In synthesizing results across these sites, national partners found that limitations in available data and ineffective data sharing frequently constrained programmatic decision-making—hindering partners’ ability to identify learner barriers and intervene to support access, persistence, and success across pathways (Education Strategy Group, 2025).

Education Strategy Group’s synthesis, *Smarter Systems, Stronger States*, responds directly to this pattern by identifying “smart opportunities” for state investment: strengthening cross-system data infrastructure, building state and local data literacy, investing in usable tools for data collection and sharing, shifting from compliance-driven reporting toward strategic quality assurance, and leveraging disaggregated data to better serve learners across education-to-employment systems (Education Strategy Group, 2025).

- **1. Scope creep**
Some intermediaries remain programmatic—managing a discrete

grant—while others claim system roles without durable authority, financing, or facilitation capacity to sustain them.

While these limitations often appear together in practice, this section briefly elaborates data scarcity as a representative constraint—because it most directly shapes evaluation, learning, and public investment decisions across intermediary forms.

These gaps are not merely technical; they are ideological. In a policy climate where higher education is increasingly framed as valuable only insofar as it produces immediate labor-market returns, intermediary ambiguity and scope creep unintentionally reinforce the false binary between economic alignment and civic formation. HQIF counteracts this framing by treating identity development, shared governance, and youth civic agency as non-negotiable dimensions of quality—guardrails against reducing education-to-employment systems to narrow job-training pipelines rather than democratic institutions.

Even in leading examples, intermediary quality is not consistently articulated in a way that supports codification, evaluation, and sustainable public investment. This is precisely the gap HQIF is designed to address: not by replacing existing frameworks, but by specifying the architectural, governance, and relational capacities required for intermediaries to reliably convert fragmented initiatives into coherent civic—economic systems.

Indiana’s MSC policy design effort is useful here not because it is the only or ideal approach, but because it attempts a rare move: translating intermediary practice into policy-ready architecture (definitions, outcomes, funding mechanisms, and evidence tools). In this dissertation’s framing, those artifacts are best interpreted as one state’s attempt to codify an HQIF-aligned collective impact strategy—an attempt to move the field from “helpful connector” to “civic infrastructure.”

4.8 From Collaborative Distinction to Policy-Ready Infrastructure

The High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) reframes regional collaboratives not as a typology to be debated, but as a design challenge to be solved. Rather than asking whether rural alliances, countywide work-based learning hubs, or state-authorized Multi-Sector Collaboratives are “the right model,” HQIF asks a more fundamental question: what capacities must any intermediary possess if it is to reliably convert fragmented programs into coherent civic-economic systems?

This reframing clarifies three distinctions that are often blurred in national discourse. First, HQIF clarifies the unit of change. The unit of change is not a single pathway, credential, or internship slot; it is the regional intermediary architecture that makes pathways legible, equitable, and durable over time—shared governance, staffed backbone capacity, aligned incentives, and routines for learning and accountability. Programs can be replicated quickly; infrastructure cannot. Without durable intermediary capacity, even strong programs remain dependent on heroic individuals and short-term funding cycles, and they revert to fragmentation when leadership turns over or grants expire.

Second, HQIF distinguishes collaboration from infrastructure. Many regions collaborate episodically: they convene task forces, host employer breakfasts, or pilot new programs. Infrastructure, by contrast, is what remains when enthusiasm fades or leadership turns over. It includes formal governance agreements, braided finance strategies, shared measurement systems, and staffed facilitation capacity that together reduce transaction costs for students, families, employers, and educators. One practical expression of this infrastructure question is where backbone responsibilities are housed—whether in a newly created intermediary entity or within an authorized incumbent institution under shared-governance guardrails—because that choice shapes operational capacity, legitimacy, and the ability to scale beyond a single region. HQIF insists that without these elements, collaboration remains fragile—especially in a political economy marked by austerity pressures, workforce churn, and declining institutional trust.

Third, HQIF clarifies that civic purpose is not ancillary to economic alignment. In the current policy climate, education-to-employment initiatives are frequently framed defensively—as a response to labor shortages or economic competitiveness alone. This framing fuels caricatures of work-based learning and apprenticeship as narrowing education into job training, stripping it of its civic, ethical, and developmental dimensions. Yet the youth narratives in Chapters 2 and 3 directly challenge this assumption. Students are not rejecting work; they are rejecting disempowerment. They want pathways that confer dignity, agency, and the capacity to shape—not merely enter—the systems that govern their lives.

Seen through this lens, regional collaboratives that move toward HQIF quality do not hollow out higher education or civic learning; they reconstitute them under contemporary conditions. By embedding youth voice in governance, distributing decision rights across institutions, and formalizing shared responsibility for outcomes, HQIF-aligned intermediaries treat education-to-employment alignment as a site of democratic practice rather than technocratic optimization.

This is why Indiana’s policy-era articulation of Multi-Sector Collaboratives is instructive. The MSC framework represented a pragmatic attempt to translate intermediary practice into policy-ready infrastructure: defining who participates, what outcomes matter, how funds can be braided, and how accountability is shared. In this dissertation, MSCs are best understood not as the conceptual umbrella for the field, but as policy and advocacy attempt to authorize and invest in HQIF-aligned regional coherence. Their significance lies less in their label than in their intent: to move intermediary work from project status toward public infrastructure.

Critically, this move toward policy readiness exposes the political stakes of intermediary design. Legislative authorization does not simply fund programs; it signals which forms of coordination are worthy of public trust and investment. In an era of democratic strain and skepticism toward institutions, the ability to name, evaluate, and govern intermediaries as civic infrastructure becomes itself a form of democratic repair. HQIF offers a way to do so without collapsing into either technocracy or charity—by insisting

that economic alignment, civic power, and relational legitimacy be designed together.

Taken together, these distinctions clarify why intermediary design—not goodwill or activity level—determines whether collaboration matures into durable civic-economic infrastructure. Table 4.1 makes this distinction visible by contrasting common intermediary patterns in the national field with HQIF-aspirational regional collaboratives. The comparison is not a critique of intent or effort; rather, it surfaces the design limits that emerge when coordination remains grant-bound, advisory, or person-dependent, and it specifies the governance, operational, data, financing, and legitimacy capacities required for intermediaries to function as durable public infrastructure.

Table 4.1 Comparison of Typical Intermediary Approaches in the National Field and HQIF-Aspirational Regional Collaboratives

Table 4.1 is intentionally diagnostic rather than evaluative. It does not suggest that “typical” intermediary approaches lack value; many produce meaningful short-term gains and often operate under real constraints. The point is architectural: when coordination remains person-dependent, grant-bound, or advisory, regions predictably struggle to sustain quality, equity, and employer trust over time.

The implication is not that one collaborative type is inherently superior, but that each form requires different protective capacities to guard against predictable failure modes. The next step, therefore, is to ask: which dimensions of intermediary quality are most protective for common collaborative forms in this field? Table 4.2 addresses that question by mapping collaborative forms to their typical strengths, risks, and the HQIF domain(s) most likely to preserve public purpose, equity, and durability.

4.9 Previewing the HQIF Domains: Assessing Collaborative Forms for Intermediary Quality

Synthesizing national field guidance (including PAYA, JFF, Advance CTE, Aurora Institute, and Talent Pipeline Management) with developing proof points in Indiana (RAZ-32, the Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub, and Whitley County’s CTE collaborative work), this dissertation uses a set of HQIF domains to name what “intermediary quality” must entail when intermediaries are treated as civic infrastructure rather than as program support. These domains function as an analytic vocabulary for distinguishing collaboratives that coordinate activity from intermediaries that can steward durable architecture—governance, backbone capacity, braided finance, shared measurement, and legitimacy practices that persist beyond any single grant, champion, or political moment.

Table 4.2 uses these domains in a deliberately limited way: not to “score” collaboratives, but to illuminate a pattern. Common collaborative forms—countywide WBL hubs, rural multi-district collaboratives, CTE consortia, policy-codified multi-sector collaboratives, and TPM employer collaboratives—each solve a real coordination problem. Yet each form also has predictable failure modes when intermediary capacity is thin: collaboration collapses into logistics, compliance, or narrow labor matching; experience quality becomes uneven; and equity gaps widen rather than close. The table identifies which HQIF domain(s) are most protective against those predictable risks for each form.

This preview also clarifies why TPM employer collaboratives are necessary but insufficient for the civic-economic aims this dissertation advances. TPM offers a powerful method for organizing the demand side of the labor market—clarifying competencies, aligning hiring expectations, and reducing transaction costs for employers. But without an HQIF-aligned intermediary that embeds public purpose, equity, youth voice, and cross-system governance, employer collaboratives can unintentionally narrow education to immediate job needs or drift toward extractive outcomes. Linked to HQIF-level architecture, however, TPM becomes a critical subsystem within a broader civic infrastructure—one that aligns employer ROI with student

belonging, mobility, and democratic agency. This distinction becomes clearer when employer collaboratives are examined alongside regionally embedded intermediaries operating across governance, operations, and finance.

The HQIF domains are named here as analytic signposts to support pattern recognition across collaborative forms. They are formally defined and consolidated into the High-Quality Intermediary Framework in Chapter 5 (Table 5.1), alongside companion tools that operationalize quality for practice and evaluation.

A brief comparison across Indiana examples illustrates how HQIF Domains 1 and 3 differentiate collaborative maturity even when all cases are productive in some respects. RAZ-32 represents the most explicit attempt to operate as a durable intermediary institution through separate incorporation and a multi-district mandate; its primary maturation edge is ensuring that cross-sector governance is structurally distributed (Domain 1) and that backbone capacity is sufficient to institutionalize employer co-design, operational routines, and braided finance beyond individual bandwidth (Domain 3). The Whitley County CTE Collaborative is intentionally narrower by design—an inter-district access agreement that solves a bounded seat-sharing challenge. HQIF would theoretically predict that, absent a resourced backbone with cross-sector decision rights, this form can improve access while remaining limited in its ability to drive sustained education–employment system linkage or scale (Domains 1 and 3). The Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub reflects a third configuration: a new initiative anchored within an incumbent regional institution serving as backbone, paired with explicit shared-governance guardrails that distribute responsibilities by function and comparative advantage. Because the Hub is new, claims should remain provisional; however, HQIF would predict that this “incumbent backbone + shared governance” structure may reduce coordination overhead and increase the likelihood of durability and replicability if cross-sector decision rights and operational capacity remain intact over time.

Table 4.2 How Common Regional Collaborative Forms Map Design Strengths, and Strongest HQIF Domain(s)

Read together, Table 4.2 reinforces a central claim of this dissertation: no single collaborative form is sufficient on its own. Countywide hubs, rural multi-district collaboratives, CTE consortia, policy-codified MSCs, and employer collaboratives each solve real coordination problems—but each also carries predictable risks when intermediary capacity is thin. In this sense, the HQIF domains function less as a checklist than as protective design capacities: they prevent collaboration from collapsing into logistics, compliance, or narrow labor matching, and they keep public purpose, equity, and youth agency structurally intact.

This mapping also clarifies how subsystems relate. Employer collaboratives (including TPM) can strengthen the demand side of the labor market, but they do not substitute for cross-system governance, student navigation, or civic legitimacy. HQIF-level intermediary architecture is what allows these forms to operate as mutually reinforcing components of a coherent civic-economic infrastructure rather than as parallel initiatives. The next section turns to the intermediary's core translational work—designing the routines and decision processes that make alignment usable in practice.

4.10 Intermediaries as Translators and Designers

HQIF-aligned intermediaries perform two essential translation functions.

- 1. **Between sectors:** They interpret policy for practice and practice for policy. As Indiana and other states raise expectations for work-based learning, credentials, and verified readiness experiences, intermediaries translate requirements into agreements, placements, schedules, mentor training, and quality assurance routines. Without this translation layer, individual schools and employers remain trapped in fragmentation—each solving the same problems alone.
- 2. **Between system levels:** They bridge local implementation with state and national strategy. Regional collaboratives feed upward evidence about what works while drawing down technical assistance, funding, and policy flexibility. This vertical fluency allows them to function simultaneously as designers (creating new models) and interlocutors (advocating for enabling conditions).

In both roles, intermediaries do more than “connect dots.” They design the lines—the routines, calendars, protocols, and decision processes that make alignment possible in the first place.

4.11 Indiana as a Living Laboratory for Intermediary Design and Civic-Economic Infrastructure

Indiana offers a rare alignment of policy reform, intermediary development, and employer demand that makes it an instructive living laboratory for HQIF-aligned system design. Unlike states where education, workforce, and economic development reforms move on parallel but disconnected tracks,

Indiana's recent policy shifts have created unusually clear signals about what counts—while leaving open the question of how those signals are translated into lived experience for students, employers, and institutions.

At the policy level, Indiana's redesigned diploma and readiness expectations mark a shift from compliance toward capability. By emphasizing verified experiences—such as work-based learning, credentials, and pathway completion—rather than seat-time proxies alone, the state has expanded the range of what can legitimately “count” for graduation and readiness. These signals matter because they unlock practical levers: scheduling flexibility, funding eligibility, accountability alignment, and predictable demand for employer participation. Policy, in this sense, establishes legitimacy and incentive—but not execution. LAUNCH's cross-state learning similarly suggests that even strong pathway agendas are often underpowered by cross-system data infrastructure, limiting states' ability to see learner barriers and improve access and outcomes in real time (Education Strategy Group, 2025).

That execution gap reveals the missing middle of system design. Policy signals alone do not move buses, align calendars, build mentor pipelines, reconcile liability and supervision questions, or ensure that work-based learning is equitable and high quality. Those functions are carried by intermediaries. In Indiana, HQIF-aspiring regional collaboratives have emerged as the civic infrastructure that translates state-level incentives into operational routines that schools and employers can actually use. Across cases, this translation work consistently includes HQIF-aligned functions that make policy usable in practice:

- - **Governance and Public Purpose** (HQIF Domain 1): codified agreements, clear decision rights, employer councils and/or cross-sector steering structures, and recurring review routines that formalize accountability while protecting equity and legitimacy.
 - **Backbone Capacity, Operations, and Braided Finance** (HQIF Domain 3): staffed convening and facilitation, coordinated intake and placement processes, transportation and scheduling logistics, mentor preparation, safety protocols, and continuous-improvement routines that reduce transaction costs for schools, employers, and families.
 - **Policy Alignment, Systems Integration, and Durability** (HQIF Domain 4): deliberate integration of local practice with state and federal policy levers—funding eligibility, diploma and graduation pathway requirements, data-sharing expectations, and accountability incentives—so that reforms reduce fragmentation rather than layering on additional complexity.
 - **Data, Learning, and Continuous Improvement** (HQIF Domain 7): shared metrics on participation, experience quality, and outcomes—reviewed through collective learning cycles rather than compliance alone—with guardrails that prevent reductive output measures from eclipsing belonging and public purpose.

Seen together, these functions clarify why intermediary quality—not policy intent alone—determines whether reform produces coherence or simply adds another layer of complexity.

Across case vignettes from RAZ-32, Elkhart County’s Work-Based Learning Hub, and Whitley County’s pathways work, a consistent pattern emerges. State policy creates legitimacy and incentives. Regional collaboratives make those incentives usable by organizing governance, operations, and relationships at the scale where students and employers actually interact. Employers experience lower transaction costs and clearer value propositions. Students accumulate not only credits and wages, but also social capital, navigational skill, and a more legible sense of how education connects to economic and civic life. In this way, Indiana functions less as an outlier and more as a proving ground. Its experience illustrates how HQIF-aligned intermediaries can convert policy momentum into durable civic-economic infrastructure—and why the absence of such intermediaries leaves even well-designed reforms underpowered.

4.12 From Prototype to Civic Infrastructure: A Practitioner-Scholar Synthesis

The intermediary capacities articulated in this chapter are not abstract ideals; they are synthesized from lived systems leadership across multiple contexts and scales. The regional collaboratives examined here—rural alliances, countywide Work-Based Learning hubs, and policy-ready collaboratives developed through Indiana’s 2024–2025 legislative work—were built through iterative design, negotiation, and learning under real political, fiscal, and organizational constraints. Taken together, these experiences underscore a central insight: intermediary quality is not incidental to outcomes; it is the condition that makes outcomes sustainable and scalable.

Across this work, a consistent pattern emerges. When intermediaries lack formal authority, shared metrics, or facilitation capacity, collaboration depends on extraordinary personal labor. Counselors absorb coordination gaps; employers rely on informal networks; students shoulder the burden of navigating incoherent systems. These compensatory strategies can produce short-term wins, but they are inequitable and brittle. They burn out individuals and leave systems vulnerable to turnover and funding shocks—especially in a political economy marked by high churn, thin staffing, and widespread distrust in institutions. In such contexts, “partnership” can become another form of privatized problem-solving: the public system’s fragmentation is patched through individual heroics rather than repaired through shared infrastructure. Across the Indiana examples, a consistent distinction emerges: collaboratives can solve bounded access problems through agreement alone, but sustained—and scalable—education-employment system linkage typically requires cross-sector governance that protects public purpose and a backbone organization with sufficient operational capacity to institutionalize routines beyond any single leader, grant cycle, or regional success.

A central design question, therefore, is not simply whether to collaborate, but how backbone functions are housed—whether through a newly created entity or through a formally authorized incumbent institution capable of convening across sectors, sustaining operations, and supporting replication beyond a single geography. The Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub illustrates one such configuration: a new regional initiative anchored by a strong incumbent backbone, guided by collective impact tenets, and governed through shared decision-making and co-design—potentially positioning it closer to the employment system than district-led or education-only configurations, though further longitudinal research is needed to assess durability and transferability. For example, RAZ-32’s ability to secure nearly half a million dollars in county funding to support core operations—particularly transportation across districts and access to shared facilities—demonstrates strong local political legitimacy, while also revealing a structural constraint: when intermediary functions are not fully anchored in a cross-sector backbone with regional or workforce-system authority, funding streams may remain bounded to operational necessity rather than expandable toward broader system replication and narrative scale.

By contrast, when intermediaries move toward HQIF quality—codifying governance, braiding resources, embedding youth voice, and institutionalizing shared learning—collaboration becomes less heroic and more reliable. The work shifts from constant reinvention to continuous improvement. Importantly, this shift does not depoliticize education-to-employment alignment; it makes its political economy visible and governable. Decisions about which pathways to invest in, whose labor counts, how costs are shared, and how success is defined become collective questions rather than hidden defaults. HQIF does not claim neutrality; it specifies the governance and legitimacy practices through which regions can pursue economic alignment without surrendering civic purpose.

These findings carry clear implications for research and policy. Quality is not programmatic but infrastructural: the unit of change is the collaborative capacity itself, not the isolated classroom, credential, or placement. Evaluations that ignore the intermediary layer will systematically misattribute both success and failure. Likewise, relational governance is not amorphous or immeasurable; when trust, reciprocity, and shared decision-making are formalized through charters, scorecards, and review routines, they can be assessed, strengthened, and sustained. This reinforces a central policy implication: funding innovation without funding intermediary infrastructure risks recreating fragmentation once pilot dollars expire. Backbone capacity, data systems, and facilitation are not overhead; they are the work.

Ultimately, HQIF-aligned intermediaries represent more than administrative efficiency; they are expressions of civic renewal. They embody collective efficacy—the capacity of communities to achieve shared goals through mutual trust and coordinated action (Sampson, 2012). When intermediaries function well, they instantiate this efficacy through practical mechanisms: steering committees with real decision rights, data routines that support shared problem-solving, public narratives that build legitimacy, youth

leadership roles that exceed consultation, and improvement cycles that normalize adaptation rather than blame.

This is where the civic stakes sharpen. Measurement can reproduce hyper-capitalist logic if it reduces young people to outputs and regions to labor pools. HQIF counters this risk by insisting that operational quality include belonging, legitimacy, and shared power alongside efficiency and scale. Youth participation in governance, transparent decision-making, and public narrative are therefore not ornamental; they are core indicators of intermediary health and democratic integrity. From a Critical Policy Analysis lens, regional collaboratives can either reproduce or disrupt inequity depending on how they are designed. When they center youth perspectives, attend to racial and geographic disparities, and embed healing-centered practices, they help transform public systems from sites of extraction into sites of shared flourishing (Ginwright, 2018).

This is also why the youth voice evidence in Chapters Two and Three remains structurally essential. Students' skepticism—"Why should I vote? They don't care about us."—was not apathy; it was discernment. HQIF exists, in part, to ensure that pathways collaboratives do not inadvertently confirm that skepticism through tokenism or shallow engagement. Instead, they should build governance where voice matters, where decisions are shared, and where economic mobility is braided with belonging and power. In a period when work-based learning and apprenticeship are caricatured as producing "worker bees for the machine," HQIF functions as a design guardrail: framing work-learn-earn not as civic shrinkage, but as one potential route toward civic agency—if, and only if, intermediary architecture protects dignity, distributes authority, and treats young people as co-theorists of the system rather than inputs into it.

Viewed holistically, the practitioner-scholar timeline that undergirds this chapter demonstrates that HQIF is not a static checklist but a developmental target. Regional collaboratives mature toward HQIF quality over time, shaped by context, leadership, and political opportunity. The value of HQIF lies in its ability to orient that maturation—to provide a shared language for what "better" looks like when the goal is not merely placement, but civic-economic renewal. Together, the analysis in this chapter establishes the bridge from practice to framework, setting the stage for Chapter Five's examination of the relational mechanisms—collective efficacy, healing-centered engagement, and identity formation—through which intermediary infrastructure sustains coherence amid ongoing political and economic volatility. These findings are interpreted through an identity-attentive lens that recognizes how race, class, system involvement, and place shape institutional trust—without attributing observed patterns to fixed identity traits or stages of individual development.

4.13 Conclusion: From Project to Permanence

As apprenticeships, pathways, and work-based learning reforms proliferate across the United States, the question is no longer whether to collaborate but how. Regional collaboratives can institutionalize collaboration through governance, data, finance, and culture—transforming competition into

cooperation; pilots into infrastructure; and good intentions into durable civic capacity.

Considered collectively, national frameworks, Indiana's developing proof points, and this dissertation's youth voice findings suggest that intermediaries are not a luxury; they are a precondition for coherent, equitable education-to-employment systems. Yet they also surface a deeper boundary condition. Even the strongest HQIF-aligned collaboratives remain constrained by macro-level political economy: they can realign incentives, redesign regional architectures, and humanize bureaucratic processes, but they cannot by themselves enact progressive tax policy, regulate corporate behavior, or reverse structural inequality. Their work reveals what is possible within existing constraints—and what remains unfinished without broader democratic and economic reforms.

Within those constraints, however, this chapter also advances a pragmatic claim: intermediary quality is portable, even when specific programs are not. What travels across regions is not a particular pathway model, credential sequence, or employer partnership, but the infrastructural functions of a high-quality intermediary—the ability to convene and govern across institutions; align incentives and decision rights; braid resources; standardize where possible while allowing adaptation where necessary; and sustain shared learning over time. Programs must—and should—vary based on regional labor-market demand, postsecondary offerings, demographic context, and the distinct capacities, assets, and complementarities that local partners bring to the table. By contrast, the underlying system architecture that makes coordination feasible and equitable is replicable. HQIF is therefore framed as a transferable quality standard rather than a prescriptive model: it specifies the conditions under which regions can design pathways that fit local context without reproducing fragmentation, duplication, or inequity. While Indiana's developing proof points ground the analysis, the underlying challenge recurs across states—particularly in small-district rural regions facing insufficient scale to build high-quality pathways independently, paired with the civic costs of consolidation and the practical costs of fragmentation. Future inquiry could therefore test how HQIF-aligned multi-district collaboratives translate in other rural geographies, including Tennessee, where in related work I have collaborated with University of Tennessee system partners, including Erin Crisp, now Assistant Vice President for Learner Success and Workforce Pathways, on aligned workforce-pathways innovation efforts.

The preceding analysis positions HQIF-aligned intermediaries not only as labor-market mechanisms but as civic infrastructure. Chapter Five deepens this logic by examining the relational mechanics—collective efficacy, healing-centered engagement, and identity formation—that allow these collaboratives to function as engines of civic and economic renewal and growth.

Chapter 5: Indiana as a Living Laboratory for Cohesive Learning Infrastructure and Intermediary Quality

5.1 Why Indiana Functions as a Living Laboratory

Over the last five years, policy reform, philanthropic investment, and regional collaboration in Indiana have converged to produce a real-time experiment in aligning secondary, postsecondary, and workforce systems. This convergence has not been accidental. It reflects a deliberate shift by state leaders, intermediaries, and employers away from fragmented program delivery and toward more coherent education-to-employment architecture—tested publicly, iteratively, and at scale. Comparative vocational education research emphasizes that apprenticeship and pathway effectiveness depend not on discrete program features, but on the surrounding institutional architecture that sustains coordination across education, labor markets, and the state (Rauner & Wittig, 2010).

Central to this shift is Indiana’s redesigned high school diploma framework, adopted by the State Board of Education in 2024 and scheduled for full implementation by 2029 (Indiana Department of Education, 2024a). The new framework replaces traditional credit accumulation as the primary indicator of readiness with demonstrated competencies validated through postsecondary credit, industry credentials, and work-based learning. The Employment Seal and Employment Honors+ Seal formalize this shift, requiring students to complete rigorous, standards-aligned work-based learning experiences and earn credentials of value aligned to regional labor demand.

State infrastructure has been actively retooled to operationalize these reforms. The Indiana Department of Education’s Work-Based Learning Menu—an agency-issued implementation guidance document used by districts statewide—formalizes a range of work-based learning models and clarifies quality expectations while preserving multiple entry points responsive to uneven district and regional capacity (Indiana Department of Education, 2024b). In doing so, the Menu makes explicit that apprenticeship is only one component of a broader work-based learning continuum, a critical distinction given both uneven employer capacity and the developmental value of multiple on-ramps prior to intensive earn-and-learn commitments.

Together with the redesigned diploma requirements, the Menu increases the volume, diversity, and rigor of work-based learning experiences districts are expected to provide. The Department’s Career Scholarship Account expansions and graduation pathway reporting mechanisms further translate policy intent into district-level implementation, increasing visibility, accountability, and demand for employer-connected learning opportunities (Indiana Department of Education, 2024c). In parallel, the Indiana Commission for Higher Education’s Career Guide, dual-credit alignment policies, and credential tracking systems link secondary coursework to postsecondary attainment and workforce outcomes (Indiana Commission for Higher Education, 2023).

Collectively, these tools move Indiana beyond rhetorical endorsement of pathways toward enforceable, measurable alignment. At the same time, they intensify the coordination burden placed on regions—particularly the expectation that districts independently cultivate, sustain, and quality-assure sufficient employer relationships to meet expanded work-based learning requirements. In the absence of shared intermediary infrastructure

and authorized governance forums, this burden risks reinforcing fragmentation rather than coherence, even amid strong policy intent. Across regions, practitioners consistently report that the volume, pace, and relational labor required to secure, maintain, and quality-assure employer partnerships now exceeds what districts can reasonably carry alone. In response, many regions have turned to intermediary structures and employer-led coordination models—such as Talent Pipeline Management and Employer Provided Innovation Challenges—to aggregate employer demand and reduce duplicative outreach across education and workforce systems (U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation, n.d.-a; n.d.-b). These dynamics help explain the growing reliance on employer-led coordination frameworks and intermediary strategies—examined in Chapter 5—that seek to aggregate employer demand and reduce duplicative outreach under expanding policy expectations.

Indiana’s redesigned high school diploma reflects sustained leadership by the Indiana Department of Education and the State Board of Education—under the stewardship of Secretary of PK-20 Education Katie Jenner—to translate a readiness vision into statewide requirements and implementation supports (Indiana Department of Education, 2024a). This redesign now lives alongside—and in practice helps accelerate—broader cross-sector efforts already underway across the state, including employer-led Talent Pipeline Management (TPM) initiatives coordinated by the Indiana Chamber of Commerce and Workforce Indiana; LAUNCH Phase 1 and Phase 2, which convene state education and workforce agencies, regional intermediaries, employers, and national technical-assistance partners; and philanthropic investments such as the Richard M. Fairbanks Foundation’s iLab Indiana and Indiana Career Apprenticeship Pathway (INCAP) initiatives (LAUNCH, n.d.; Richard M. Fairbanks Foundation, 2025). Collectively, these efforts position Indiana as what this dissertation terms a living laboratory: a state-scale proving ground in which intermediary governance, employer engagement, and pathway infrastructure are being tested in full public view—conditions that make Indiana especially useful for specifying what “high-quality intermediary” must mean in practice.

Indiana’s policy context also heightens the significance of this moment. Biennial budgeting cycles, the phased implementation timeline of the diploma redesign, ongoing Career Scholarship Account expansion, and changes in workforce-region governance and administrative coordination under Governor Braun’s administration have created an unusually synchronized reform window (Governor’s Workforce Cabinet, n.d.). For regional collaboratives aspiring toward the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF), this alignment enables a shift from informal coordination toward codified governance—supported not only by local will, but by fiscal authorization and statewide incentive structures—and positions HQIF as a practical standard for intermediary design, investment, and evaluation.

The sections that follow trace Indiana’s living laboratory in action. Section 5.2 examines how emerging vertical alignment across regional collaboratives, state infrastructure, and national learning networks concentrates responsibility for shared outcomes and creates feedback loops

between policy and practice. Section 5.3 introduces the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) and its companion analytic tools, which serve as the chapter's organizing lens. Sections 5.4 and 5.5 then apply this framework to Indiana's mixed reform landscape: first through a critical case study of iLab and INCAP, and then through a broader mapping of the state's education–employment initiative ecosystem and the coordination pressures it generates. Sections 5.6 through 5.8 distill cross-case structural challenges, empirical lessons, and cautions for intermediary design, situating Indiana's experience within national evidence on mobility, labor markets, and social capital. Section 5.9 concludes by transitioning from laboratory to praxis, setting up the normative and applied questions that animate the chapters that follow.

5.2 Vertical Alignment in Practice: Policy, Practice, & Intermediary Governance

Indiana's intermediary ecosystem operates across three mutually reinforcing levels: regional collaboratives, state infrastructure, and national learning networks. This vertical alignment matters not because it multiplies initiatives, but because it concentrates responsibility for shared outcomes—and creates feedback loops between practice and policy.

At the regional level, collaboratives such as Rural Alliance Zone 32 (RAZ-32), the Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub, and the Whitley County CTE Collaborative anchor implementation in place. These entities braid K-12 districts, postsecondary partners, workforce boards, employers, and civic organizations into shared governance arrangements capable of delivering pathways, apprenticeships, and work-based learning at scale. By pooling infrastructure—employer engagement, advising redesign, transportation coordination, and data use—they reduce competition among districts and lower navigation burdens for students and employers alike. The next section traces how these vertical feedback loops function in practice—how policy becomes usable locally, and how local implementation revises policy in real time.

At the state layer, Indiana has increasingly shifted from program authorization toward infrastructural enablement—using policy design, accountability mechanisms, and incentive alignment to shape how regions organize for pathways and work-based learning. The redesigned high school diploma, Employment Seals, Work-Based Learning Menu, and graduation pathway reporting requirements create demand for intermediary functions that no single district can sustain alone. At the same time, state agencies remain dependent on regional intermediaries to translate these reforms into operable routines—broker employer relationships, coordinate transportation and scheduling, align advising, and ensure equity of access. This interdependence clarifies why intermediary quality matters: when state policy outpaces regional backbone capacity, implementation fragments; when intermediary governance is strong, policy intent becomes usable rather than aspirational.

Indiana's work increasingly both draws from and contributes to peer learning and federal frameworks, as state agencies, regional intermediaries,

and implementation leaders encounter these reference points through efforts such as LAUNCH, Talent Pipeline Management (TPM), and related cross-sector convenings. National efforts including PAYA's Principles for High-Quality Youth Apprenticeship, the U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation's Talent Pipeline Management framework, the U.S. Department of Labor's Career Pathways Toolkit, and emerging apprenticeship-degree initiatives offer shared language, design heuristics, and measurement conventions that help orient employer engagement and pathway development (Partnership to Advance Youth Apprenticeship, 2021; U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation, n.d.-a; U.S. Department of Labor, 2015). These frameworks do not substitute for regional governance or backbone capacity. Rather, they function as learning and legitimating supports: they help clarify intermediary roles, circulate practice-based evidence, and provide reference points through which state and regional actors—including this study's practitioner-researcher—interpret and translate local design choices within broader field conversations. Vertical alignment, in this sense, is less about replication than about sustaining public purpose across multiple scales of action.

Indiana's living laboratory reveals policy and practice shaping one another in real time—state reforms generate demand for intermediary functions, and regional implementation generates practice-based evidence that revises policy. This interplay clarifies, empirically, what high-quality intermediaries must be capable of doing: translating policy shifts into operable routines, coordinating employers at scale, and creating the relational and administrative conditions under which new mandates can be implemented equitably. One visible expression of this feedback loop occurred when regional leaders were invited to present the RAZ-32 model to the Indiana State Board of Education as a developing proof point of multi-district, employer-anchored pathway infrastructure. The presentation situated RAZ-32 not as a pilot program, but as an example of how intermediary governance, shared district commitments, and employer coordination can translate statewide policy intent into operable regional systems. Public artifacts from this engagement—including the State Board meeting recording, slide deck, and agenda—are included in Appendix as implementation and validation evidence rather than as empirical sources, documenting how regional practice enters formal state governance discourse (Indiana State Board of Education, 2025).

The reimagined diploma requirements serve as both a challenge and a catalyst. By elevating work-based learning and credential attainment as required readiness demonstrations within the redesigned diploma framework, the state has signaled that every student should have structured exposure, through a progression of WBL experiences, not apprenticeship alone, to the world of work prior to graduation. For districts long accustomed to measuring success through standardized tests, this shift requires new operational capacity, renewed employer partnerships, and integrated data systems—all hallmarks of high-quality intermediaries.

Indiana's approach reflects a philosophical departure from programmatic reform toward systemic design. The Elkhart WBL Hub Letter of Intent articulates this shift explicitly: "Rather than creating new programs, Elkhart

WBL Hub focuses on creating a cohesive education sector that can activate and engage a cohesive employment sector” (Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub, Contract, December 2025). That statement concisely captures the broader state movement—one in which collaboration overtakes competition as the dominant incentive structure and becomes the operating system rather than an aspirational value.

TPM Indiana reinforces this mindset by translating supply-chain logic into human-capital design. Within employer collaboratives, companies articulate shared talent needs, co-design curricula, and pool resources. The resulting “we will / we will not” agreements establish behavioral norms that mirror those now emerging among school districts: we will share data; we will celebrate collective gains; we will not duplicate services or poach talent. In both cases, collaboration is codified as a professional practice rather than an act of charity. Relatedly, EPIC (Educator and Employer Powered Innovation Challenges) extends employer coordination upstream into classrooms through project-based “innovation challenges,” offering a lower-lift, high-reach on-ramp to employer-education alignment that can complement internships and apprenticeship in regions still building capacity.

Indiana’s living laboratory thus becomes a site where policy and practice are in constant dialogue. Diploma redesign creates demand for pathways and WBL; regional collaboratives and employer collaboratives supply the structures needed to deliver them; and implementation feedback informs the next rounds of regulatory guidance, funding criteria, and technical assistance.

Importantly, regional collaboratives do not diminish the role of the state, nor do they outsource public responsibility to private actors; they operationalize a civic form of shared governance that relies on the strengths of each sector. The patterns emerging across these regions highlight the need for a clear definition of intermediary quality—a gap this dissertation seeks to fill. While Indiana’s collaboratives exemplify promising practice, the field still lacks a codified framework for assessing what intermediaries must reliably do in order to produce coherence rather than complexity.

5.3 From Cohesive Learning Infrastructure to HQIF: A Framework for Intermediary Quality

Building on the definition established in Chapter 4, this section consolidates the empirical and theoretical insights developed thus far into a High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF). The HQIF specifies intermediary architecture as an institutional form rather than a programmatic service, articulating the durable capacities required to steward education-to-employment systems over time. Synthesizing national field guidance (including PAYA, JFF, Talent Pipeline Management, DOL/OCTAE, and the collective impact literature), international research (including CEMETS), and five years of embedded design and implementation work in Indiana, the framework makes explicit what has often remained implicit in the field: intermediaries function as civic institutions. To convert fragmentation into coherence, they must sustain shared governance, durable finance, relational practice, shared measurement, and youth-centered design over time.

This framework did not emerge fully formed. Rather, it reflects a deliberate lineage of practice-informed design, through which intermediary quality was progressively clarified, tested, and refined under real institutional conditions. An early step in this evolution was the Multi-Sector Collaborative (MSC) Proofpoint Scorecard, a practitioner-generated diagnostic tool developed to make intermediary quality visible and discussable through observable indicators and routines. The scorecard surfaced recurring dimensions of collaborative function—such as leadership and governance, program and pathway design, operations and finance, partnership health, communications and visibility, and outcomes—and helped regions move beyond informal collaboration toward more intentional backbone capacity.

Subsequent field learning extended this work by translating practitioner insights into a Cohesive Learning Infrastructure Logic Model, developed through applied design and external review processes including the Learning Landscapes Challenge. The logic model articulated how governance authority, backbone capacity, learning design, and systems alignment interact over time to produce reliability, equity, and scale. Together, the MSC Proofpoint Scorecard and the Cohesive Learning Infrastructure Logic Model functioned as complementary, practice-facing bridges that preceded—and ultimately evolved into—the High-Quality Intermediary Framework.

The HQIF consolidates and sharpens these earlier tools into a unified analytic architecture aligned to the dissertation’s civic-economic emphasis. Rather than replacing the scorecard or logic model, the framework clarifies how intermediary quality can be assessed consistently across contexts while remaining adaptable to place. The retained tools, provided in Appendix, continue to serve implementation purposes, while HQIF provides a common analytic frame for research, policy, and system-level evaluation.

Viewed as a whole, HQIF domains function as protective design capacities. They identify what must be structurally true for regional collaboratives to remain oriented toward public purpose and equity while delivering employer value and measurable outcomes. The framework is not a checklist or scoring system; it is a diagnostic architecture for anticipating predictable failure modes—such as drift toward the dominant sector, brittle coordination dependent on individual champions, innovation layered without ecosystem alignment, and measurement regimes that optimize outputs while weakening belonging and legitimacy.

Table 5.1 Domains of a High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF)

Table 5.1 consolidates these domains as the chapter’s analytic frame, specifying the core design principles, guiding questions, and primary tools associated with high-quality intermediary architecture. The MSC Proofpoint Scorecard and the Cohesive Learning Infrastructure Logic Model translate this frame into practice, enabling regions, funders, and policymakers to evaluate not simply whether activities are occurring, but whether intermediary architecture is becoming coherent, sustainable, and publicly accountable. Importantly, each tool was intentionally designed to remain legible within existing public accountability and investment systems. Together, they can be cross-walked to federal and state frameworks including WIOA and Perkins V, as well as Indiana-specific incentive and measurement systems such as Indiana GPS and READI—supporting durable braiding across regional, state, and federal funding streams rather than reliance on short-term grant cycles.

Across Indiana’s regional collaborative examples, backbone capacity emerges not merely as staffing, but as a set of design decisions that determine whether collaboration matures into infrastructure. Three recurring decision points shape intermediary durability across contexts:

- **Backbone placement and authorization:** Will core intermediary functions be held by a newly created standalone entity, or by an authorized incumbent institution (such as a workforce board, education service center, or community college) operating under shared governance guardrails? This decision shapes legitimacy, scale potential, and access to braided public funding.
- **Decision rights and governance processes:** Which cross-sector decisions are binding—such as pathway selection, quality standards, employer engagement norms, data access, and funding allocation—and which actors hold authority for each? Absent clarity, governance predictably defaults to the most institutionally dominant sector.
- **Operating capacity and institutionalization:** What minimum staffing, data infrastructure, and facilitation routines are required so the system survives leadership turnover and does not revert to school-centered implementation or grant-chasing behavior?

These decision points do not prescribe a single model; rather, they function as design thresholds within the High-Quality Intermediary Framework. The sections that follow illustrate how different configurations succeed—or falter—when these thresholds are insufficiently resolved.

Taken together, when communities build high-quality intermediary infrastructure to align education and employment—grounded in shared governance, braided resources, and youth-informed legitimacy—both systems become more humane and more effective. Schools expand meaningful learning-to-earning pathways, employers cultivate talent without extraction, and young people—especially those furthest from opportunity—experience greater dignity, mobility, and civic belonging. In this sense, the HQIF offers a pragmatic approach to organizing education-to-employment

systems around shared stewardship and institutional responsibility, rather than isolated transactions or individual effort.

5.4 Importing Without Adapting: iLab/INCAP as an Ecosystem Alignment Stress Test

This section examines iLab Indiana and the Indiana Career Apprenticeship Pathway (INCAP) as a case study in what happens when apprenticeship innovation is layered without sufficient ecosystem alignment. Read through the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF), iLab/INCAP functions as a stress test of intermediary design: it surfaces how unresolved decisions about backbone placement and authorization, decision rights, and operating capacity can introduce friction even amid substantial investment and strong stated intentions. This analysis also aligns with scholarship on the changing nature of professionalism in hybrid governance roles, where authority, expertise, and accountability are negotiated across institutional boundaries rather than conferred through traditional professional hierarchies (Evetts, 2011). The critique that follows is not of ambition, but of fit—how models perform when imported into institutional conditions that differ from those that make them work. Comparative VET scholarship underscores that apprenticeship models are not transferable technologies but institutional achievements—dependent on labor-market governance, public investment, and social settlement rather than training design alone (Rauner & Wittig, 2010).

Funded by the Richard M. Fairbanks Foundation and implemented by Ascend Indiana during the period examined in this study, Implementation Lab Indiana (iLab)—in collaboration with CEMETS at ETH Zürich—seeks to adapt elements of Switzerland’s dual-education model to the U.S. context. In 2025, iLab partners launched the Indiana Career Apprenticeship Pathway (INCAP), awarding more than \$1.2 million to twelve regionally based “Connector” organizations designed to strengthen youth apprenticeship coordination and link Industry Talent Associations (ITAs) with local schools (Richard M. Fairbanks Foundation, 2025). The stated aspiration is the creation of a more integrated statewide apprenticeship marketplace.

As documented elsewhere in this dissertation, however, the Swiss apprenticeship model rests on enabling conditions that differ markedly from those currently available in Indiana, including dense employer networks, universal access to transportation and healthcare, and a publicly funded, high-touch advising infrastructure. While iLab has invested substantially in exposure to Swiss practice and technical design translation, these contextual gaps—particularly in transit, advising capacity, and employer return on investment—constrain the feasibility of replicating Swiss-style apprenticeship participation at scale. As a result, regional partners and employers are often asked to absorb additional coordination, financial, and administrative burdens without commensurate infrastructure to offset these costs. The ambition of INCAP is significant; the challenge lies in adapting innovation to ecosystem capacity rather than layering new intermediary functions atop systems that remain under construction.

First, from an HQIF Domain 4 perspective (policy alignment, systems integration, and durability), Indiana's concurrent investment in new intermediary structures—most notably iLab Indiana and INCAP—reveals the risks of layering innovation without fully integrating existing ecosystems. Regional workforce boards, chambers of commerce, economic development organizations, education service centers, and nonprofit intermediaries already broker apprenticeships, coordinate employers, and support students through piecemeal but functioning arrangements. When a single INCAP-designated regional lead is elevated as the primary coordinating entity without commensurate investment in these incumbent actors, role clarity erodes rather than consolidates. In practice, employers may be asked to pay additional participation fees and per-apprentice costs to access services that previously existed through established partnerships, while long-standing intermediaries are expected to absorb added responsibility without added resources. Rather than strengthening what works, such overlays risk duplicating effort, escalating costs, and weakening trust.

Second, from HQIF Domains 2 and 7 (program design and quality; data, learning, and continuous improvement), regional partners consistently reported that statewide efforts have not resolved inconsistencies in apprenticeship training plans, hours of related technical instruction (RTI), or program expectations. Employers described RTI plans ranging from 650 to 1,000 hours for comparable roles—variation that complicates return-on-investment calculations and undermines confidence in program coherence. As one INCAP regional lead noted, this degree of inconsistency “makes it difficult to tell employers what they’re signing up for,” particularly when Ivy Tech, the state’s core RTI provider, is expected to deliver comparable instruction across multiple campuses. These concerns surfaced repeatedly in practitioner interviews. In an October 2025 strategy conversation (practitioner interview/fieldnote, Oct. 2025), an INCAP leader articulated a sentiment widely shared across regions: “One of the core issues that is going to continue to come up is that [the state design team] is trying to solve a problem without respecting the ecosystem that currently exists—the incentives, the challenges, the relationships we’ve already built to solve them.” In the same discussion, the leader added that the model “offers us nothing beyond this \$100,000 to kick it off ... and it’s a ridiculous amount of work” to re-apply for limited support.

Third, viewed through HQIF Domains 6 and 9 (student access, navigation, and equity; contextual adaptation), the comparison to Switzerland highlights a deeper structural mismatch. Switzerland’s apprenticeship system rests on enabling conditions that differ markedly from those currently available in Indiana: dense employer networks with longstanding apprenticeship commitments; robust, publicly funded advising systems; and universal access to transportation, childcare, and healthcare. Indiana lacks comparable structural foundations. The state’s student-to-school-counselor ratio—approximately 1:694—is among the worst in the nation (Indiana Capital Chronicle, 2024), far exceeding the 250:1 ratio recommended by the American School Counselor Association for comprehensive academic and career guidance (ASCA, 2023). Many Indiana families also lack reliable transportation, affordable childcare, or consistent access to healthcare—conditions that materially constrain participation in intensive training

programs such as youth apprenticeship and work-based learning (Indiana Capital Chronicle, 2024).

Observations from the 2024 CEMETS Education Systems Reform Lab reinforced this gap. Swiss apprentices typically meet weekly with pathway counselors, supported by universal transportation systems and a publicly funded, high-touch advising infrastructure. When Indiana participants asked whether comparable supports existed even in rural Swiss regions, CEMETS faculty confirmed that reliable transportation and weekly advising are guaranteed. This comparison underscored how deeply the Swiss model depends on public goods that Indiana does not currently fund at scale—and that iLab/INCAP alone cannot create.

More fundamentally, the Swiss dual-education system rests on political-economic conditions that extend far beyond apprenticeship design. Switzerland sustains comparatively high and progressive taxation, strong public investment in education and training, sectoral coordination through guild-like professional associations, and a long sociopolitical memory that treats craftsmanship, professional formation, and youth transitions as public responsibilities rather than firm-level conveniences. Compulsory-education teachers are among the best paid and most professionally supported in the world; healthcare, transportation, and retirement systems function as public goods; and apprenticeship operates within a broader settlement that tempers profit maximization with long-term workforce stewardship. Absent these enabling conditions, attempts to import Swiss models into the U.S. risk extracting surface features—training plans, branding, or intermediary structures—while leaving intact the political-economic dynamics that shift risk onto schools, families, and young people. Cross-national analyses of vocational education systems similarly conclude that successful apprenticeship economies are underwritten by coordinated governance, public investment, and shared social responsibility—conditions that cannot be replicated through program adoption alone (Tucker, 2019).

Fourth, from an HQIF Domain 4 standpoint, INCAP's reliance on an Indiana-specific "modern youth apprenticeship" model that operates largely outside federally recognized Registered Apprenticeship (RA) has created a parallel system. As a result, most INCAP-affiliated programs do not unlock RA's established advantages, including access to WIOA-aligned supports, standardized wage-progression frameworks, or national credential portability. Practitioners emphasized that this increases administrative effort and employer persuasion costs relative to models more directly aligned with existing federal infrastructure. Where feasible, Indiana should consider designing youth apprenticeship pathways so they can benefit from the strongest elements of the Registered Apprenticeship infrastructure—such as clearer progression norms, portability, and existing incentive and support structures—while still adapting requirements for late-high school and early postsecondary learners. This could include explicit interoperability bridges to Registered Apprenticeship where fit is strong, and/or youth-appropriate apprenticeship degree models that braid paid work, postsecondary credit, and employer investment through existing college and workforce infrastructure rather than creating new parallel systems (National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree, n.d.). Fifth, from HQIF Domains 3 and 5

(backbone capacity; employer value proposition and ROI), sustainability emerged as a significant concern across regions. Manufacturing partners cited participation fees of approximately \$4,000 per student; healthcare employers reported comparable or higher costs, compounded by clinical-placement bottlenecks and faculty shortages. Leaders outside central Indiana estimated that sustaining the model at scale would require \$250,000–\$300,000 annually—numbers untenable without substantial, ongoing state support. As one health-system leader explained, “The second-year ROI is where apprenticeship finally pays off—but the model’s current instability makes that hard to plan for.”

A Critical Policy Analysis (CPA) lens makes clear why these issues are not merely technical. CPA asks whose evidence counts, whose problems are being defined, and who bears the burden of policy experimentation (Welton & Cummings Mansfield, 2020). In the case of iLab and INCAP, core design assumptions reflected state and philanthropic priorities more than the needs of rural youth, first-generation students, or small employers—groups already operating with minimal slack.

Healing-Centered Engagement (Ginwright, 2018) adds that reforms that overlook structural conditions can inadvertently reproduce extractive patterns. When new initiatives require local partners to stretch across multiple pilots without commensurate infrastructure, communities experience administrative fatigue, fragmented relationships, and diminished trust. Thus, well-funded innovation can introduce friction into—or even operate parallel to—the systems they intend to strengthen, particularly when they proceed without intentionally building upon the regional collaboratives already carrying the work.

An alternative, ecosystem-aligned model can be found in the emerging work of the Inter/National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree (I/NCAD). These efforts embed innovation within federally recognized Registered Apprenticeship, leverage community colleges and regional universities as primary intermediaries, offer job-embedded degree pathways aligned with Workforce Pell and dual-credit policy, and reinforce portability, stackability, and long-term mobility. For states facing coordination fatigue, such approaches economize on existing infrastructure—braiding postsecondary systems, RA-aligned incentives, and regional intermediaries—rather than constructing parallel structures that increase transaction costs for employers and schools. Rather than adding a new intermediary layer, apprenticeship degree models braid together what already exists: higher education, federal policy, employer demand, and regional labor markets. In doing so, they align with both Critical Policy Analysis and Healing-Centered Engagement by reducing administrative fragmentation, centering learner supports, and acknowledging the lived realities of low-income and rural families.

A complementary pathway is to organize employer coordination through Talent Pipeline Management-style sector collaboratives with dedicated career navigators. Several practitioners suggested that Indiana’s newly authorized workforce regions—or the INCAP regions themselves—could better meet employer needs through such structures. Done well, this

approach would reduce duplicative employer outreach, strengthen sector-based problem-solving, provide a durable governance home for apprenticeship and broader work-based learning pathways, and mitigate the compensatory burden currently carried by districts—particularly those experiencing fiscal strain due to recent property-tax policy changes.

Read through the High-Quality Intermediary Framework, Indiana’s iLab/INCAP experience underscores a core design principle of this dissertation: models must be adapted to context, not transplanted. The state’s efforts reveal both the potential and the limits of innovation absent a strong intermediary and governance architecture—reminding us that apprenticeship is one high-intensity strategy within a broader continuum of work-based learning, and that both advance equity and mobility only when embedded within coherent civic, economic, and social systems. In practice, this means building HQIF-aligned regional capacity to coordinate the full spectrum of WBL (from career awareness and project-based experiences to internships and youth apprenticeship), so regions can match opportunity design to student interest, employer capacity, and local enabling conditions rather than forcing a single “best” model everywhere. Read through HQIF, the lesson is not “apprenticeship vs. not”—it is that regions need authorized backbone governance, integrated roles, and sustainable operating capacity so WBL options add up to a coherent system rather than a stack of pilots.

By contrast, the Indiana nursing pathway described in Section 6.7 illustrates a different adaptation logic. Rather than introducing a new intermediary layer, regional partners worked through—and strengthened—existing institutions, including Ivy Tech Community College and employer governance structures, while coordinating collective advocacy to the appropriate regulatory authority: the Indiana State Board of Nursing. That process required shared regional decision-making, employer-side policy adjustments, and sustained cross-sector facilitation, but it resulted in formal statewide regulatory change rather than a parallel implementation structure. Read through HQIF, the distinction is not sectoral but architectural: innovation traveled through aligned regional collaboration and authorized policy channels, rather than being overlaid onto an ecosystem still lacking shared governance and backbone capacity.

5.5 Mapping Indiana’s Education-Employment Ecosystem and Coordination Burden

Where Section 5.4 uses iLab/INCAP as a case study in misalignment and contextual under-adaptation, this section maps Indiana’s broader education-employment initiative landscape and the systemic pressures it creates. The abundance of initiatives—across state agencies, philanthropic partners, and intermediary organizations—places strain on employer relationships, local capacity, and regional trust. These pressures reveal the difference between “activity” and “architecture”: without clear intermediary stewardship, even well-intentioned innovations can work at cross-purposes. Table 5.2 maps the major statewide initiatives shaping Indiana’s education-employment landscape, highlighting their respective governance structures, contributions, and points of tension within the broader ecosystem.

Table 5.2 Indiana Education-Employment Alignment Initiatives

As shown in Table 5.2, these initiatives reveal both the abundance and the fragmentation of Indiana's reform ecosystem. The state has succeeded in mobilizing unprecedented public and private investment in pathways and apprenticeships; yet each effort operates with distinct governance, funding streams, and accountability measures.

My critique of iLab and INCAP is therefore not a repudiation of their aims but a call for ecological coherence: new programs must be situated within the living systems of practice already at work. As expressed in conversation with state partners, "You cannot build an alternative system on top of one that's still under construction; the result is duplication, fatigue, and lost trust." A cohesive learning infrastructure demands state-level stewardship capable of braiding these efforts—integrating policy reforms (IDOE diploma redesign), employer-led strategies (TPM, EPIC), and regional collaboratives (RAZ-32, Elkhart WBL Hub, Whitley) into a single, transparent, and mutually reinforcing system.

Interviews with regional partners suggest that Indiana's newly configured workforce boards could play a pivotal role in this stewardship. Practitioners proposed organizing sector-specific employer collaboratives—aligned with Talent Pipeline Management (TPM) principles—under each workforce board, with clear responsibility for convening employers in healthcare, manufacturing, IT, and logistics. These collaboratives could then coordinate with iLab/INCAP's emerging statewide "talent associations" without duplicating their functions, align Registered Apprenticeship, short-term credentials, and "modern youth apprenticeship" models using shared labor-market data, and provide a single point of engagement for schools and intermediaries. Such a structure would begin to supply the labor-market architecture that apprenticeship requires: regional governance, aligned incentives, and predictable backbone capacity.

5.6 Structural Challenges: The Education-to-Employment Ecosystem Under Strain

Having outlined the strengths and strains of Indiana's ecosystem, this section distills the core design elements of a cohesive learning infrastructure—backbone capacity, shared measurement, braided finance, and narrative legitimacy—and analyzes how they emerge from the preceding sections.

The Indiana ecosystem's strength—its proliferation of actors—is also its vulnerability. As one practitioner noted, "either incentives have to be given to intermediaries, especially the long-standing ones who already have relationships with businesses, or at some point INCAP will just shut down the former intermediaries ... because as long as we exist, there is competition." This competition among organizations—workforce boards, education service centers, foundations, and newly created connectors—produces what partners have called coordination fatigue. In interviews, both long-standing intermediaries and newly designated INCAP Connectors described the risk that multiple parallel entities approach the same

employers with overlapping offers, fragmenting relationships rather than consolidating them.

The resulting duplication mirrors the very fragmentation intermediaries were designed to solve. Multiple entities may approach the same employer with similar requests, or design overlapping youth apprenticeship pilots in the same sector without shared standards or data. Practitioners in RAZ-32 and Elkhart WBL Hub describe spending increasing amounts of time “translating between initiatives” rather than improving student and employer experiences.

In regions where Black, Latino, immigrant, and low-income rural youth have experienced generations of underinvestment, the constant churn of initiatives can communicate that systems are experimenting on them rather than investing with them. Healing-Centered Engagement insists that systems-level work attend to collective histories, not just individual resilience: coherence, stability, and genuine voice are themselves forms of healing. Sampson’s neighborhood-level studies in Chicago demonstrate that collective efficacy—shared norms of trust and mutual obligation—helps explain why some communities sustain greater stability even at similar levels of poverty (Sampson, 2012). Complementary research on social capital and mobility reinforces that relational infrastructure is economically consequential: places with stronger cross-class connection and civic trust tend to show higher rates of upward mobility and greater resilience over time. In this light, investments in intermediary governance are also investments in long-run economic resilience.

Amid this strain, Indiana’s living laboratory surfaces a critical lesson: collaboration cannot be mandated through grant guidelines alone; it must be cultivated through clear governance, relational stewardship, and mutual accountability. The Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub illustrates this principle through its operational guardrails, which commit partners to deciding “transparently and collaboratively” and to avoiding duplication of services. These guardrails function not as moral claims, but as practical parameters that clarify expectations of mutuality—what partners commit to contribute, how decisions are made, and how value is both given and received. Without such guardrails, the risk is that well-intentioned innovation erodes trust, leaving communities skeptical of the next “big idea.” With them, intermediaries can differentiate roles, align efforts, and maintain focus on the shared purpose that brought partners together in the first place. Despite its relative newness, the Hub is analytically useful because it shows early HQIF-aligned design decisions in a high-complexity regional setting.

All seven public school districts in Indiana’s sixth-largest county have formally committed to a shared, integrated system alongside the regional workforce board and education service center. The Hub has also clarified sectoral focus and employer leadership, particularly in healthcare, where Beacon Health serves as a designated workforce champion—coordinating employer engagement and convening partners through a Talent Pipeline Management (TPM) lens.

At the same time, these regional models expose the limits of local coordination in the absence of broader structural reform. Even the most aligned partnerships cannot directly counteract the systemic drivers of labor shortages—low wages, limited transportation, rising healthcare costs, and the long shadow of deindustrialization. Nor can they remedy the unequal bargaining power between employers and communities or the volatility created by corporate consolidation in key sectors. While TPM and EPIC offer important mechanisms for employer coordination, better labor-market signaling, and improved project design, they still rely on substantial local capacity and do not replace the policy infrastructure that undergirds more coherent systems abroad. These collaboratives reveal both the power of local agency and the structural barriers that local agency alone cannot overcome.

These dynamics also illuminate a broader truth: the responsibilities intermediaries now carry were never meant to rest solely on schools. Indiana's PK-12 systems—underfunded, overextended, and staffed by educators whose labor is already stretched beyond sustainable limits—cannot on their own resolve the structural drivers of workforce shortages or mobility stagnation. Historically, large-scale economic mobility in the United States was not produced by localized educational effort alone, but by national investments in civic and economic infrastructure—from the GI Bill and the National Defense Education Act to federal mortgage supports and industry-aligned research institutions. High-quality intermediaries do not replace these public goods; they provide the regional architecture that allows education, workforce, and civic institutions to function as a system rather than as isolated sectors.

These structural challenges reinforce the dissertation's central claim: intermediaries are most effective when they operate within coherent civic-economic architectures, not as isolated brokers. The next section outlines what such architecture requires and how Indiana's laboratory is beginning to approximate it.

5.7 Learning Landscapes as a Site of Iterative HQIF Development

The demographic, economic, and institutional conditions described throughout this chapter help explain why intermediary work requires durable civic-economic infrastructure—not just coordination—and why HQIF emerged iteratively through practice and external evaluation. As this dissertation has argued, HQIF provides the analytic framework for assessing that quality. Yet the framework itself did not emerge fully formed. Its development was iterative, shaped through cycles of practice, external evaluation, and design refinement.

One formative arena in that evolution was the national Learning Landscapes Challenge, a competitive initiative focused on identifying and advancing place-based approaches to cohesive learning ecosystems. I applied to the Challenge and led my team's participation as a practitioner-researcher, using the opportunity to prototype and stress-test intermediary design assumptions in real-world conditions. From hundreds of national applicants, our work was selected for Phase 1 (40 teams), and subsequently named one

of five national finalists—an external validation that both sharpened and challenged the intermediary logic developed in Indiana.

Within the Learning Landscapes framing, what the field termed a Cohesive Learning Infrastructure functioned not as a distinct framework, but as a descriptive synthesis of design elements that high-quality intermediaries must operationalize to convert fragmented initiatives into durable systems. Through this process, several core elements repeatedly surfaced as necessary for coherence, scale, and legitimacy:

- **◦ Backbone capacity.**
Regions require a trusted, authorized convener with sufficient staffing and facilitation capacity to align education, workforce, and civic partners. Backbone functions include governance support, work-based learning logistics, employer coordination, and continuous improvement—reducing reliance on individual heroics and enabling collaboration to persist beyond any single leader or grant cycle.
- **Shared measurement and collective learning.**
Coherent systems depend on transparent, shared metrics that span education, workforce, and civic outcomes. When data is reviewed through structured governance routines, it becomes a tool for collective learning and course correction rather than compliance or punishment—reinforcing shared accountability and trust.
- **Braided funding and functional alignment.**
Public, philanthropic, and employer resources must be intentionally aligned to support shared priorities and reduce administrative burden. Treating funding as a design variable—rather than an afterthought—clarifies role differentiation, sustainability, and the conditions under which infrastructure can endure.
- **Narrative and public legitimacy.**
Durable systems require public-facing coherence. Regular communication, shared celebrations, and visible civic leadership help build collective identity and belief in the system's permanence. Narrative, in this sense, operates as infrastructure: it sustains engagement, attracts partners, and reinforces public purpose.

Read through a Healing-Centered Engagement and Critical Policy Analysis lens, these elements extend beyond administrative best practice. Backbone capacity and braided finance shape whose labor is recognized and resourced; shared measurement determines whose outcomes count; and narrative infrastructure influences whose stories define success. A cohesive learning infrastructure is therefore also a site of institutional repair—one that can redistribute decision-making power, surface youth and community knowledge, and counter historically exclusionary system designs.

Crucially, this prototyping phase did not replace HQIF; it informed and refined it. The Learning Landscapes logic model and evaluation criteria helped clarify which intermediary capacities were important, which were

insufficiently specified, and where relational and civic dimensions required stronger protection. HQIF consolidates those lessons into a more explicit quality standard—one that names governance, backbone capacity, employer value, equity, youth co-creation, data use, and place-based adaptation as non-negotiable dimensions of intermediary design rather than optional features.

For transparency, the dissertation references several public-facing materials associated with the Learning Landscapes Challenge, including the Challenge overview, published evaluation criteria, and a team profile interview reflecting on this work (Learning Landscapes Challenge, n.d.-a; n.d.-b; Hall Riggins, n.d.). These materials document the practitioner-researcher learning context through which intermediary concepts were tested, externally reviewed, and iteratively refined. They are cited to contextualize how field-facing language around cohesive learning infrastructure informed the maturation of the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF), rather than to function as independent empirical evidence. Selected artifacts from this process are included in Appendix to support transparency regarding how analytic frameworks evolved alongside applied design and peer review.

Seen in this light, the Learning Landscapes experience represents a developmental waypoint rather than a parallel theory. It offered a structured opportunity to translate emerging intermediary practice into a form legible to national audiences, funders, and policymakers—while revealing the need for a more rigorous, integrated framework capable of holding economic alignment and civic purpose together. HQIF is the result of that synthesis: a framework grounded in lived systems leadership, sharpened through external validation, and oriented toward durable civic-economic renewal.

5.8 Quantitative Context and Design Implications for High-Quality Intermediary Design

Indiana's demographic and economic landscape underscores the imperative for coherent intermediary systems. One in five students in the United States attends a rural school—over 9.5 million students nationally—with approximately 230,000 of them in Indiana. In RAZ-32, 62 percent of students are low-income and 40 percent identify as Hispanic, while regional employers report vacancy rates of 20 to 30 percent in critical healthcare and manufacturing roles. By 2027, an estimated 70 percent of Indiana jobs will require postsecondary education or training beyond high school (Empower Schools Rural Innovation data, 2024).

These numbers illustrate both the scale of need and the potential of intermediary-driven solutions: filling vacancies while expanding purpose-driven, family-sustaining opportunities for young people who have historically been excluded from such pathways. They also reinforce the insight that mobility is shaped as much by who young people can access as by what they know. In counties where low-income students have more ties to higher-income peers and adults, upward mobility is systematically higher; where networks are more segregated, mobility stalls, even when formal schooling levels are similar (Raj Chetty et al., 2022). For rural Indiana regions facing both workforce shortages and youth out-migration, building these cross-class, cross-sector networks through regional collaboratives is

therefore a core economic-development strategy, not a peripheral education reform.

Indiana's living laboratory offers three overarching lessons for the field of education-to-employment system design:

- 1. **Alignment must precede innovation.**
In the regional collaborative cases highlighted here (Elkhart WBL Hub, RAZ-32, Whitley) began by building trust and shared governance before pursuing new programs. Where alignment work was short-circuited, new initiatives often added complexity without increasing impact.
- 2. **Adaptation requires contextual humility.**
As the iLab and INCAP experience shows, transplanting models without attending to social infrastructure—counseling, transportation, family supports, healthcare—risks replicating inequities. As I argued in conversation with state leaders, “you can’t go to an employer already under duress and ask them to take on costs they didn’t budget for ... without first strengthening the ecosystem around them.”
- 3. **Intermediary ecosystems require policy stewardship.**
Without state coordination, multiple funding streams can create competition among intermediaries rather than collaboration. Future policy should incentivize alignment through shared metrics and sustained infrastructure funds, not only through short-term grants tied to isolated pilots.
- 4. **Good jobs are necessary but insufficient.**
Indiana's initiatives underscore that wages, benefits, and advancement opportunities matter (U.S. Department of Labor, 2022; EmployIndy, 2023), but the interviews and youth narratives in this study also point to additional conditions: predictable schedules, supportive supervision, and pathways that connect work to identity, purpose, and civic participation (Mehta & Fine, 2019). As later chapters argue, apprenticeship systems that focus solely on skill acquisition and wage gains—without attention to governance, belonging, and voice—risk reproducing existing inequities rather than transforming them (Osei-Kofi et al., 2021). This analysis aligns with emerging “good jobs” frameworks in federal and state policy (State of Indiana, 2025), while emphasizing that job quality must be embedded within broader civic and educational design if it is to advance long-term mobility.

These lessons reinforce a central conclusion of this dissertation: high-quality intermediaries are not a luxury but a precondition for coherent, equitable education-to-employment systems. Indiana's experience shows both the promise and the perils of attempting to build such an architecture at scale without a clear stewardship strategy.

Across these regional examples, youth voice functions not as a symbolic add-on but as a corrective to structural misalignment. Youth critiques consistently sharpened intermediaries' focus on coherence, access, and credibility—highlighting where education systems failed to connect learning to real opportunity and where economic pathways lacked transparency,

dignity, or agency. In this sense, youth participation strengthened both civic and economic aims by clarifying what it would mean for systems to work as systems rather than as disconnected offerings.

Importantly, the intermediary designs examined here were not uniform, nor should they be. Indianapolis-based civic organizations, rural healthcare collaboratives in Randolph County, countywide hubs in Elkhart, and sector-focused partnerships in Whitley County operate across distinct labor markets, institutional densities, and political contexts. What travels across these settings is not a single model, but a quality standard: HQIF provides a way to assess whether regional collaboratives—regardless of size, sector, or geography—are building durable linkages between education and employment while distributing power, responsibility, and opportunity more equitably. This logic also positions Indiana’s work for national learning through ongoing comparative research and applied reflection with partners such as CEMETS and the Inter/National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree (NCAD).

5.9 Transition: From Laboratory to Institutional Praxis

Indiana’s living laboratory demonstrates that systemic alignment is possible when policy, practice, and philanthropy operate in concert. The state’s experience affirms that progress depends as much on relational stewardship as on technical reform—on cultivating trust, shared measurement, and transparent governance across multiple scales. At the same time, it reveals the limits of structure alone: without shared norms, clear expectations, and sustained relational investment, even well-designed systems risk reverting to transactional coordination rather than durable collaboration.

The next chapter turns from structure to praxis—from the mechanics of system-building to the values and practices that make it enduring. It asks what it means for a “good job” to be not only economically stable, but civically developmental, and introduces Braided Futures, the praxis-based framework and applied systems-design practice I founded to translate the lessons of Indiana’s intermediary ecosystem into a repeatable method for designing civic infrastructure through education-to-employment systems. If Indiana is the laboratory, Braided Futures is the application: a living demonstration of how people, policy, and practice can be braided together to advance equity, purpose, and shared prosperity.

Taken together, Indiana’s regional collaboratives, iLab districts, and INCAP intermediaries illustrate the productive tension between innovation and constraint. They show how regions can organize for coherence, expand opportunity, and strengthen youth readiness. Yet they also illuminate what becomes impossible when the underlying rules of the economy remain unchanged. Without reforms to tax policy, labor standards, and corporate accountability—without mechanisms that redistribute opportunity rather than merely coordinate it—local collaboratives are often left to repair, rather than transform, a system shaped by structural inequity.

This realization frames the chapters that follow, which ask what kinds of political-economic and civic architectures are required for praxis to reach its democratic and economic potential. The relational and civic dynamics

explored here point toward a more expansive view of systems design—one that treats social capital, civic intermediaries, and the politics of identity as inseparable elements of education-to-employment ecosystems. Viewed comprehensively, Indiana’s living laboratory not only surfaces the promise and limits of current reforms; it also provides the empirical grounding for the intermediary framework this dissertation advances.

Indiana does more than illustrate the promise and limits of reform; it provides the empirical foundation for the dissertation’s core contribution: a codified, practice-tested definition of high-quality intermediary architecture. The High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) distills what Indiana’s regions have taught in real time—what intermediaries must consistently do, how they must be governed and financed, and what kinds of civic, relational, and policy conditions allow them to thrive.

At the state level, alignment is shaped by policy design rather than centralized control. Following the abolition of the Governor’s Workforce Cabinet in 2025 (Indiana Governor’s Workforce Cabinet, n.d.), coordination functions have shifted toward agency-based implementation and employer-led strategies aligned with Governor Braun’s economic agenda. INCAP, industry talent associations, and expanded work-based learning guidance increasingly emphasize employer return on investment, regional labor-market responsiveness, and credential portability—heightening the importance of intermediaries that can translate market signals into equitable, youth-centered pathways without collapsing civic aims into narrow labor matching.

At the national level, Indiana’s work is informed by—but not subordinate to—peer learning. North Carolina’s Chamber-led TPM partnerships with university systems, South Carolina’s workforce-board-driven pathway alignment, Colorado’s apprenticeship degree infrastructure, and Tennessee’s statewide career pathways reforms offer comparative reference points. National frameworks such as PAYA’s Principles for High-Quality Youth Apprenticeship, JFF’s work-based learning guidance, the U.S. Chamber Foundation’s TPM model, and the U.S. Department of Labor’s Career Pathways Toolkit provide scaffolding rather than prescription.

From a social-capital perspective, these intermediaries are not neutral technical structures. They are sites where bonding and bridging social capital are actively built—or neglected. As I argued in earlier research (Hall, 2016), bonding social capital strengthens ties within communities, while bridging social capital connects people across lines of race, class, and geography. Regional collaboratives such as RAZ-32 and the Elkhart WBL Hub illustrate the possibility of doing both: deepening trust within local communities while building new bridges between rural and urban districts, employers and educators, and youth and policymakers.

Recent empirical work underscores that these civic relationships are not only normatively important but economically consequential. Research on economic connectedness demonstrates that regions where low-income youth have more cross-class relationships experience significantly higher rates of upward income mobility, even after controlling for poverty and racial

composition. In this light, intermediary design becomes not merely operational, but distributive. Whether Indiana's living laboratory advances equity depends in part on whether intermediaries invest intentionally in bridging across historic divides rather than formalizing existing networks of advantage.

Together, these vertical relationships illustrate a central claim of this dissertation: intermediaries are not ancillary actors but connective tissue. They enable practice-based evidence to flow upward into policy guidance, allow state incentives to become usable locally, and position regional innovations for national learning. These empirical patterns directly inform the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF), which evaluates intermediary quality not by program count, but by durable institutional capacity.

Chapter 6: A New Civic-Economic Infrastructure for American Democracy and Mobility

6.1 From Laboratory to Civic-Economic Commitments in System Design

Chapter 5 treated Indiana as a living laboratory for education-to-employment system design. It illustrated what becomes structurally possible when intermediaries braid people, policy, and practice into durable regional arrangements—shared governance routines, braided funding strategies, employer coordination, and the connective infrastructure required for work-based learning and pathways to function at scale. That chapter also surfaced a central limit: alignment alone does not sustain transformation. Structures can exist on paper while young people still experience opportunity as inconsistent, episodic, or dependent on luck.

This chapter turns from architecture to the civic-economic commitments that determine whether regional systems become reliable in the lived experience of students and families. The question is not simply whether a region can coordinate programs, but what kind of public responsibility those programs enact—who is counted, included, and treated as worthy of sustained investment. In this dissertation, education-to-employment systems are understood not only as workforce strategies, but as civic institutions. They communicate what a community owes its young people, how work is valued, and whether belonging and opportunity are treated as shared public goods or left to individual navigation. Viewed through this lens, system design reflects a region's implicit normative framework—the taken-for-granted assumptions, made visible through resource allocation, governance decisions, and everyday implementation, that shape which futures are treated as interconnected and which are rendered contingent or optional. This framing is analytic rather than moralizing. It does not ascribe intent to individual actors, but attends to how institutional arrangements—often assembled incrementally and in good faith—produce patterned differences in access, reliability, and recognition over time.

The analysis in this chapter is interpretive rather than prescriptive. Drawing on youth narratives and civic artifacts surfaced in Chapters 2-3, and on the intermediary design evidence and ecosystem analysis developed in Chapters 4-5, it examines the civic, ideological, and economic assumptions embedded

in how education-to-employment systems are designed and governed. Using collective efficacy, healing-centered engagement, and democratic professionalism as guiding lenses, the chapter treats students not only as participants but as co-theorists: their accounts clarify what counts as “reliability,” “dignity,” and “public responsibility” in the lived experience of systems.

Students in this dissertation described civic and economic fracture in plain terms: “figuring it out on our own,” adults who cared but were “too busy,” and opportunities that appeared as one-off exceptions rather than predictable pathways. When students did encounter high-quality work-based learning or youth leadership experiences, they narrated those moments as more than instructional successes. They felt “seen,” “trusted,” and “like I actually matter here”—early experiences of agency, recognition, and contribution that functioned as civic experiences as much as workforce preparation.

These perspectives align with widely used job-quality frameworks—such as the U.S. Department of Labor’s Good Jobs Principles and state and local efforts to define wages, benefits, and advancement as baseline expectations. Yet the youth narratives in this study underscore a crucial point: good jobs are necessary but insufficient. Young people also want work that offers mentorship, stability, voice, and a sense of being needed—dimensions that shape not only economic mobility, but civic participation and community attachment over time. When learning systems fail to provide reliable pathways to purposeful work and contribution, students experience that absence as both economic exclusion and civic abandonment.

This chapter therefore widens the analytic lens. It treats regional collaboratives as sites where public responsibility is practiced: where partners negotiate what counts as meaningful work, how opportunity is distributed, and how collective obligations are upheld across lines of district, sector, race, and geography. The sections that follow examine how collective efficacy operates as connective tissue in regional collaboratives; how relational approaches to learning and governance strengthen democratic capacity; and how praxis-oriented intermediary work—including the applied model of Braided Futures—can translate civic and economic commitments into repeatable routines and durable infrastructure.

6.2 Enduring American Ideals: Liberty, Localism, and Shared Responsibility

American political culture has long been characterized by twin commitments to individual liberty and democratic participation—ideals that have fueled both economic ingenuity and civic aspiration. These ideals have given rise to enduring beliefs in local control, limited government, and opportunity through merit. Yet when divorced from structures of equity and shared accountability, these commitments have also produced stark disparities in both democratic voice and economic mobility, especially for those furthest from opportunity.

The modern regional collaborative both reflects and challenges these traditions. On one hand, regional collaboratives respect the American ethos of localism: they empower communities to craft bespoke solutions tailored to

regional needs. In Indiana, RAZ-32, Elkhart WBL Hub, and the Whitley County CTE Collaborative illustrate early attempts to operationalize this local agency—building county- and region-level structures shaped by specific histories, economies, and cultures. On the other hand, regional collaboratives resist the fatalism of market-only logic and the exclusionary instincts of hyperlocalism by asserting that all students—regardless of ZIP code—deserve meaningful opportunities. In this way, regional collaboratives braid together the Jeffersonian vision of an educated citizenry with the New Deal-era idea of government as guarantor of opportunity.

Seen through this lens, regional collaboratives can be read as one contemporary effort to reconcile two enduring American impulses: local self-determination and shared public responsibility. In Indiana, RAZ-32, the Elkhart Work-Based Learning Hub, and the Whitley County CTE Collaborative illustrate communities working toward that balance—building place-rooted governance while also asserting that opportunity should not depend on ZIP code or informal access to the “right” adults. At the same time, these collaboratives resist both market-only fatalism and the exclusionary instincts of hyperlocalism by insisting that all students are owed meaningful pathways. In this way, they braid a Jeffersonian vision of an educated citizenry with a New Deal-era understanding of government and civic institutions as guarantors of opportunity. The question, then, is not whether localism is good or bad, but whether local control is paired with durable commitments that make opportunity predictable in young people’s everyday lives.

Even as high-quality regional collaboratives demonstrate what local coordination can achieve, Braided Futures remains a meso-level strategy operating within macro-level political-economic constraints. It can redesign regional governance, elevate youth voice, strengthen employer partnerships, and integrate civic and economic purpose—but it cannot, on its own, restructure the distribution of wealth, rewrite labor rules, or regulate corporate power. The framework is therefore best understood as an institutional innovation within a broader political-economic regime—one that must be complemented by state and federal policies capable of redistributing opportunity, stabilizing families, and ensuring that the benefits of shared prosperity are not captured disproportionately by private actors.

John Dewey (1916) argued that education should be both democratic and democratizing, serving not merely to transmit knowledge but to cultivate civic agency. Dewey saw schools as sites where students learn to engage the world, to question, and to contribute. The youth in this dissertation echoed that aspiration in their own language: they wanted adults who “walk with us,” opportunities to “actually change something,” and pathways that connect learning, work, and community. High-quality regional collaboratives can answer that call by inviting students and stakeholders alike to shape learning ecosystems as expressions of democracy, not just delivery systems.

Dewey’s call for education as a site of democratic practice resonates with today’s dual challenge: rebuilding public trust and shared prosperity. In Indiana’s case, high-quality regional collaboratives can function as vehicles

for both democratic renewal and economic inclusion. They make it possible for local control to coexist with shared responsibility—for communities to exercise self-determination while participating in a broader civic project.

6.3 Collective Efficacy as the Missing Glue in Regional Systems

Sociologist Robert J. Sampson (1997) defines collective efficacy as “social cohesion among neighbors combined with their willingness to intervene on behalf of the common good” (p. 918). Originally developed in urban criminology, this concept has profound implications for education and workforce ecosystems. Sampson’s work demonstrates that even in communities facing economic hardship, high levels of collective efficacy predict stronger outcomes in health, safety, and youth development—and, by extension, stronger economic outcomes rooted in community stability (Sampson, 2012).

Regional collaboratives, when functioning optimally, are expressions of collective efficacy. They represent more than coordination; they are relational accountability systems. By design, regional collaboratives foster sustained trust among actors who have historically operated in silos. They create feedback loops, shared metrics, and forums for ongoing communication—all of which strengthen the “willingness to intervene” that Sampson (2012) identifies. In student terms, they answer a simple question: “Who is going to show up for us—and keep showing up?” Collective efficacy is thus a dynamic property, not a static one—a task for community-building rather than a resource to be merely measured (Sampson, 2012, p. 29).

Indiana’s developing proof points illustrate how collective efficacy is enacted through institutional design rather than rhetorical alignment alone. Across cases, partners have translated shared purpose into binding commitments through mechanisms such as the “we will / we will not” guardrails embedded in the Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub, the shared multi-district MOU anchoring RAZ-32, joint presentations to the State Board of Education, and coordinated advocacy for policy change in partnership with the Indiana Chamber of Commerce. These mechanisms specify how actors will behave when capacity constraints, competing incentives, or external pressures pull systems toward fragmentation—moving collaboration from intention to obligation.

To support transparency, predictability, and shared responsibility, selected institutional artifacts are included in Appendix, including the Elkhart County Work-Based Learning Hub contract—particularly its “We Believe” values and operational “We Will / We Will Not” commitments—as well as joint State Board of Education presentation materials developed by RAZ-32 partners. Together, these documents demonstrate how collective efficacy is formalized through shared norms, decision rules, and accountability structures that govern cross-sector action over time. The Elkhart guardrails, for example, codify expectations that partners will share data, avoid duplicative services, coordinate employer outreach, and celebrate collective gains—aligning cross-sector decision-making while anchoring youth voice, relational accountability, and regional equity as non-negotiable design principles. Complementing these governance mechanisms, Multi-Sector Collaborative

(MSC) policy materials document how regional actors collectively surface systemic barriers and engage state leaders to reshape the enabling conditions for pathways and work-based learning.

Importantly, these arrangements intervene on behalf of the common good in concrete terms—not as abstraction, but on behalf of specific young people and employers navigating fragmented systems. From a youth perspective, collective efficacy appears as reliability: buses that run, mentors who return, and adults who do what they say they will do. Students in this dissertation repeatedly linked trust to consistency, fairness, and follow-through—qualities that cannot be sustained through individual goodwill alone, but instead depend on the relational and institutional infrastructure that high-quality regional collaboratives are designed to provide. In regional education-to-employment systems, collective efficacy does not emerge spontaneously; it must be organized, authorized, and sustained through intermediary governance structures that convert relational trust into shared responsibility.

Beyond its civic significance, this form of social and civic capital is also economically consequential. Robert Putnam's work on social capital shows that regions with denser associational life and stronger civic ties tend to experience higher levels of economic performance and resilience (Putnam, 2000). Sampson similarly demonstrates that collective efficacy is associated with neighborhood stability and long-run developmental outcomes, not just short-term reductions in crime (Sampson, 2012). More recently, Raj Chetty and colleagues' analysis of "economic connectedness" has shown that cross-class social ties—especially friendships that bridge income levels—are among the strongest predictors of upward economic mobility in the United States (Chetty et al., 2022). High-quality regional collaboratives intentionally cultivate precisely this kind of cross-institutional and cross-class connectedness: they bring young people, educators, employers, and civic leaders into sustained, problem-solving relationships that are simultaneously civic goods and engines of mobility.

6.4 Critical Pedagogy & Democratic Professionalism: Relational Approaches to Civic Learning

While Sampson provides a sociological frame, bell hooks and Paulo Freire offer moral, pedagogical, and political ones. In *Teaching Community: A Pedagogy of Hope* (2003), hooks challenges educators and leaders to center justice, dialogue, and collective care in communal life. She argues that classrooms—and, by extension, other learning environments—can serve as "locations of possibility" where individuals and communities cultivate the capacity to live meaningful public lives (hooks, 2003, p. 12). Likewise, Freire contends that liberatory education requires "acts of cognition" rather than the passive transfer of information; students and educators must be co-creators of knowledge, jointly analyzing structural conditions and imagining alternatives (Freire, 1970/2000).

The youth narratives in this study echo these principles. Students described wanting "to be at the table," not simply talked about. Their desire to co-design work-based learning (WBL) experiences, evaluate pathway quality,

and advise employers illustrates what Freire would call acts of cognition—the ability to name, analyze, and reshape the conditions affecting one’s future. As youth articulated throughout the study, wages and advancement matter, but so do belonging, predictable structures, supportive supervision, and opportunities to contribute.

Regional collaboratives can thus function as macro-classrooms: distributed learning environments where civic and economic learning intertwine. When students serve on advisory councils, pitch to employers, or critique pathway design, they participate in relational governance—the same deliberative processes that democratic professionalism identifies as central to public work (Horsford, Scott, & Anderson, 2019). Interpreted through this framework, regional collaboratives offer one set of civic structures capable of enacting these principles: they create contexts in which young people and adults can jointly imagine and build more coherent pathways, connecting what is to what could be.

Transformation, in these frameworks, involves not only shifts in belief or practice but changes in material conditions—redistributing access to opportunity, recognition, and stability across lines of race, class, and geography. As bell hooks reminds us, meaningful transformation requires intentional action rooted in care: “Love is an action, never simply a feeling” (hooks, 2000, p. 87). Within regional collaboratives, this ethic is enacted through concrete institutional choices: sustained investment in backbone capacity, predictable mentorship and advising structures, and shared accountability for youth outcomes across sectors. These are not symbolic gestures or moral appeals; they are governance and infrastructure decisions that treat care as a public resource, embedding relational commitment into the everyday operation of education-to-employment systems.

In the Indiana regions examined here, these arrangements include stable convening roles; jointly developed MOUs; routine cross-sector data reviews; youth advisory mechanisms; and systematic use of student feedback to refine pathways. Many of these elements also align with contemporary “good jobs” frameworks—including the U.S. Department of Labor’s Good Jobs Principles (2022), EmployIndy’s Good Wages Initiative (2022), and the state’s Power Up Indiana strategy (2025)—which emphasize predictable scheduling, supportive supervision, and advancement opportunities alongside wages and benefits. High-quality regional collaboratives extend this logic by framing these features not only as labor-market assets but as components of civic learning: conditions under which young people can practice agency, voice, and collective responsibility in the course of preparing for work.

Indiana’s evolving workforce-governance landscape further illustrates how democratic professionalism can be operationalized at scale. As workforce-board roles and regional coordination structures have shifted during the 2024–2025 period—including workforce-board realignment, evolving convening expectations, and a renewed emphasis on sector-based strategies—new opportunities have emerged for employer collaboratives organized around shared demand rather than isolated, one-off partnerships (Indiana Department of Workforce Development, 2024; Indiana Workforce Alliance,

2025; Indiana Capital Chronicle, 2025). These opportunities are most fully realized when grounded in the Talent Pipeline Management (TPM) framework, which provides a shared vocabulary and set of routines for demand planning, competency alignment, and continuous improvement. In regions such as East Central Indiana, the partnership between Eastern Indiana Works (the regional workforce board) and the East Central Education Service Center illustrates how this alignment can function in practice: coordinated employer engagement across districts, shared career-advising and navigation supports, and integrated pathway development that reduces duplication while expanding access to high-quality work-based learning experiences.

These efforts complement, but do not replace, school-based supports like career coaches, CSA-funded advising initiatives, and district-level counseling teams—supports that remain strained under counselor-to-student ratios near 1:700 in Indiana districts (Indiana Capital Chronicle, 2024). High-quality regional collaboratives thus serve as bridging structures that help local actors absorb the demands of career-connected learning while providing routine, relational, and civic-oriented mechanisms for coordination across education, workforce, and industry.

Cumulatively, these dynamics illustrate how high-quality regional collaboratives operationalize the relational and democratic commitments articulated by hooks and Freire, while also attending to the pragmatic requirements of job quality, governance, and regional economic design. As the next section explores, these civic and pedagogical commitments intersect directly with the political-economic traditions that have shaped American understandings of work, responsibility, and collective life.

6.5 High-quality Regional Collaboratives as Localist Redistribution & Democratic Repair

Perhaps the most compelling feature of regional collaboratives is their dual nature: they are both localist and redistributive, civic and economic. In a policy landscape that too often treats local control and shared investment as opposing impulses, high-quality regional collaboratives reveal how the two can coexist—how communities can govern together and grow together. They show that belonging and investment need not be separate acts; when schools, employers, and neighbors collaborate, care and capital can flow through the same hands.

By aligning schools, employers, postsecondary institutions, and community organizations, high-quality regional collaboratives redistribute access to the resources that shape opportunity: mentorship, work-based learning, college credit, social capital, and economic mobility. Concretely, this redistribution often occurs through shared “front door” employer engagement, pooled placement coordination, and cross-district agreements that make transportation, scheduling, and paid work-based learning slots usable at scale. These structures operationalize a principle too often left aspirational—that shared prosperity begins with shared infrastructure. In doing so, regional collaboratives transform collaboration from charity into civic

reciprocity, creating mechanisms through which investment and belonging circulate together.

For youth in this dissertation, that redistribution showed up as concrete differences: access to paid clinical experiences rather than unpaid internships; transportation solutions that made programs genuinely accessible; mentors who understood their cultural and linguistic identities; and pathways that did not require leaving home to succeed. When young people described feeling “like this is actually for us,” they were naming redistributed power as much as redistributed resources.

Rather than imposing improvement from the top down, regional collaboratives cultivate civic capacity from the inside out, asking not what government can deliver alone but what communities can author, govern, and sustain together. As bell hooks reminds us, beloved community rests on an ethic of radical love—love understood not as sentiment but as action, obligation, and care made structural (hooks, 2021). Paulo Freire similarly argues that educators and civic actors cannot claim neutrality in the face of inequality, because educational and public work inevitably takes sides in struggles over dignity, voice, and power (Freire, 2000). In intermediary governance, these commitments translate into deliberate institutional choices: who holds decision-making authority, whose knowledge is treated as legitimate, and whether systems are designed to redistribute opportunity rather than merely coordinate access to it. Regional intermediaries thus function not only as technical brokers but as civic institutions, embedding durable commitments to inclusion, shared responsibility, and democratic participation within the everyday practice of education-to-employment system building.

In practice, these principles translate into shared responsibility rather than rhetoric: a willingness among partners to act on behalf of one another’s success. High-quality regional collaboratives return us to that ground—where care and accountability coexist, and where the health of civic relationships directly determines the resilience of local economies. Collective efficacy, social capital, and economic performance are braided rather than separate domains: when communities build robust civic infrastructure, they also cultivate the conditions for inclusive growth (Putnam, 2000; Sampson, 2012; Chetty et al., 2022).

6.6 From Civic Theory to Institutional Praxis

This insight clarifies the move from analysis to praxis. If regional collaboratives function as civic-economic infrastructure in theory, the question becomes how such infrastructure is intentionally designed, governed, and sustained in practice. Braided Futures represents one applied extension of this dissertation’s argument—a praxis-based framework that operationalizes the research insights, design principles, and analytic tools developed here into actionable systems-change work. References to Braided Futures in this chapter are analytic rather than evaluative, and are offered to illustrate how the dissertation’s design principles operate when translated into applied system-building contexts.

Developed in Indiana and grounded in the lived realities of students, educators, and employers, Braided Futures operates as both an applied systems-design practice and a learning laboratory. It operationalizes the conceptual architecture of high-quality regional collaboratives, the MSC Proofpoint Scorecard, and the Cohesive Learning Infrastructure framework through applied consulting, facilitation, and policy design. In this sense, Braided Futures functions as one applied site through which the research-practice claims of this dissertation are examined, tested, and refined under real institutional constraints through sustained engagement in live regional contexts.

At its core, this praxis rests on a simple but consequential premise: sustainable progress does not emerge from the proliferation of new programs, but from alignment among people, policy, and practice. Fragmentation, as the preceding chapters demonstrate, is not a failure of effort or intention; it is a failure of connection. Braided Futures responds to this condition by helping regions braid education, workforce, and community-development strategies into cohesive systems capable of delivering reliability, dignity, and opportunity at scale.

In practice, this work takes shape through three interlocking modes of engagement: braiding, facilitating, and advising. Braiding involves integrating education, workforce, and community-development strategies into coherent regional systems oriented toward both economic mobility and civic participation. Facilitating centers on building cross-sector partnerships and collaborative governance structures that align local innovation with state and national policy environments. Advising equips leaders with practical tools—such as shared scorecards, logic models, and governance guardrails—to strengthen implementation quality, clarify roles, and sustain impact over time. Together, these modes instantiate theoretical constructs central to this dissertation—such as collective efficacy (Sampson) and beloved community (hooks)—into living organizational principles embedded in everyday institutional practice. In this sense, the Braided Futures model functions as a bridge between scholarly inquiry and applied systems design. Table 6.1 synthesizes how the civic and pedagogical commitments developed across this chapter translate into concrete design implications, institutional mechanisms, and applied tools within regional collaboratives.

Table 6.1 From Civic Theory to Institutional Praxis in Regional Collaboratives

These design relationships provide the conceptual foundation for the Braided Futures implementation agenda that follows, framing subsequent initiatives as tests of institutional praxis rather than programmatic add-ons. Tools developed and refined through this dissertation now inform and support active regional collaborative work across several Indiana regions and national learning contexts. These applications are illustrative rather than exhaustive, and they are presented as design assets rather than outcome claims. The Proofpoint Scorecard supports diagnostic assessment and shared planning across districts, employers, and intermediaries; the Cohesive Learning Infrastructure logic model guides the integration of digital, community-based, and in-school learning; the “We Will / We Will Not” guardrails shape relational norms and decision-making routines within cross-sector teams; and quarterly progress review frameworks institutionalize transparency and shared measurement in multi-district governance.

Taken together, these elements show how the contributions of this dissertation function not as static knowledge but as transferable design assets—structures that enable continuous learning, adaptation, and institutional coherence across diverse regional contexts. They show how civic commitments articulated in theory can be rendered operational through governance routines, backbone capacity, and shared accountability, creating the conditions under which regional collaboratives can move from episodic coordination to durable civic-economic infrastructure.

6.7 Applied Extensions of HQIF: Learning Sites and Early Design Implications

This section describes a set of applied extensions through which the dissertation’s framework is being tested, stress-tested, and refined in live settings. The purpose is analytic: to examine whether HQIF-aligned routines—especially those grounded in youth voice, shared governance, and collective efficacy—can produce reliability under real constraints (limited advising capacity, employer bandwidth, fragmented funding, and shifting policy incentives). The examples below are presented as working hypotheses and learning sites rather than as proven models or outcome claims.

To extend the theory of action articulated in this dissertation, Braided Futures is currently engaged in a set of applied research-and-practice efforts oriented toward testing, refining, and translating the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) into real-world system design. HQIF consolidates and extends earlier design assets—such as the MSC Proofpoint Scorecard and the Cohesive Learning Infrastructure logic model—into a single, integrated quality framework for intermediary architecture. Read together, these tools specify not programs but conditions: the governance routines, backbone capacities, and relational commitments required for regional collaboratives to function as durable civic-economic infrastructure rather than episodic initiatives.

Across its early work, Braided Futures has engaged multiple pathways for extending this inquiry. One such pathway involves collaboration with the

U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation's EPIC initiative to explore employer-led, project-based learning in three Indiana regions—Elkhart County (Elkhart WBL Hub), Whitley County (CTE Collaborative), and Rural Alliance Zone 32 (RAZ-32). These engagements emphasize not only project design, but governance routines: how employers are coordinated without duplicative outreach, how youth feedback informs pathway refinement, and how regional partners steward shared responsibility rather than one-off transactions. Analytically, this work examines whether employer-led learning can be integrated into broader regional governance structures without reproducing the fragmentation critiqued in Chapter 5.

One illustrative learning site is the Indiana nursing pathway. Developed by RAZ-32 partners—including Ivy Tech Community College, Reid Health as the anchor employer, and Randolph Eastern School Corporation as a founding and catalytic district—this pathway offers a bounded analytic case for examining how regional collaboration and policy advocacy can enable scalable, statewide pathway design. With facilitation support from my role as practitioner-researcher, partners leveraged shared learning from the CEMETS Education Systems Reform Lab 2024 Summer Institute to pursue coordinated policy and regulatory advocacy with the Indiana State Board of Nursing. This effort focused in particular on removing the prerequisite that students must first graduate high school before beginning licensed practical nurse (LPN) coursework—an institutional barrier that had previously constrained youth access to accelerated nursing pathways.

The result was not a regional exception, but a scalable nursing pathway architecture now available to students statewide, with applicability across healthcare employers and regions in Indiana. Following its initial creation through RAZ-32, Ivy Tech—uniquely positioned as the nation's only singly accredited statewide community college system—selected Madison, Evansville, Sellersburg, and Richmond (RAZ-32's home base) as early pilot campuses, before expanding access across additional Ivy Tech locations. This design enables students to begin structured healthcare apprenticeships during high school, earn dual credit, progress through LPN licensure shortly after graduation, and access articulated on-ramps to registered nurse (RN) and bachelor of science in nursing (BSN) programs (see Appendix for full pathway sequencing, policy documentation, and credential timelines).

Analytically, this case highlights how collective efficacy can translate into institutional redesign when regional partners align around shared purpose, relational trust, and cross-sector advocacy—particularly in highly regulated fields. Notably, approval by the Indiana State Board of Nursing functioned as a critical legitimacy threshold in this process, illustrating how intermediary-led coordination can translate civic collaboration into formal regulatory change—an outcome rarely achieved through isolated programmatic efforts alone. This translation of learning into policy change has generated national interest as an example of what is possible when intermediary infrastructure supports coordinated systems-change guidance rather than isolated program innovation.

Looking ahead, this experience also informs an area of emerging interest and future inquiry: whether similar CEMETS-informed, HQIF-aligned

processes could support the creation of additional sector pathways, including degree-bearing apprenticeships that intentionally extend into the high school years. Ongoing dialogue with CEMETS and applied research partners such as the National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree (NCAD) offers a promising avenue for exploring how cross-sector facilitation, policy translation, and intermediary design can support new pathway architectures across states—particularly in contexts seeking to align secondary education, postsecondary credentials, and workforce demand without reproducing fragmentation.

Another dimension of the implementation agenda focuses on operational rigor and backbone durability. As Chapters 4 and 5 demonstrate, even well-designed collaboratives struggle to sustain coherence without repeatable operational routines. In response, Braided Futures has begun exploring partnerships—such as with Reportwell’s Operational Excellence Foundation—to examine how process management, data hygiene, placement logistics, and stakeholder communication can be embedded into intermediary practice. The analytic purpose of this work is to test whether operational-excellence tools, when integrated into the MSC Proofpoint Scorecard and Cohesive Learning Infrastructure logic model, can reduce reliance on compensatory individual effort and increase transparency, equity, and reliability across regions. Here again, the emphasis is not on tools as ends in themselves, but on whether operational discipline can function as civic infrastructure—supporting trust, follow-through, and institutional memory. These facilitative capacities are especially consequential in racially and regionally stratified contexts, where historical education debt and uneven access to institutional voice shape how trust is built, whose knowledge is legitimized, and which futures feel imaginable. In this sense, intermediary facilitation is not merely technical coordination but democratic practice: it structures how difference is engaged, how power circulates, and whether collective efficacy can be built across lines of race, class, and place.

Because the HQIF is designed as civic infrastructure rather than as a youth-apprenticeship or work-based learning model alone, its applications extend beyond pathways to the broader work of regional governance and place-based problem solving. Local governments, county systems, mayoral offices, community foundations, chambers of commerce, and regional talent associations can use this architecture to coordinate economic development, digital infrastructure, healthcare pathways, civic learning, and Main Street revitalization. RAZ-32 offers an illustrative case: it was catalyzed through a half-million-dollar, two-year investment from the Randolph County Commissioners, suggesting that local government can function as one of the most durable anchors for braided civic-economic systems. Read in this way, intermediary architecture becomes a standing civic capability—an ongoing capacity to convene, align, and steward shared work—rather than a project-dependent function tied to a single grant cycle.

To further explore this possibility, Braided Futures is examining the concept of a High-Quality Regional Collaborative Design and Readiness Lab as one potential vehicle for HQIF application. The Lab is conceived not as a new intermediary, but as a support structure through which counties, municipalities, school districts, and emerging regional collaboratives could

assess readiness, clarify governance, model sustainable cost-sharing, and test “light” collaborative configurations where full-scale intermediaries are not yet feasible. Analytically, the Lab responds to a recurring challenge identified throughout this dissertation: regions are often asked to coordinate across education, workforce, and industry without shared decision rights, adequate backbone capacity, or durable funding architecture. The Lab concept therefore centers on strengthening role clarity, shared decision routines, and leadership capacity—particularly in rural communities navigating limited staffing, fragmented funding streams, and uneven access to advising and transportation supports.

Finally, Braided Futures’ implementation agenda extends beyond Indiana through national learning and diffusion efforts. Ongoing engagement with partners such as New America’s Partnership to Advance Youth Apprenticeship (PAYA), the Inter/National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree (NCAD), and CareerWise provides opportunities to share HQIF-aligned tools—such as governance templates, scorecards, and design guardrails—and to contribute to national conversations about apprenticeship-degree design that intentionally leverage higher education and Registered Apprenticeship infrastructure. Importantly, these engagements function as anticipatory learning rather than descriptions of Indiana’s current system. Comparative exposure to apprenticeship-degree models illuminates design questions that would arise if states pursued degree-bearing apprenticeship pathways in future policy cycles, reinforcing the dissertation’s argument that statewide infrastructure should be built to accommodate future innovation rather than optimized solely for current initiatives.

In parallel, this applied inquiry is increasingly informed by comparative, multi-state dialogue. Emerging conversations with partners in Tennessee—where rural distress, workforce transition, and postsecondary fragmentation mirror many Indiana conditions—offer a potential second inquiry site through which to examine how HQIF-aligned intermediary design travels across political, cultural, and policy contexts. Ongoing relationships with Tennessee-based education and workforce leaders, alongside international and national learning through CEMETS, the International Network for Apprenticeship Degree (INCAD), and applied research dialogues with NCAD, further position this work as part of a broader, comparative design conversation rather than a solution for just one state. Analytically, these engagements surface which elements of intermediary quality are context-dependent, and which appear to function as more generalizable civic-economic design principles.

Taken together, this applied agenda tests multiple dimensions of the HQIF—employer coordination, governance durability, sector pathway design, operational rigor, and knowledge diffusion—while remaining grounded in the youth aspirations and community conditions documented throughout this study. It also clarifies an implication that runs across Chapters 4–6: regional coherence is easier to sustain when broader political-economic conditions stabilize families and distribute risk more equitably. This implication is offered here as analytic context rather than a policy platform, naming the

macro-level conditions that can enable or constrain the durability of regional civic-economic infrastructure.

6.8 Diagnostic Friction: Why Intermediary Quality Matters

Indiana's recent investments in youth apprenticeship and career-connected learning—including initiatives such as Indiana iLab and the Indiana Career and Postsecondary Apprenticeship (INCAP) effort—provide important context for understanding why a High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) is necessary. These initiatives have elevated the visibility of youth apprenticeship, expanded employer engagement, and signaled a statewide commitment to work-based learning as a core educational priority. At the same time, practitioner interviews, employer conversations, and fieldwork across multiple regions suggest that implementation challenges have emerged not primarily from lack of will or innovation, but from structural misalignment between initiative design and the intermediary capacity required for durable regional coordination.

Three recurring constraints surfaced across regions. Taken together, they illustrate what this dissertation terms diagnostic friction: the gap between the ambitions of statewide reform and the infrastructural conditions required to realize them equitably and sustainably.

First, fragmented partnership structures have limited collective coherence. iLab and INCAP have largely relied on one-to-one agreements between a designated intermediary and individual school districts or employers. While administratively expedient, this transactional structure often reinforces fragmentation by treating partnerships as discrete engagements rather than as components of a shared regional system. Regional leaders reported duplicative employer outreach, inconsistent expectations across districts, and limited mechanisms for collective decision-making. By contrast, HQIF-aligned regional collaboratives are structured around regional memoranda of understanding (MOUs), steering committees, and shared metrics that codify collective responsibility and reduce transaction costs. The contrast suggests that fragmentation is not an inevitable feature of youth apprenticeship, but a design outcome shaped by governance architecture.

The second constraint concerns underdeveloped backbone roles and funding. Employer partners and intermediaries consistently described expectations for recruitment, placement, advising, worksite monitoring, and compliance that outstripped available staffing and sustainable cost models. These pressures were compounded by a third, related source of friction: ambiguity about the relative value of Indiana's "modern youth apprenticeship" branding compared to established Registered Apprenticeship infrastructure. Leaders raised concerns about portability, hour thresholds, and access to federal funding streams—leading several employers to conclude that, with adequate intermediary support, they could implement youth apprenticeship or Registered Apprenticeship directly with education partners at lower cost and with clearer return on investment.

Practitioners described persistent ambiguity around the portability and recognition of Indiana's modern youth apprenticeship pathways relative to federally registered apprenticeship (RA). In interviews, leaders raised

concerns about differences in hour expectations, training-plan recognition, and access to federal funding streams, noting examples in which youth pathways required substantially fewer hours (e.g., approximately 650 hours) than benchmarks they associated with RA programs (often cited as closer to 900–1,000 hours). Importantly, these figures reflect practitioner perceptions and examples offered during fieldwork rather than a comprehensive audit of program standards. Nevertheless, these perceptions materially shaped employer decision-making, with several partners reporting that, absent sufficient HQIF-aligned intermediary support, RA pathways appeared clearer in terms of portability, incentives, and return on investment.

These constraints have been amplified by broader system transitions. As Indiana restructures its workforce development regions and redefines the role of workforce boards (Indiana Department of Workforce Development, 2024), districts and employers are navigating shifting convening authorities, emerging sector-based priorities, and reconfigured regional boundaries. In this context, uncertainty about who holds decision rights—and at what scale—has further strained coordination. Rather than resolving fragmentation, overlapping reforms risk compounding it unless intermediary architecture is intentionally designed to absorb change.

Read through the HQIF lens, these dynamics clarify a central claim of this dissertation: the durability of education-to-employment systems depends on cohesive intermediary architecture that stabilizes collaboration amid policy flux. High-quality regional collaboratives offer a stabilizing structure precisely because they braid employer demand, district advising, and regional labor-market intelligence into shared governance routines. When aligned with frameworks such as Talent Pipeline Management (TPM), they provide a common vocabulary for demand planning, continuous improvement, and shared accountability—reducing reliance on personality-driven coordination or short-term grant cycles.

Importantly, this analysis does not position Indiana’s current initiatives as failures. Rather, it treats them as instructive prototypes that reveal the limits of initiative-driven reform absent infrastructural alignment. The constraints documented here are not unique to Indiana; they reflect broader patterns in U.S. education and workforce policy, where innovation often outpaces the intermediary capacity required to sustain it. The analytic contribution of this section, therefore, is not evaluative but diagnostic: it identifies the structural conditions under which well-intentioned reforms struggle—and the design principles required to move from episodic coordination to durable civic-economic infrastructure.

6.9 Continuous Learning as Intermediary Governance

Across Braided Futures engagements, implementation is treated as a continuous learning loop, embedding cycles of reflection, adaptation, and evidence-building that mirror both the theoretical commitments and methodological approach of this dissertation. Across engagements, implementation is treated not as a linear rollout but as a continuous loop—one that integrates data, practitioner insight, youth feedback, and system constraints into iterative redesign.

Continuous inquiry functions as a form of governance in HQIF-aligned regional collaboratives: it creates routine public spaces for collective interpretation of evidence, negotiation of meaning, and shared accountability. Fragmentation is not simply inefficiency; it is a civic signal. When systems rely on compensatory effort rather than predictable architecture, they communicate to youth that opportunity depends on luck rather than public responsibility. Across Indiana, students interpreted these inconsistencies as evidence of institutional unreliability—precisely the kind of structural condition that weakens both mobility and democratic trust. High-quality regional collaboratives address this problem not through heroic individual action, but through design: shared governance, clear routines, and transparent decision-making that anchor relational work within durable public systems.

Each regional collaborative supported by Braided Futures uses recurring routines—quarterly partner surveys, post-convening debriefs, TPM-style demand analyses, and shared data dashboards—to surface where coordination is working, where burdens are accumulating, and where youth or employers are signaling unmet needs. These routines echo the principles of improvement science, but they also operationalize key HQIF domains related to shared governance, collective learning, and continuous improvement. Rooted as much in civic practice as in technical management, they establish shared deliberative routines for interpreting evidence, negotiating meaning, and sustaining collective accountability over time. Viewed through this lens, high-quality regional collaboratives function as what Honig (2006) calls “learning-centered intermediaries”: organizations that do not simply implement programs, but build partners’ capacity to diagnose and address systemic challenges as an ongoing public practice.

This learning loop unfolds amid significant structural constraint, shaped by Indiana’s fragmented and evolving educational and workforce architecture. Districts and regional partners are simultaneously navigating multiple, overlapping system demands, including:

- - **Career Scholarship Accounts (CSAs)**: administrative complexity related to student eligibility, provider lists, and family-facing logistics;
 - **Career Coaching and Advising Grants**: essential but time-limited supports that remain insufficient relative to counselor caseloads nearing 1:700 in many districts;
 - **Commission for Higher Education coaching frameworks**: emerging expectations for postsecondary advising and alignment that often require local actors to compensate in the absence of sustained funding;
 - **Statewide apprenticeship pilots** (e.g., iLab, INCAP): expanded opportunity coupled with additional intermediaries, reporting requirements, and programmatic complexity; and
 - **Workforce board realignment** (Indiana Department of Workforce Development, 2024): evolving sector priorities and convening roles that introduce both opportunity and uncertainty.

These overlapping structures shape the conditions under which high-quality regional collaboratives must learn and adapt. They often require collaboratives to spend significant “sensemaking” labor just to reconcile the policy landscape: determining how CSA funds intersect with work-based learning (WBL) transportation needs, how coaching grants align with employer demand signals, or how INCAP training plans interact with existing Registered Apprenticeship (RA) curricula.

As Chapter 5 details and this section extends, iLab and INCAP are instructive not primarily as critiques but as diagnostic friction when assessed through the HQIF lens: they reveal what happens when new initiatives are layered without sufficient backbone capacity, intermediary alignment, or clear governance routines. Within the learning loops used by regional collaboratives, that friction becomes actionable information rather than latent system strain.

Indiana’s realigned workforce boards, when paired with the Talent Pipeline Management (TPM) framework, offer a promising opportunity to institutionalize this learning loop as durable civic-economic infrastructure. TPM’s core routines—demand planning, competency analysis, talent flow mapping, and continuous improvement—mirror the cycles used in high-quality regional collaboratives. Where boards adopt these practices not only for employers but alongside schools, education service centers (ESCs), and intermediaries, they can function as durable civic-economic learning hubs.

East Central Indiana offers a leading example. The partnership between Eastern Indiana Works (the regional workforce board) and the East Central Education Service Center demonstrates how workforce boards and ESCs can jointly support career coaching, CSA-aligned advising, WBL logistics, and pathway development. Their collaboration reduces duplication, aligns incentives, and provides precisely the kind of shared learning structure that other regions often attempt to build independently.

This learning loop is also shaped by youth voice and family experience, ensuring that refinement remains anchored in the lived realities of those furthest from opportunity. In this sense, continuous improvement is not only a technical routine but an extension of the dissertation’s commitments to youth voice and healing-centered engagement: it treats young people and families as knowledge-holders whose interpretations carry design authority. Across Braided Futures engagements, youth advisory councils, student feedback routines, and culturally responsive design reviews have surfaced critical insights that conventional implementation metrics often miss—for example, that transportation gaps are not merely logistical but tied to dignity; that paid WBL placements can alter family dynamics and household decision-making; and that young people want “real responsibility” rather than symbolic roles. In this way, continuous learning becomes a mechanism for redistributing voice, not merely refining programs. The perspectives of youth and families shape how pathways are structured, how supports are targeted, and how partners interpret what “success” ought to mean.

Finally, cyclical learning within regional collaboratives functions as policy feedback, informing state-level conversations about advising capacity,

apprenticeship design, and intermediary architecture. Patterns that emerge across regions—such as advising shortages, the limits of short-term grant timelines, employer confusion about apprenticeship branding, or misalignment between CSA rules and WBL structures—become part of Braided Futures’ state policy advising and national contributions through partners such as New America, the Inter/National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree (NCAD), and the U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation.

This recursive structure exemplifies the dissertation’s assertion that praxis is both product and process: a way of knowing through doing, and a way of designing through learning. In this sense, high-quality regional collaboratives—and the Braided Futures engagements that support them—operate not only as coordination structures but as learning infrastructures: civic and economic systems capable of evolving through evidence, relationship, and shared responsibility. This continuous loop sets the stage for the chapter’s concluding synthesis in Section 6.10, which draws together the civic, economic, and structural implications of this model.

6.10 Conclusion: Toward Durable Civic-Economic Design

Taken together, the analysis across Chapters 4–6 demonstrates that regional collaboratives function as a distinctive form of civic infrastructure—one capable of aligning economic mobility with democratic participation when designed with coherence, shared governance, and relational accountability. In its founding year, Braided Futures has supported multiple Indiana regions—Elkhart County (Elkhart WBL Hub), the Whitley County CTE Collaborative, and RAZ-32—as well as national partners engaged in the U.S. Chamber Foundation’s Talent Pipeline Management network and New America’s youth apprenticeship initiatives. These engagements illustrate how the dissertation’s design principles translate into applied system-building contexts, not as proof of outcomes, but as evidence of how civic-economic architecture can be operationalized under real institutional constraints.

Consistent with Honig’s (2006) characterization of intermediary organizations, the regional collaboratives examined here operate simultaneously in technical and normative domains. They coordinate the logistical elements of system-building—employer engagement, work-based learning placement, advising, and data use—while also shaping how partners understand shared goals, public responsibility, and institutional trust. Interpreted through this framework, high-quality regional collaboratives provide a mechanism through which regions can more reliably braid economic development with civic development, reducing fragmentation while strengthening collective efficacy.

These findings resonate with scholarship emphasizing that American civic institutions depend on both self-determination and interdependence (Bellah et al., 1985). Public education is often understood as a civic covenant between society and its young people (Gutmann, 1999), a covenant made visible not only through policy declarations but through the reliability of everyday systems. The youth narratives in this study underscore why coherence matters: students experienced aligned systems not merely as

efficient structures, but as evidence that institutions were willing to commit to them over time. This reinforces a central insight across public administration and civic education research—that work, learning, and governance are not purely technical arenas, but sites in which democratic practice is enacted in daily life (Honig, 2006; Mehta & Fine, 2019).

Braided Futures represents one applied extension of this research. It carries forward the dissertation's guiding questions: What would it require for learning to be both civically developmental—supporting identity, agency, and participation—and economically mobilizing—expanding access to stable work, upward mobility, and long-term opportunity? And how might regions design systems in which opportunity, purpose, and community well-being reinforce one another rather than compete? Viewed through this lens, Braided Futures functions not merely as a coordination strategy but as an applied framework for regional civic-economic design—translating the principles identified in this dissertation into governance routines, design tools, and learning structures that can be tested and refined in practice.

Taken together, the findings across this chapter suggest that the future of coherent education-to-employment systems will depend on multi-level collaboration: local leaders, state agencies, employers, and intermediaries co-creating the institutional conditions under which young people can pursue meaningful work and civic participation. This orientation does not propose a wholesale transformation of American governance. Rather, it offers a pragmatic approach to strengthening the civic and economic functions of regional systems in ways that are durable, responsive, and capable of providing expansive opportunity. In this sense, durable civic-economic design is not an abstract ideal but a practical obligation—one that asks regions to treat opportunity not as episodic access, but as a shared public responsibility. Chapter 7 builds on this foundation by widening the analytic lens—examining intermediaries not only as organizational solutions, but as social and political institutions that shape how responsibility, dignity, and collective life are organized in a period of economic and democratic strain.

Chapter 7: Social Capital, Civic Intermediaries, and the Work of Democratic Repair

7.1 Reframing the Problem: From Programs to Civic Intermediaries

Across this dissertation, I have moved from youth voice to system design: from students' descriptions of fractured supports and fragile opportunities, to civic intermediary design as regional infrastructure, to Braided Futures as a praxis framework that braids people, policy, and practice. This chapter widens the lens once more. Throughout this chapter, the terms intermediaries and regional collaboratives refer to the broader class of cross-sector governance structures that coordinate education, workforce, and civic actors at a regional scale; the term Multi-Sector Collaboratives (MSCs) is reserved for Indiana's specific, policy-codified instantiation of this intermediary form.

The core claim is simple, but its implications are not: the intermediaries we design are no longer just technical problem-solvers; they are civic actors

within a financialized and highly unequal political-economic order. At its core, this dissertation is an examination of what we want and what we need—and of how contested the line between the two has become. Policy debates often treat “needs” as narrowly biological: food, shelter, and protection from immediate, gunshot-style catastrophe. Yet as Case and Deaton (2020) show in their analysis of “deaths of despair,” slow forms of social and economic abandonment can be just as lethal as sudden violence, particularly when isolation, addiction, and chronic stress accumulate over time.

The question is not simply how to keep people alive in the most minimal sense, but how to organize education and work so that young people can plausibly anticipate hope, dignity, and rest—not just survival. MSCs emerge in this space as one response to that deeper demand: they are experiments in collective flourishing, not just emergency management. They sit at the intersection of public systems and private markets, holding together threads that earlier generations expected governments, unions, or neighborhood institutions to carry alone. When we design intermediaries, we are deciding whether—and how—there can be structures that perform both economic and civic functions at once. Students in this study repeatedly named this distinction in their own terms: not just “a job,” but a life that feels stable, dignified, and connected to community—an expectation that is simultaneously economic and civic. This distinction echoes Bettina Love’s critique of what she terms the “survival complex” in American education—systems that ask young people, particularly students of color, to endure instability rather than redesign the conditions that produce it (Love, 2019). Love argues that justice-oriented systems must move beyond helping students survive broken structures toward building institutional arrangements that make dignity, joy, and full participation possible. Read alongside the youth narratives in this study, her work clarifies that reliability itself is a form of justice: when pathways are predictable, when adults follow through, and when opportunity is treated as a public obligation rather than an exception, young people experience not only economic inclusion but civic recognition.

If intermediaries lean only toward economic coordination, they risk becoming another instrument of extraction: matching labor to jobs without interrogating wages, conditions, or the broader distribution of risk. This “labor-matching” orientation is often framed as efficiency, but it contradicts core American civic ideals of individual flourishing, self-determination, and the pursuit of happiness—values embedded in the Declaration of Independence and reinforced across generations (Bellah et al., 1985). When intermediaries reduce young people to labor inputs, they undermine the very ideals that animate the American ethos. Conversely, if intermediaries lean only toward civic aspiration without grappling with employer needs and fiscal realities, they risk irrelevance or burnout. The challenge, then, is not simply “how to do collaboration,” but how to design civic intermediaries whose economic work strengthens, rather than erodes, democratic life.

Beneath these institutional choices lies a longstanding political question about who bears responsibility for collective well-being. One tradition emphasizes the public sector—the state—as the primary guarantor of baseline security and opportunity. Another is skeptical of state capacity or

legitimacy and instead looks to families, faith institutions, philanthropy, or employers as engines of care and mobility. At their best, both traditions recognize that prosperity is relational rather than individual. Yet in the current moment, consumerism and polarized information ecosystems often redirect this obligation away from structural commitments and toward individualized blame for conditions that are fundamentally systemic (Bellah et al., 1985; Somers, 2008). Intermediaries offer a third orientation: they do not replace the state or the market, but create local governance tables where public agencies, employers, and community institutions must enact—rather than merely profess—their shared responsibilities.

This “dual-role” question is sharpened by a broader shift in political economy. Over the last several decades, responsibility for what were once considered core public functions—training, care, health, and elements of social protection—has increasingly migrated across the state, market, and household sectors. Economists describe this as a reorganization of social reproduction, in which essential coordination and care work flows toward whichever actors possess the least bargaining power or institutional protection (Goldin, 2021; Mazzucato, 2021). In the education-to-employment arena, regional collaboratives increasingly operate as relational governance infrastructure—neither replacing government authority nor market mechanisms, but organizing the connective, coordinating, and sustaining work that allows public systems to function in practice—particularly where formal capacity, time, and trust are thin.

This chapter uses that framing to extend the dissertation’s contribution in three ways. First, it argues that social capital is both a crutch and a catalyst in this landscape—necessary, but insufficient, for structural change. Second, it offers a practitioner-facing outline of how civic intermediaries can be designed to balance individual supports with system-level transformation. Third, it proposes directions for future research that take seriously the political, economic, and relational stakes of this work.

7.2 Civicness, Proximity, and the Extraction of Time

Earlier chapters argued that collective efficacy (Sampson, 2012) is the “missing glue” of intermediaries: the social cohesion and willingness to intervene on behalf of the common good. Here, I extend that argument by foregrounding proximity and time.

Civic life is not an abstraction. It is built—or eroded—through repeated, proximate encounters: sitting with a student to map next steps, riding the same bus route, serving on a shared committee, answering a late-night text from a worried parent. Bryan Stevenson (2014) has famously argued that justice requires proximity: we cannot repair what we refuse to come close to. In a similar vein, this dissertation suggests that civicness requires regional proximity—shared schools, shared employers, shared main streets—even as digital life stretches our imagined communities far beyond local boundaries.

Hyper-capitalism, however, has reallocated one of the scarcest resources in civic life: uncommodified time. When every hour is framed as a unit of potential income or productivity, time spent in slow relationship-building—

mentoring, listening, conflict resolution—can feel like “wasted” capital. The result is a vicious cycle: as time for relationships shrinks, social capital becomes rarer and more precious, which in turn makes it harder to generate the trust needed for coordinated system change.

The extraction of time and attention is further reinforced by digital platforms that simulate connection without requiring the embodied commitments of community life. Online networks can expand access to information, ideas, and opportunity; they can also intensify loneliness and misrecognition, as individuals comment on one another’s lives without sharing the slow, proximate work of mutual responsibility—attending a school board meeting, sitting through a difficult conversation, or showing up when something goes wrong. Under these conditions, social media can generate a marketplace of commentary about “what should be done” without cultivating the shared obligations required to actually do it. For civic intermediaries, this distinction is consequential: implementation trust is built less through shared opinion than through shared routines, accountability, and follow-through over time. Trust accrues when commitments are made visible, revisited, and honored in practice—not when agreement is merely signaled or performed.

Intermediaries push against this extractive logic in two ways. First, they institutionalize proximity—by convening regular cross-sector meetings, youth advisory councils, and employer design sessions that require people to show up together over time. Second, they protect relational labor as real work, not volunteerism on the margins. When a backbone staff member spends two hours troubleshooting a student’s transportation barrier with a counselor and an employer, that time is part of the job—not an extracurricular act of charity.

Viewed this way, intermediaries represent a small but significant political choice: to treat social capital and care as infrastructural, not incidental. This chapter builds on this logic by examining how system-level policy and intermediary design can embed these principles in durable ways. Several youth-generated civic artifacts examined in this study progressed beyond advisory influence to formal institutional uptake. One concrete illustration is the passage of an Indiana law establishing permanent system-impacted youth seats on a statewide commission focused on children and family wellbeing—an outcome that followed policy analysis and proposals advanced through the Statewide Youth Policy Fellowship. The study also examines youth-authored policy pitches and draft legislation addressing youth mental health, addiction, and financial stability for students in foster care. These outcomes are treated here not as evaluative claims of causality, but as evidence of intermediary infrastructure capable of translating youth analysis into durable governance arrangements.

7.3 Social Capital as Crutch and Catalyst for System Design

Recent empirical work has sharpened what earlier theorists like Putnam (2000, 2015) intuited: social capital is strongly associated with economic mobility. Raj Chetty and colleagues, using large-scale data, show that “economic connectedness”—the extent to which lower-income individuals

are linked to higher-income peers—is a powerful predictor of upward mobility across U.S. communities (Chetty et al., 2022). Their findings suggest that who you know, and who knows you, measurably shapes where you can go.

For the students in this study, this insight was lived, not abstract. They understood that employers “hold the keys” to social mobility, that a recommendation from the right adult can open doors, and that being known—in the deepest sense—creates a buffer against being overlooked. It is unsurprising that social capital has become a kind of folk policy: “If every successful person just mentored a young person, we could fix this.” Social capital, in this narrative, becomes both the means and the moral of the story.

This dissertation affirms and complicates that narrative. Social capital is indeed a catalyst: it amplifies the impact of pathways, apprenticeships, and credentials. It can help students navigate bureaucracies not designed for them, and it can sustain hope when systems falter. It is also, too often, a crutch we lean on when political will to change structures is lacking.

In highly segregated communities, these dynamics are especially acute: social capital becomes both more potent and more parochial, reinforcing the idea that private virtue (mentorship, volunteering, benevolence) can compensate for public inadequacy. This substitution—interpersonal support standing in for structural adequacy—makes social capital feel like a solution even when structural conditions remain unchanged.

As Smith (2010) and Putnam (2015) show, Americans increasingly live in homogenous moral communities where cross-class relationships are rare. In such settings, small acts of generosity can feel sufficient, even virtuous, because people seldom encounter the structural conditions others endure. Bryan Stevenson (2014) reminds us that justice requires proximity, narrative repair, hope, and a willingness to do uncomfortable things—including confronting systems rather than relying solely on interpersonal charity. Without this discomfort, social capital becomes a substitute for structural responsibility: a well-intentioned but insufficient replacement for the systemic changes young people actually need.

Finally, this crutch dynamic intersects with a deeper American ethos. The United States prizes individualism, self-determination, and the pursuit of happiness—not merely subsistence. When systems rely primarily on interpersonal benevolence rather than structural adequacy, they reduce mobility to luck rather than liberty, contradicting the democratic promise that each person should have a fair chance to flourish. Leaning on social capital alone not only fails young people materially; it undermines the moral foundations of American civic life.

This also points to a deeper truth: social capital is never context-free. It is built and used within identity landscapes shaped by race, class, gender, region, and history. These orbits matter because relationships are not interchangeable parts; they are specific, accumulated, and often fragile—built over years of shared context and rooted in particular histories of race, class, place, and power.

Healing-Centered Engagement (Ginwright, 2018) reminds us that relationships are culturally situated and shaped by historical harm. Jenkins' (2014) identity theory similarly shows that relational ecosystems are interpretive spaces where young people make meaning of themselves and their futures. Intermediaries that ignore these dynamics risk reproducing inequity; intermediaries that attend to them—through governance representation, youth voice, and healing-centered design—can redistribute social capital as a public resource rather than a private asset.

7.4 Designing Civic Intermediaries: Capacity, Pace, and Local Governance

The design questions that undergird this chapter return repeatedly to a practical tension: how to match the pace and scope of change to regional capacity. In Indiana, I have seen communities start from very different places. Some regions are effectively creating systems from scratch—motivated by unmet needs, but with limited existing coordination, few shared data systems, and fragile trust. Others possess abundant assets—chambers, workforce boards, community foundations, and strong CTE centers—but lack an intentional architecture to braid those assets into a coherent system.

My own practice has illustrated the stakes of design choices in this arena. National Talent Pipeline Management (TPM) work often organizes employers by sector across multiple regions, assuming that an employer's primary identity and set of incentives flow from its industry. In early Indiana work, I leaned toward a similar statewide-by-industry logic. Over time, however, it became clear that for the vast majority of the economy—especially small and midsize firms—their deepest commitments are regional rather than abstractly sectoral. Owners and managers care about specific schools, specific neighborhoods, and the particular young people who might one day work alongside them. This realization pushed the Braided Futures model more firmly toward regional MSCs that integrate sector strategies, rather than sector strategies that only occasionally reach back to place. It is another reminder that economic development, workforce strategy, and youth development are not separate lanes; they converge most powerfully where people actually live. Intermediaries must therefore act as facilitators of regional self-determination, not one-size-fits-all templates.

Apprenticeship, in this light, is not merely a labor-market instrument; it is a youth development and justice practice. High-quality youth apprenticeship invites young people into real workplaces with real stakes, where they can see adults navigating conflict, cooperation, and constraint. When structured well, it offers healing-centered engagement: students are not only learning technical skills, but also experimenting with identity, testing their own agency, and experiencing what it feels like to contribute to something larger than themselves.

This has implications for how intermediaries and employers co-govern programs. In this study, youth participation functioned not only as consultation, but as governance work. Several youth-generated civic artifacts examined here progressed beyond advisory influence to formal institutional uptake. Notably, policy analysis and proposals developed

through the Statewide Youth Policy Fellowship informed multiple state-level actions, including an Indiana state law, which established two permanent system-impacted youth seats on the Indiana Commission on Improving the Status of Children, as well as youth-authored policy pitches and draft legislation addressing youth mental health, addiction, and financial stability for students in foster care. These outcomes are treated not as evaluative claims of causality, but as evidence of intermediary infrastructure capable of translating youth analysis into durable governance arrangements. These examples underscore that youth governance is not ancillary to workforce design, but central to whether education-to-employment systems reproduce extraction or cultivate shared responsibility.

If apprenticeship is understood only as a pipeline for filling vacancies, the temptation will be to extract capacity from young people—and from the communities and environments that sustain them—as efficiently as possible. If apprenticeship is also understood as a site for cultivating individual and collective capacity, then employers, schools, and intermediaries must ask different questions: What forms of participation foster self-respect, not just compliance? How do we ensure that young people see themselves as co-authors of their community's future, not merely as inputs into someone else's business model? The governance models described in earlier chapters—youth seats on advisory councils, co-design sessions, and feedback loops—begin to answer these questions, while also pointing to a wider agenda for theory-building and practice.

In practice, this design orientation suggests several near-term moves:

- - Conduct asset mapping and readiness assessments that honor what is already working, rather than assuming a blank slate.
 - Use cluster approaches (e.g., healthcare, manufacturing, education) to convene employer groups that align with both regional demand and school pathway design.
 - Clarify role boundaries in the advising ecosystem by specifying what counselors will and will not do, and how specialized career coaches, navigators, or employer liaisons will complement them—so individual staff are not asked to be all things to all students.

Operationally, regions also confront a common set of design variables that shape governance, legitimacy, and implementation burden:

- - **Backbone / Convener:** Which entity has the legitimacy, capacity, and staying power to serve as the backbone (district, ESC, chamber, community foundation, nonprofit), and how is that choice perceived by smaller districts and employers?
 - **Funding Streams:** Which state, federal, and philanthropic dollars can be braided, and how much of that funding is stable enough to underwrite backbone staffing rather than short-term projects?
 - **Signatories vs. Partners vs. Technical Assistance:** Who signs binding MOUs, who participates as partners, and who provides technical assistance from the “outside edge” of the system?
 - **Primary Focus:** Is the initial emphasis on shared pathways across districts (economies of scale), employer activation (demand-side

- organizing), or the “highway” that coordinates advising, transportation, credit transfer, and WBL logistics?
- **Ecosystem Positioning:** How does the backbone relate to existing EDCs, workforce boards, and chambers? Which regional and state-level tables does it prioritize as it builds credibility and spreads learning?

None of these choices is neutral. Each shapes whose interests become most visible, how power circulates, and which young people ultimately gain access to high-quality opportunities. These choices also require micro-governance structures sturdy enough to outlast individual leaders. Conferences, exposure trips, or one-time convenings can spark relationships and generate enthusiasm, but they are necessary and insufficient if not anchored in durable routines and written agreements.

When a superintendent leaves for a new district, a CEO retires, or a beloved principal is reassigned, relational capital can evaporate unless it is anchored in:

- - written guardrails and MOUs that define roles, metrics, and expectations over multiple years;
 - backbone organizations with dedicated staff whose job descriptions explicitly include employer partnership stewardship, convening routines, and implementation troubleshooting; and
 - contracts and policy instruments that tie public dollars to collaborative structures (e.g., requiring multi-district governance to access certain funds).

At the same time, intermediaries must attend to the pace of change. Too slow, and trust erodes as students continue to experience fragmentation. Too fast, and partners experience initiative fatigue or feel hijacked by designs they did not help shape. Braided Futures has attempted to navigate this tension through phased scopes of work rather than one monolithic plan. Rather than a single linear rollout, HQIF-aligned regional collaboratives typically develop through phases that align governance, capacity, and scale over time. Table 7.1 illustrates a phased model of regional collaborative development, translating HQIF design principles into a sequenced progression of governance formation, operational coherence, and long-term institutionalization.

Table 7.1 Potential HQIF-Aligned Phases of Regional Collaborative Development (Illustrative)

Phase & Horizon	Primary Aim	Example Scope-of-Work Elements
Phase 0 (0-6 months) Readiness & Asset Mapping	Establish shared understanding, trust, and baseline capacity	Regional landscape analysis; youth focus groups; employer and partner interviews; inventory of existing pathways and supports; initial governance guardrails; readiness assessment across districts and employers
Phase 1 (6-18 months) Governance Formation & Early Wins	Build durable collaborative structure and demonstrate early value	Formalize steering committee and backbone roles; execute MOUs; adopt HQIF / Proofpoint Scorecard; launch 1-2 flagship pathways, apprenticeships, or EPIC projects; establish youth advisory structures
Phase 2 (18-36 months) Operational Coherence & Scaling	Deepen implementation quality and system integration	Expand WBL placements; align diploma seals and credential pathways; integrate shared data and reporting tools (e.g., advising, placement tracking); conduct quarterly cross-sector data reviews; strengthen employer coordination
Phase 3 (36+ months) Institutionalization & Diffusion	Sustain gains and support adaptation beyond the initial region	Codify collaborative structures in local or state policy; braid additional funding streams; stabilize backbone staffing; document practices and playbooks; support neighboring regions in adapting the model

Across these phases, this dissertation has treated high-quality work-based learning as having a “Core Four”:

- 1. **Paid and Protected:** Students are compensated for their contributions and covered by clear safety, labor, and anti-discrimination protections.
- 2. **Progressive and Credentialed:** Experiences follow an ascending sequence of skills and responsibilities, with meaningful postsecondary “currency” in the form of dual credit, industry-recognized credentials, or advanced standing.
- 3. **Relationally Anchored:** Each placement is embedded in durable relationships—with mentors, supervisors, and school-based advocates—rather than one-off tasks.
- 4. **Reflective and Identity-Building:** Students have structured opportunities to make sense of what they are learning about themselves, their communities, and possible futures, including the civic implications of their work.

These elements knit together student interest, employer needs, and civic purpose. They also embody the dissertation’s core claim that work, when designed with care, can be both economically relevant and democratizing.

This phased approach reflects a broader principle: intermediary design must honor both human limits and structural ambition. It must protect time for reflective dialogue—intentional time to talk—because group reflection is not a luxury but a precondition for honest problem-solving.

7.5 Policy Directions for Intermediaries: Beyond Blunt Instruments

Indiana’s pathways reforms—and the national movement they exemplify—raise a policy question that extends beyond this dissertation: how can states move from blunt policy instruments to implementation architectures that actually embody their equity aspirations?

Several themes emerge:

- ◦ Separate start-up and outcomes funding (“belt and suspenders”). As practitioners noted in Indiana, it may be wise to split policy mechanisms: one stream that funds start-up costs (backbone staffing, planning time, initial employer engagement), and another that rewards outcomes (credentials, WBL hours, employment and enrollment metrics). Combining both into a single short-term grant can create unrealistic expectations and invite gaming rather than learning.
- Build statewide alliances as accountability and support. Policy is a blunt tool; it can mandate WBL, but it cannot, on its own, create trust or solve for local capacity. States therefore need alliances—cross-sector bodies that accompany agencies and districts, help interpret policy, and feed implementation insights back into statute and regulation. These entities should include youth, rural voices, and employers from small and mid-sized firms, not only marquee companies.

- Clarify roles in the advising ecosystem. Given counselor caseloads, states should distinguish clearly between school counselors, who must attend to broad academic and social-emotional needs, and career coaches or navigators, who specialize in pathways, financial aid, and WBL logistics. Intermediaries can host these specialized roles regionally, so that individual schools are not left to invent them alone.

Connect pathways to broader economic policy. As Chapter 5 argued, pathways cannot compensate for low wages, weak labor standards, or highly unequal tax structures. Research on guaranteed income and cash-transfer pilots—including those targeted to parents and young children—suggests that direct material supports can improve child health, reduce stress, and increase educational attainment. Yet such interventions remain politically contested, even as emerging evidence suggests potential downstream benefits for stability, health, and educational persistence. For pathways policy to fulfill its promise, it must be complemented by broader economic conditions that reduce volatility and make family life less precarious.

In all of these areas, intermediaries can function as translators: clarifying what policies mean on the ground, surfacing unintended consequences, and modeling more nuanced approaches to accountability than test scores or short-term placement metrics alone. Importantly, High-quality intermediaries require facilitative leaders who can function as cultural brokers—translating across sectors and social difference, legitimizing marginalized perspectives, and structuring interaction in ways that build trust without erasing power. Prior research on cultural brokering and identity-attentive facilitation suggests that inclusion is not achieved through co-presence alone, but through mediated interaction that can hold tension, surface difference, and still move groups toward shared responsibility (Jenkins, 2014; Weisinger & Salipante, 2005). In this study, such facilitation emerges as a core intermediary capacity: one that enables youth to participate as co-theorists and co-advocates, while also preparing adult institutions to receive, interpret, and act on youth knowledge.

7.6 Future Research: Democracy, Identity, and the Civic-Economic Politics of Interests

This dissertation opens more questions than it can resolve. I highlight five directions for future research that emerge directly from this work and from the interpretive reflections that accompanied it.

- ◦ **Civic intermediaries and democratic outcomes.** This study has treated intermediaries as civic infrastructure; future research could explicitly measure their impact on democratic indicators: voter registration and turnout among youth, participation in local governance, trust in institutions, and cross-group dialogue. Do regions with strong intermediary infrastructure exhibit different civic trajectories than demographically similar regions without it?
- **Social capital, identity, the interpretation of “interests.”** Public discourse often frames political behavior in terms of individuals or communities acting “for” or “against” their

- interests, as if those interests were self-evident or universally defined. Future qualitative research could examine how communities interpret dignity, security, and opportunity through the lenses of race, region, class, religion, and place—and how those interpretations shape perceptions of economic policy, social order, and collective responsibility. Rather than evaluating whether choices align with externally defined interests, such research could ask how interests are narrated, contested, and revised over time—including how solidarities expand or contract across difference. Civic intermediaries offer a productive site for this inquiry, given their role in convening diverse stakeholders and translating policy into lived experience.
- **Care, time poverty, and institutional burden-shifting.** Future research could examine how education-to-employment systems redistribute care, coordination, and emotional labor across families, schools, employers, and intermediaries—particularly under conditions of labor scarcity, childcare constraint, and time poverty. Longitudinal studies could trace which actors absorb system failures when pathways falter, and how those burdens shape participation, trust, and sustainability.
 - **Longitudinal evaluation of intermediaries and Braided Futures projects.** This dissertation offers early-stage evidence and design logic. Future mixed-methods studies could follow regions like RAZ-32, Elkhart WBL Hub, and Whitley County over five to ten years, examining not only student outcomes (earnings, education, health), but institutional resilience: do collaboratives survive leadership transitions? Do they adapt to economic shocks? How do youth who experienced intermediary-supported pathways describe their civic identities as adults?
 - **Scaling social capital without re-privatizing responsibility.** Finally, researchers could explore how to design initiatives that expand social capital without reinforcing the idea that individual mentoring or charity alone can resolve structural inequities. This might involve comparative studies of programs that couple mentoring with direct material supports (income stabilization, housing supports, childcare infrastructure) and with systemic reforms, versus those that rely on relationships alone.

Taken together, these lines of inquiry would deepen understanding of intermediaries not just as technical innovations, but as political and cultural formations that both reflect and reshape American democracy.

7.7 Closing Reflection: Navigating Between Extraction and Collective Responsibility

Recent U.S. political polarization, and the broader dynamics it reflects, can be understood as an intensified extraction mindset: a worldview that treats relationships, institutions, and even truth itself as instruments for securing advantage, rather than as shared projects requiring collective stewardship. From the vantage point of this dissertation, the question is not whether self-preservation is legitimate—it is—but what happens to civic and economic ecosystems when extraction overwhelms collaboration. As Cramer (2016)

documents in *The Politics of Resentment*, many rural and post-industrial communities experience public systems as distant, extractive, or indifferent—fueling political alienation, declining institutional trust, and skepticism toward collective solutions.

Civic intermediaries counteract these dynamics not by replacing the state or the market, but by grounding system-building in local governance, shared returns, and visible accountability. They create civic routines in which people can see that their participation matters—and that responsibility is shared rather than displaced. In this sense, intermediaries offer a practical response to democratic erosion: not a rhetorical appeal to unity, but a set of structures that make cooperation legible, reciprocal, and durable.

The youth whose voices animate this dissertation, alongside the regional collaboratives examined here, point toward a different possibility. They suggest that social capital and civic infrastructure can be mobilized not to hoard advantage, but to redistribute possibility. They show that local control and shared investment need not be in tension, that employers can function as partners in mobility rather than gatekeepers, and that young people can act as co-authors of systems rather than passive recipients of opportunity.

This leads to the dissertation's central proposition: education-to-employment systems should be understood as sites of democratic repair. This is not a sentimental claim. In a hyper-capitalist economy, the institutions where young people learn and work are among the last remaining spaces where individuals regularly cross lines of class, race, belief, and aspiration. If civic capacity is not cultivated in these settings, it is unclear where else that work will reliably occur.

Social capital, in this view, is neither savior nor excuse. It is the everyday practice of people showing up for one another—embedded within structures that make such practice possible without relying on individual heroism. Intermediaries, when designed with care, can ensure that responsibility is shared, visible, and sustained over time.

The work ahead, then, is to continue braiding: youth voice with system design; economic mobility with civic belonging; private capacity with public purpose. The future this dissertation outlines is not guaranteed, but it is plausible—and it warrants the social, political, and intellectual labor required to move it from possibility to practice. In this respect, *Braided Futures* illustrates one pathway through which regions might translate these insights into coherent civic-economic systems, while remaining accountable to the democratic values that animate them.

It is important to state clearly what the High-Quality Intermediary Framework does and does not claim. Like democratic governance itself—and like fair, inclusive economic systems—HQIF does not offer a final or static solution. Building education-to-employment systems that are just, humane, and effective is an ongoing, iterative project requiring continual monitoring, adaptation, and relational repair.

HQIF is therefore best understood as necessary but insufficient. The framework specifies the institutional conditions required for coherence,

accountability, and shared responsibility across sectors, but it cannot substitute for the substantive work those institutions must carry. Its effectiveness depends on what it is paired with: social capital and trust-building across difference; attention to identity, legitimacy, and belonging; instructional redesign toward competency-based and human-centered learning; and employer transformation that treats work as a developmental and civic site rather than a purely extractive one. HQIF is infrastructure—not an endpoint. Its democratic value lies not in producing perfect outcomes, but in enabling communities to pursue fairer, more inclusive economic and civic arrangements over time.

Chapter 8: Coherent Learning Infrastructure: Economic and Civic Stakes, Implications, and the Work Ahead

This dissertation has argued that the United States faces a dual challenge of economic precarity and weakened civic trust—and that these challenges are deeply intertwined. Across Chapters 1–7, the analysis traced an arc from young people’s lived experiences of fragmented opportunity to the design and testing of intermediary infrastructure as a means of operationalizing coherence across education, workforce, and civic systems. Together, these chapters advance a central claim: education-to-employment systems are not merely technical arrangements for allocating labor or credentials. They are civic institutions whose design shapes how opportunity, responsibility, and belonging are distributed. When fragmented, such systems concentrate risk, heighten exposure to instability, and erode institutional trust. When coherently designed, they can support both economic mobility and democratic participation by making opportunity more predictable, legible, and durable.

Read together, the findings synthesized here foreground three interlocking contributions of this dissertation. First, the analysis reframes intermediaries—not as ancillary supports or delivery mechanisms—but as civic-economic institutions whose governance, financing, and relational design shape how opportunity and responsibility are coordinated at the regional level. Second, the study advances a methodological approach that treats young people as co-theorists of system design: their analyses of incoherence, dignity, belonging, and purpose inform institutional critique and applied design decisions rather than serving as illustrative testimony alone. Third, the dissertation introduces the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) as an applied architecture that translates research and practice into replicable strategies for building coherent education-to-employment systems—specifying the governance routines, backbone capacities, and design thresholds required for regional efforts to function as durable public infrastructure rather than episodic initiatives.

These contributions emerged through an extended researcher-practitioner trajectory spanning more than five years and marked by distinct milestones in policy engagement, regional system design, and comparative learning. Early work focused on advancing policy conditions and shared language for cross-sector collaboration; subsequent phases emphasized the design and implementation of coherent learning infrastructure across multiple Indiana regions; and later stages incorporated comparative engagement with

national and international partners, including the Learning Landscapes Challenge, the CEMETS Education Systems Reform Lab, and applied research dialogues with the (Inter)National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree. Taken together, this evolution reflects a sustained inquiry into how intermediary quality is built, tested, and refined under real institutional conditions—rather than a single programmatic intervention or static model.

Throughout this study, fragmentation and coherence emerged as questions of institutional reliability rather than individual motivation or effort. Young people did not describe fragmented systems as merely complex or inefficient; they experienced them as unpredictable, conditional, and unreliable. Opportunity depended less on transparent pathways than on chance encounters, informal networks, or insider knowledge—reinforcing the perception that institutions could not be relied upon to deliver what they promised. These experiences functioned as a hidden curriculum, teaching young people that stability must be self-manufactured and institutional support cannot be assumed.

Coherence, by contrast, emerged as a precondition for trust and recognition. Where intermediary infrastructure aligned schools, employers, and civic institutions through shared governance and predictable routines, young people interpreted systems as more legitimate and navigable. In these contexts, education-to-employment pathways were not simply more efficient; they were more humane—signaling that institutions recognized young people not as interchangeable workers or abstract future citizens, but as whole participants with aspirations, commitments, and the capacity to contribute meaningfully to the life of their communities. Coherent systems created space for young people to be seen in relation to their interests, relationships, and local contexts, and to participate in shaping pathways that reflected the distinct character, needs, and possibilities of the places they inhabit.

While social capital is often proposed as a remedy for fragmentation, the findings of this study suggest that relational resources alone are insufficient without institutional structure. Social capital remains personal and contingent; when left unstructured, it is unevenly distributed and fragile. As demonstrated across earlier chapters, when relationships function as private safety nets rather than public commitments, opportunity defaults to luck rather than design. The regional efforts examined here counter this tendency by embedding relational practice—proximity, shared governance, feedback loops, and youth input—within formal infrastructure. In doing so, they convert social capital from a private asset into a more durable public good. These efforts function as regional civic infrastructure: right-sized for shared governance and collective decision-making—small enough to sustain relationship, accountability, and local knowledge, yet large enough to expand opportunity, distribute risk, and generate systems-level impact. Within these spaces, economic coordination and democratic practice are braided together through everyday operation rather than symbolic participation.

Across cases, intermediaries functioned not as programmatic supports or compliance vehicles, but as institutional actors whose value lay in their

capacity to steward shared responsibility over time. Positioned between policy and practice, intermediaries emerged as one of the few institutional sites where market coordination and democratic governance are negotiated in daily life. Decisions about who participates, who bears risk, and whose futures are worth sustained investment are made concrete through governance routines, funding flows, accountability structures, and role clarity. Importantly, building high-quality intermediary infrastructure is not a one-time technical achievement. Like functioning labor markets and democratic institutions themselves, it requires continual adaptation, relational maintenance, and institutional learning. This finding contributes to emerging scholarship on hybrid professionalism in contemporary governance contexts. As Evetts (2011) argues, roles that operate across institutional boundaries—such as intermediaries charged with facilitation, coordination, and stewardship—exercise authority that is negotiated rather than formally delegated. Their legitimacy rests not on credentialed expertise alone, but on relational trust, procedural integrity, and demonstrated capacity to hold collective decision-making over time. Yet such facilitative professionalism remains under-theorized and under-resourced in education and workforce systems, despite its centrality to sustaining shared governance. This dissertation positions facilitation not as neutral process work, but as skilled institutional labor that materially shapes whether collaborative arrangements generate coherence, legitimacy, and durable public value.

A related implication concerns the selection of the backbone organization itself. Beyond the facilitation skill of individual leaders, the organizational form and institutional location of the backbone can materially shape a collaborative's ability to mature across High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) domains. This distinction suggests that facilitative leadership must be understood as both an individual professional capacity and an institutionalized function, requiring ongoing development, peer learning, and evaluation rather than reliance on charismatic or heroic actors. Backbones positioned closer to the education end of the education-to-employment continuum (e.g., education service centers, districts, higher education institutions, education nonprofits) may bring deep instructional legitimacy, access to student-level routines, and clearer authority within schooling systems, while sometimes facing constraints in employer responsiveness or cross-sector neutrality. Backbones positioned closer to the employment end (e.g., workforce boards, chambers of commerce, employer-led entities) may bring labor-market credibility, demand coordination capacity, and a clearer employer value proposition, while sometimes requiring additional infrastructure to embed youth development, instructional quality, and equitable access as non-negotiables. A second axis concerns institutional durability and authorization. Legislatively mandated or publicly funded entities may offer continuity, legitimacy, and stable financing, while newer or more flexible nonprofit structures may offer adaptability, innovation speed, and fewer bureaucratic constraints but remain more vulnerable to funding volatility and leadership turnover. Future policy and practice should therefore treat backbone selection as a governance and infrastructure decision—not merely an administrative one—clarifying decision rights, accountability expectations, and the conditions under which different backbone types can function as credible stewards of

shared purpose. In practical terms, HQIF-aligned evaluation and improvement efforts should include explicit attention to backbone fit, incentives, and constraints, since these institutional features often determine whether shared governance, braided finance, employer engagement, youth voice, and continuous improvement can be sustained at scale.

An important implication of this dissertation concerns how young people move from co-theorists of system design toward developmentally appropriate forms of civic and economic participation, including peer leadership, institutional feedback roles, and early advocacy. This transition does not presume that youth carry primary responsibility for reform. Rather, it underscores the obligation of adult leaders and institutions to listen, translate, and act—creating structures that convert youth insight into improved policy, practice, and system performance. Youth participation in this study was experienced not merely as expression, but as consequential input into governance and design processes. Civic engagement was not treated as a distant future obligation, but as a practical extension of economic participation and institutional navigation, scaffolded by adults and embedded within intermediary infrastructure.

This reframing helps resolve the tension youth themselves articulated between economic security and civic voice. For young people navigating precarity, civic participation can appear secondary relative to immediate economic needs. The evidence presented here suggests that this tension is not resolved by prioritizing one domain over the other, but by designing systems that braid them together. When young people engage in work-based learning, pathway navigation, and policy sense-making simultaneously, economic participation becomes a site of civic learning rather than a substitute for it. Intermediaries play a critical role in this translation by connecting lived experience to institutional decision-making, while maintaining clear adult responsibility for outcomes, accountability, and continuous improvement.

The applied contribution of this work lies in the High-Quality Intermediary Framework and its associated design tools. HQIF operationalizes coherence by specifying what must be structurally true—governance authority, backbone capacity, relational legitimacy, and policy alignment—for education-to-employment systems to function reliably over time. These tools do not replace political judgment or eliminate conflict; rather, they reduce reliance on individual heroism by embedding coordination, accountability, and learning within institutional design. HQIF offers regions a way to professionalize intermediary work, clarify decision rights, and steward shared responsibility across sectors while remaining adaptable to local context. High-quality intermediaries thus function not only as sites of coordination, but as translation infrastructure—connecting lived experience to governance, regional practice to state policy, and economic participation to democratic renewal.

A central implication of this work is the need for continued institutional experimentation and learning around how civic-economic infrastructure is designed, assessed, and improved over time. The High-Quality Intermediary

Framework is not intended as a static rubric or certification tool, but as a developmental architecture that can guide planning, professional learning, and continuous improvement across regions. Future research and practice should test and refine the evaluative structures introduced here, particularly HQIF-aligned scorecards derived from Table 5.1. Such tools can be used to examine how intermediary design choices shape pathway quality, institutional reliability, youth access and navigation, employer value, and perceptions of legitimacy and trust. Used formatively rather than punitively, these tools surface governance, relational, operational, and sensemaking dimensions of system performance that are often invisible in traditional outcome metrics. Iterative use across contexts can support comparative learning, strengthen facilitative practice, and help regions diagnose where coherence is breaking down—and where targeted investment in governance authority, backbone capacity, or relational infrastructure may yield the greatest gains in equity, dignity, and effectiveness.

A complementary pathway for future research and practice involves strengthening youth-facing evaluative tools that examine how intermediary infrastructure is experienced by young people navigating regional education-to-employment systems. The Healing-Centered Civic Participation survey instrument included in Appendix was developed and piloted with statewide youth policy fellows to assess perceptions of belonging, wellbeing, voice, and agency within civic and pathway contexts. While this instrument centers relational safety and developmental experience, future iterations should more intentionally incorporate the core tenets of Critical Policy Analysis. CPA-informed revisions would invite youth to surface how power, ideology, and institutional design shape their access to opportunity—asking not only whether systems feel supportive, but whose interests are advanced, whose voices carry authority, how race, class, and geography structure participation, and where lived experience affirms, complicates, or contests official policy narratives. Strengthening the HCE survey in this way would preserve its healing-centered orientation while ensuring that youth feedback functions as policy-relevant system intelligence rather than decontextualized sentiment. Used alongside HQIF-aligned evaluative tools, such instruments can help regions assess not only whether intermediary structures exist, but whether they are operating in ways that redistribute responsibility, reduce fragmentation, and advance coherence, dignity, and institutional trust for those furthest from opportunity.

This dissertation does not claim to resolve structural inequality, eliminate economic precarity, or adjudicate the full consequences of racial or class-based hierarchy. Its contribution is more modest and pragmatic: specifying how intermediary architecture can reduce fragmentation, increase institutional reliability, and expand access to meaningful participation in both economic and civic systems. HQIF is therefore necessary but insufficient—an enabling infrastructure rather than a comprehensive solution. By operating at the regional level, however, intermediary-led systems design leverages proximity, collective efficacy, and shared stewardship as catalysts for improvement in ways that are politically feasible, relationally grounded, and institutionally durable.

The economic and civic stakes of coherence become clearest when viewed against the broader political-economic context in which young people are coming of age. In hyper-capitalized labor markets, fragmented pathways generate not only inefficiency but civic harm by concentrating risk among those with the fewest institutional buffers. Young people in this study consistently identified stability, recognition, contribution, connection, and future orientation as prerequisites for flourishing. Fragmented systems undermine all five simultaneously. Coherent systems, by contrast, make hope rational by embedding opportunity within predictable institutional pathways.

Work occupies a central place in this civic-economic braid. In this study, work is not framed solely as economic preparation, but as a form of civic practice. To work is to contribute to collective life; to learn to work is to rehearse interdependence, responsibility, and shared purpose. When students described feeling “seen,” “trusted,” or “needed” in work-based learning settings, they were narrating early civic experiences as much as workforce ones. The distinction they drew between “any job” and “good work” reflected an intuitive understanding that dignity, voice, and trajectory matter alongside wages. Intermediaries safeguard this civic potential by designing work-based learning that fosters contribution, identity development, and cross-difference relationship-building. Yet civic formation cannot rest on interpersonal goodwill alone. In societies marked by racial, economic, and geographic segregation, proximity does not occur by accident. Social capital cannot substitute for wages, housing, childcare, or coherent governance. The contribution of coherent learning infrastructure is that it holds these imperatives together—converting isolated acts of mentorship into durable civic architecture.

Every region makes implicit decisions about how opportunity, risk, and long-term investment are distributed across individuals and communities. These decisions are embedded in institutional design choices: whether work-based learning is paid, whether employers are positioned as stewards of youth development, whether backbone capacity is funded beyond short-term grants, and whether communities furthest from opportunity are prioritized in access and investment. Intermediaries are not panaceas. They cannot, on their own, resolve structural inequality or reverse market pressures oriented toward short-term returns. They can, however, shift how opportunity is organized—moving from episodic access and individualized charity toward shared systems of public responsibility.

In periods of national volatility and institutional distrust, regionalism can function as a strategy for forward motion rather than retreat. Regional intermediary infrastructure does not absolve state or federal government of responsibility; rather, it creates conditions under which public action becomes more grounded, responsive, and effective. By anchoring economic participation and civic practice in shared local systems, regions can cultivate collective capacity while remaining connected to a broader public purpose. In this sense, high-quality intermediaries help bridge individual agency and governmental responsibility—affirming that people and institutions alike play indispensable roles in cultivating economic vitality, civic capacity, and shared futures.

The work ahead therefore requires institutional rigor and strategic clarity. Durable intermediaries require authorized governance, professionalized backbone staffing, protected relational labor, and shared sense-making routines. States can support this work by separating infrastructure funding from short-term performance metrics, enabling regional flexibility, and legitimizing intermediary roles that coordinate across education, workforce, and civic systems. Such supports are most effective when coupled with structured feedback loops that allow regional intermediaries to inform state and federal policy design—ensuring that implementation realities, governance constraints, and equity impacts shape ongoing refinement of public initiatives rather than flowing only top-down. Regions, in turn, must select backbones with cross-sector credibility, embed youth participation appropriately, and design pathways that align employer strategy with student dignity and long-term community vitality.

A persistent tension in this work concerns the appropriate balance between regional self-determination and state-level influence. While coherent learning infrastructure requires shared standards of quality, legitimacy, and accountability, it cannot be imposed through uniform organizational forms or prescriptive implementation. The findings of this study suggest that states are most effective when they govern for coherence rather than conformity—establishing clear expectations for governance, equity, and institutional reliability while allowing regions discretion in how intermediary structures are designed, sequenced, and lived in practice. Such an approach aligns with implementation science insights that emphasize adaptation over replication, and with democratic values that locate legitimacy in local participation rather than compliance alone.

The implications of this work extend beyond individual regions and point toward a scalable approach to coherent learning infrastructure at the state level. Existing investments in Indiana—including pathway initiatives, employer-led talent strategies, and regional accelerator efforts—provide a foundation for aligning intermediary practice with HQIF principles. A critical area of future work lies in policy—both legislative and administrative—that catalyzes, supports, improves, and sustains high-quality intermediary infrastructure. States serious about advancing both civic and economic aims must attend not only to program incentives, but to the governance, authorization, and operating conditions that allow intermediaries to function as durable public institutions.

This dissertation opens a research and practice agenda that exceeds its empirical scope. Future inquiry may examine intermediary design across the life cycle, the facilitation capacities required to sustain collective efficacy, and the conditions under which regional systems can steward interrelated improvements in education, workforce participation, and civic trust over time. Across these domains, the central challenge remains one of institutional stewardship: how opportunity, legitimacy, and responsibility are distributed in ways that strengthen both economic participation and democratic life.

One applied pathway for extending this inquiry involves structured experimentation with employer-led coordination models embedded within

regional intermediary governance. Ongoing applied research collaborations with initiatives such as the U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation's Employer Provided Innovation Challenges (EPIC) offer a site for examining whether employer-sponsored, project-based learning can be integrated into coherent regional systems without reproducing the fragmentation critiqued in Chapter 5. Early engagements across multiple Indiana regions foreground recurring governance questions: how employers are coordinated without duplicative outreach, how quality and equity are maintained across uneven capacity, how youth feedback informs pathway refinement, and how shared responsibility is stewarded over time rather than delegated through one-off transactions. These questions warrant systematic study as states expand work-based learning expectations faster than regional coordination capacity.

The analysis in this dissertation is informed by direct engagement with these initiatives at the state and regional level, including participation in the Talent Pipeline Management Academy of Indiana and applied implementation of EPIC as an employer-education coordination mechanism within emerging intermediary structures. This embedded perspective reinforces the dissertation's central finding: employer-facing frameworks are most effective when nested within authorized intermediary governance that aggregates demand, protects equity, and reduces coordination burden for districts, employers, and learners alike.

Education-to-employment systems remain among the few public arenas where people routinely cross lines of race, class, ideology, and geography. Their redesign is therefore not merely economic; it is civic. The evidence presented here suggests that coherent systems reduce reliance on individual heroism, distribute opportunity more equitably, protect the dignity of work, and strengthen regional capacity for collective problem-solving. In a fragmented nation, they represent one feasible path toward rebuilding civic infrastructure from the ground up.

Coherence, like economic security and democratic participation, is not a static achievement but an ongoing collective practice. It requires vigilance, adaptation, and sustained attention to institutional design over time. The High-Quality Intermediary Framework offers one pragmatic approach to this work—not as a fixed model, but as a living architecture refined through practice, policy, and peer learning. When supported by aligned governance, professionalized backbone capacity, and durable public investment, high-quality intermediaries can help regions steward shared responsibility across education, work, and civic life. Over time, such infrastructure can strengthen local opportunity, reinforce institutional trust, and contribute to broader economic vitality and democratic renewal. What ultimately matters is not the perfection of any single model, but the sustained stewardship of the intermediary conditions through which shared responsibility—and shared futures rooted in civic and economic wellbeing—are built, in partnership with young people and with one another.

APPENDIX

Author-Cited Unpublished Research and Analytic Texts

The following unpublished texts authored by the researcher are cited within the dissertation and included here to support transparency and reader access. These materials provide analytic, conceptual, and methodological context for the study and inform the development of its research design and interpretive framework. They are included for reference purposes only and do not constitute independent empirical evidence beyond their use in the dissertation.

- ◦ Hall, L. M. (2016). Are we inclusive? Racial identities and social capital in spoken word associations (Master's thesis). Indiana University Bloomington, School of Public and Environmental Affairs. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1gZngVfYVavMHJfql0WLCrJkjFc5z9en2/view?usp=sharing>
- Hall, L. M. (2021). Youth apprenticeship research study: Coalescing and analyzing youth and program leaders' perspectives on youth apprenticeship implementation (Unpublished research report; IRB #12795). Indiana University Indianapolis. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1N7oMJ29x3-g0S6Y8sVRYL4aRwhg8L4Dq/view?usp=sharing>
- Hall, L. M. (2021). Adapting the National Youth Apprenticeship Act of 2021 to be more healing-centered: The history and context of the National Youth Apprenticeship Act of 2021 (Unpublished doctoral course paper). Indiana University Indianapolis. Analytic policy paper examining the National Youth Apprenticeship Act through a healing-centered engagement framework; informs the dissertation's critique of workforce policy alignment with democratic participation, youth wellbeing, and civic development. <https://docs.google.com/document/d/1jq8JM11tSe7UVP6c8ShXh5NpMAVARa7C/edit?usp=sharing&ouid=109202038551319500594&rtpof=true&sd=true>
- Hall, L. M. (2022). Qualifying examination responses (Unpublished doctoral qualifying papers). Indiana University Indianapolis, Ph.D. Program in American Studies (minor in Sociology). <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1y1cylX1G6gq214vIRlx7zRg2m8jaFFS/view?usp=sharing>

Youth Voice, Co-Theorizing, and Youth-Led Advocacy Materials

The following materials document instances in which young people contributed as co-theorists, co-analysts, and public advocates within the intermediary and civic-economic systems examined in this dissertation. These artifacts reflect youth-led analysis, policy engagement, and public storytelling that informed the study's understanding of legitimacy, belonging, and shared power in education-to-employment systems. They are included to support transparency and contextual understanding and do not constitute independent empirical findings beyond their use in the dissertation.

- ◦ Youth-Authored Policy Proposal: Youth-Led Evaluation and Solutions to Mental Health Care in Indiana Education Systems. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1kw8N9iJa19t15JiQUGce5MABYGT-soy/view?usp=sharing>

- Youth-authored policy analysis and recommendations addressing mental health supports within Indiana education systems.
- Healing-Centered Civic Participation Survey Instrument. Survey instrument used to examine youth civic participation, wellbeing, and perceptions of voice and agency. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1IozmxC8doWiSnjf7QTerGFTOAj6bqPDF/view?usp=sharing>
- New America Youth Voice and Policy Engagement Artifacts. Public-facing youth-authored and youth-centered policy pieces developed in partnership with New America, including articles and event materials related to youth-led policy dialogue and advocacy.
 - <https://www.newamerica.org/indianapolis/blog/youth-charge-one-young-hoosiers-journey-become-advocate/>
 - <https://www.newamerica.org/indianapolis/blog/rethink-sex-ed-to-curb-violence/>
 - <https://www.newamerica.org/indianapolis/events/online-inside-out-youth-led-policy-in-the-heartland2/>
 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Rj-myOYBENY>
- Yeung, C. (2024). National Youth Poet Laureate regional finalist materials. Urban Word NYC. Youth-authored creative and advocacy materials submitted as part of the National Youth Poet Laureate regional finalist process. https://drive.google.com/file/d/1XMclLAG_TH-bx6ILKX1FTgk4INqHxOPt/view?usp=sharing
- Gaines, A. (2022). National Youth Poet Laureate application materials. Urban Word NYC. Youth-authored creative, civic, and advocacy materials submitted as part of the National Youth Poet Laureate selection process; Gaines was the inaugural Indiana Youth Poet Laureate to earn the national title in 2022. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1LzhVapI1oPjMCg4YcJrfGjS0hOdwNo9Q/view?usp=sharing>

State-Level Governance and Public Validation Materials

The following materials document instances in which the regional intermediary work examined in this dissertation entered formal state-level governance discourse. They are included to support transparency and contextual understanding of how regional practice was translated for public, policy-facing audiences. These artifacts function as implementation and public validation evidence rather than as independent evaluative or empirical findings. Specifically, the materials reflect an invited, practitioner-led presentation by regional leaders representing Rural Alliance Zone 32 (RAZ-32) to the Indiana State Board of Education. The presentation illustrated how formalized intermediary governance, employer coordination, and shared multi-district commitments can operationalize Indiana's redesigned high school diploma and expanded work-based learning priorities. Together, the artifacts document how RAZ-32 was positioned as a developing proof point for regional, employer-anchored pathway infrastructure within the state's evolving policy framework.

- ◦ Indiana State Board of Education. (2025, March 6). Board meeting materials: March 6, 2025. <https://www.in.gov/sboe/board-meetings-and-materials/march-6-2025/>

- Indiana State Board of Education. (2025, March 6). Indiana State Board of Education meeting [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/live/4EgSk9d2h-w>
- Indiana State Board of Education. (2025, March 6). Regional pathway infrastructure presentation [PowerPoint slides]. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/11uWFLGUL1J7-BtLXTJ153UOIOj5U-6CN/view>

Multi-Sector Collaborative (MSC) Indiana Policy Development Materials

The following materials document a coordinated, practitioner- and policy-informed effort to advance Multi-Sector Collaboratives (MSCs) as a formalized strategy within Indiana's education-to-employment and workforce policy landscape. Developed in collaboration with state partners, funders, and regional leaders, these artifacts reflect analytic groundwork, coalition building, and legislative exploration related to the design, funding, and scaling of MSCs—particularly in small and rural school districts, referred to throughout this policy work as “Heartland districts.”

These materials are included to support transparency and to illustrate how the intermediary concepts examined in this dissertation were translated into policy-facing analyses, draft legislation, stakeholder engagement tools, and implementation planning. They function as documentation of policy development activity and field-building efforts rather than as independent empirical or evaluative evidence. The complete set of materials is provided as a consolidated digital archive for reference and access: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1qX3I4L53eqOVDFSyn_6g-EljZaIX7q5U/view?usp=sharing

- - IN Multi-Sector Collaboratives in Indiana Funding Analysis (Unpublished analytic memorandum). Analysis of existing and potential state-level funding mechanisms relevant to the development and sustainability of Multi-Sector Collaboratives in Indiana.
 - Indiana Multi-Sector Collaborative Policy: Draft Bill (December 10, 2024) (Unpublished legislative draft). Working draft legislation outlining a potential statutory framework for recognizing and supporting Multi-Sector Collaboratives within Indiana's education and workforce systems.
 - IN Student Metric Analysis (Unpublished analytic brief). Analysis identifying student-level indicators and outcome measures relevant to evaluating the impact of coordinated, regional pathway infrastructure.
 - Policy Memo: Multi-Sector Collaboratives in Indiana (Unpublished policy memorandum). Memo articulating the rationale, design principles, and policy case for MSCs as a strategy to address workforce shortages, educational fragmentation, and regional inequities.
 - Multi-Sector Collaboratives for Heartland Districts (Unpublished white paper). Concept paper focused on the application of MSC models in

- Indiana's Heartland districts, emphasizing rural context, small-district collaboration, and shared regional capacity.
- Our Champions and Target School Districts (Unpublished planning dataset).
Internal working document identifying supportive policy champions, regional leaders, and priority districts for MSC engagement and potential early adoption.
- Multi-Sector Collaboratives: Champions and Key Collaborators Kick-Off Call (Unpublished presentation slides). Slides used to convene and align early champions and cross-sector collaborators around shared goals, roles, and next steps for advancing MSC policy and practice in Indiana.

Learning Landscapes Materials: Toward a Cohesive Learning Infrastructure

The following artifacts document key elements of the Learning Landscapes initiative as referenced in this dissertation. These materials include implementation planning, design tools, and conceptual resources used to support shared understanding of system goals and leverage points. They are included for transparency and reader access and provide contextual reference for how Learning Landscapes design and logic modeling were applied in practice. They do not constitute independent empirical evidence beyond their use in the dissertation.

- ◦ Learning Landscapes Phase 3 Application (Canva). Phase 3 application document, including contextual narrative and planning details; the Logic Model is included on page 16 of this application. https://www.canva.com/design/DAGo09HdbTs/yvF4oDdSCIdMMV1YZJpcfQ/view?utm_content=DAGo09HdbTs&utm_campaign=designshare&utm_medium=link
- Learning Landscapes Materials (Unpublished planning packet). Supplementary Learning Landscapes planning and design materials archived for reference. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1filagoDGLi0RPiVh75fEh62MH8vND2Rz/view?usp=sharing>

Practitioner-Scholar Implementation & International Engagement Materials

The following materials document the author's practitioner-scholar work translating intermediary theory into operational governance, pathway design, and cross-sector infrastructure. These artifacts reflect applied contributions to the development of high-quality intermediary capacity (HQIF), including regional implementation, state-level scaling strategies, and international learning exchange. They are included as implementation and design evidence referenced in this dissertation rather than as independent empirical or evaluative findings.

- ◦ Nursing Pathway Design (LPN Focus). Planning document developed with support from the CEMETS Education Systems Reform Lab outlining a licensed practical nurse (LPN) pathway model referenced in this dissertation for its potential replication

- across Indiana and comparable contexts. https://drive.google.com/file/d/1Evd1e2GLT72A3_KNWGDxDpjrxrtQsH0J/view?usp=sharing
- Elkhart County Work-Based Learning (WBL) Hub Contract. Executed agreement establishing shared operational guardrails, partner roles, and governance expectations for a county-wide work-based learning intermediary. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1HFIDdOqccEtWVKv53jMRz672HXCHA5Fn/view?usp=sharing>
 - LAUNCH Phase 2 Application Materials. Submitted application materials documenting intermediary strategy, governance structure, and scaling approach for Indiana's LAUNCH Phase 2 initiative. https://drive.google.com/file/d/1rup68IMmA4UjLnuPUA2sr44WszOC_D_/view?usp=sharing
 - CEMETS / NCAD Teach-In Materials. Slide deck used for a joint CEMETS–National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree (NCAD) teach-in, along with the associated funding proposal and progress update documenting how resources were used to support international learning exchange and intermediary capacity-building. Slides: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1M3EM0YXYMN3CnpESWo0288_aLDwksu7/view?usp=sharing
 - Youth Apprenticeship Innovation Fund funding proposal: <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1PfToRVxywXmv8TPqXVNI8WIAtmiba6Ur/view?usp=sharing> and progress update: <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1hMDneIDz6YnIm4IXQAhsPWCnLEqzob1Y/view?usp=sharing>
 - National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree (NCAD) Champion Strand Bios. Biographical materials documenting participation in the NCAD Champion Strand, situating the author's engagement within a national apprenticeship-degree learning network. https://drive.google.com/file/d/1CyLsky49DpPqc03cVIY_3bEcaacjOLVZ/view?usp=sharing

National Convenings, Public Media, and Field Dialogue

The following materials document instances in which the intermediary concepts, pathway designs, and governance approaches examined in this dissertation were shared and discussed through national convenings and public-facing field dialogue. These engagements reflect the socialization of emerging ideas during the development of the High-Quality Intermediary Framework (HQIF) and its articulation of civic-economic value for youth, employers, regions, and states. They are included to support transparency and contextual understanding and do not constitute independent empirical or evaluative findings.

- ◦ National Youth Apprenticeship Summit 2025 (New America). Panel contribution addressing youth apprenticeship systems, employer engagement, and intermediary coordination. <https://www.newamerica.org/education-policy/events/national-youth-apprenticeship-summit-2025/> (supplementary artifact: practitioner reflection) https://www.linkedin.com/posts/laurenmariehall1_national-youth-apprenticeship-summit-2025-activity-7404610871903154177-hUGu

- Podcast Interview – Lauren Hall Riggins (Rural Innovation Series, SWPR Group). Public discussion of intermediary design, rural workforce pathways, and RAZ-32 as regional infrastructure. <https://www.swpr-group.com/podcast/rural-innovation-series-lauren-marie-hall-riggins-senior-manager-empower-schools>
- Podcast Interview – Aaron Black, Superintendent (Rural Innovation Series, SWPR Group). Discussion of superintendent leadership and regional collaboration in employer-anchored pathway development. <https://www.swpr-group.com/podcast/rural-innovation-series-aaron-black-superintendent-randolph-eastern-school-corporation>
- Podcast Appearance – Lauren Hall Riggins (Spotify). Conversation on workforce pathways, intermediary governance, and rural systems design. <https://open.spotify.com/episode/6pnhqsXMZ6UJqhQ9BglWi>

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Curriculum Vitae

Lauren Marie Hall

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Education

- - Indiana University Indianapolis, Ph.D. in American Studies, with a Minor Sociology with focus on civic, economic, and education systems
 - Indiana University Bloomington, School of Public & Environmental Affairs Master of Public Affairs & Master of Arts in Arts Administration
 - Marian University, Master of Arts in Teaching
 - Marist College, Bachelor of Arts in Psychology, Bachelor of Arts in English

Professional Summary

Over the past decade, Lauren Hall Riggins has worked at the intersection of education, workforce development, youth civic leadership, and public policy to design and study regional education-to-employment infrastructure grounded in institutional reliability, shared governance, and youth co-creation. As Founder and Principal of Braided Futures LLC (2025-present) and previously as Director of State Strategy & National Career Pathways at Empower Schools (2022-2025), she has provided technical assistance to state agencies, colleges, and regional collaboratives on intermediary infrastructure, braided funding, governance and accountability routines, and data-informed continuous improvement—mobilizing more than \$17 million in public and philanthropic investment and facilitating coalitions of 35+ partner organizations across urban and rural contexts. Her practitioner-scholar work includes co-developing Indiana's LPN-by-high-school-graduation youth apprenticeship model and an employer-funded RN pathway with Ivy Tech Community College and Reid Health; authoring policy and funding language supporting intermediary implementation; and leading statewide activation of employer-aligned strategies including LAUNCH, Talent Pipeline Management (TPM), and Employer Provided Innovation Challenges (EPIC).

Complementing this systems-level work, she has served since 2017 as a leader, board member, and consultant with VOICES, a civic learning and youth leadership organization, including as Director of the Indiana Youth Poet Laureate program. Through this role, she has designed and stewarded healing-centered, culturally responsive pedagogies that position young people as civic actors, policy contributors, and cultural leaders—experience that directly informs this dissertation's methodological approach to youth as co-theorists of institutional design rather than passive beneficiaries of reform. Earlier roles at New America Local (Fellow/Scholar-in-Residence, 2020-2021), pilotED (Director of Learning & Identity Development, 2020-2022), and Teach For America Indianapolis (Manager, Corporate/Foundation/Government Relations, 2017-2020) further strengthened her foundation in community-engaged policy research, adult learning and leadership development, and resource mobilization in service of durable public infrastructure.

Selected Honors, Fellowships, and National Field Engagement

- - Learning Landscapes Challenge Phase 3 Finalist (Walton Family Foundation & Siegel Family Endowment), with submission positioned as a national blueprint for cohesive learning infrastructure.
 - New America Local Fellow / Scholar-in-Residence; co-host, INSide Out: Youth-Led Policy in the Heartland (youth-led policy dialogue and applied research tools).
 - NCAD Champion (National Center for the Apprenticeship Degree); national learning network advancing degree-bearing apprenticeships.
 - Panelist, New America National Youth Apprenticeship Summit (Dec 2025).
 - CEMETS Education Systems Reform Lab (ETH Zürich) — recruited, funded, and co-led a 13-member U.S. delegation focused on comparative apprenticeship and workforce governance to inform U.S. policy and implementation.
 - Invited Presenter, Indiana State Board of Education — regional pathway infrastructure / RAZ-32 model; and convener of Vision in Action convening (150+ leaders) with Dr. Katie Jenner as keynote.

Selected Research, Policy, and Public Scholarship

- - Doctoral Dissertation, Indiana University: The Civic and Economic Stakes of Work: Intermediary Infrastructure, Youth Voice, and Collective Efficacy in Education-to-Employment Systems.
 - Peer-reviewed publication: Davis, C. L., & Hall Riggins, L. M. (2020). Spoken word performance as activism: Middle school poets challenge American racism. *Middle School Journal*, 51(2), 6-15.
 - Selected policy and practice scholarship (various): Author and co-author of policy briefs, technical assistance playbooks, and implementation guides advancing high-quality intermediary infrastructure, youth apprenticeship systems, and workforce-aligned education reform, including LAUNCH-, Talent Pipeline Management (TPM)-, and Employer Provided Innovation Challenges (EPIC)-aligned field implementation supports.